

California

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FALL
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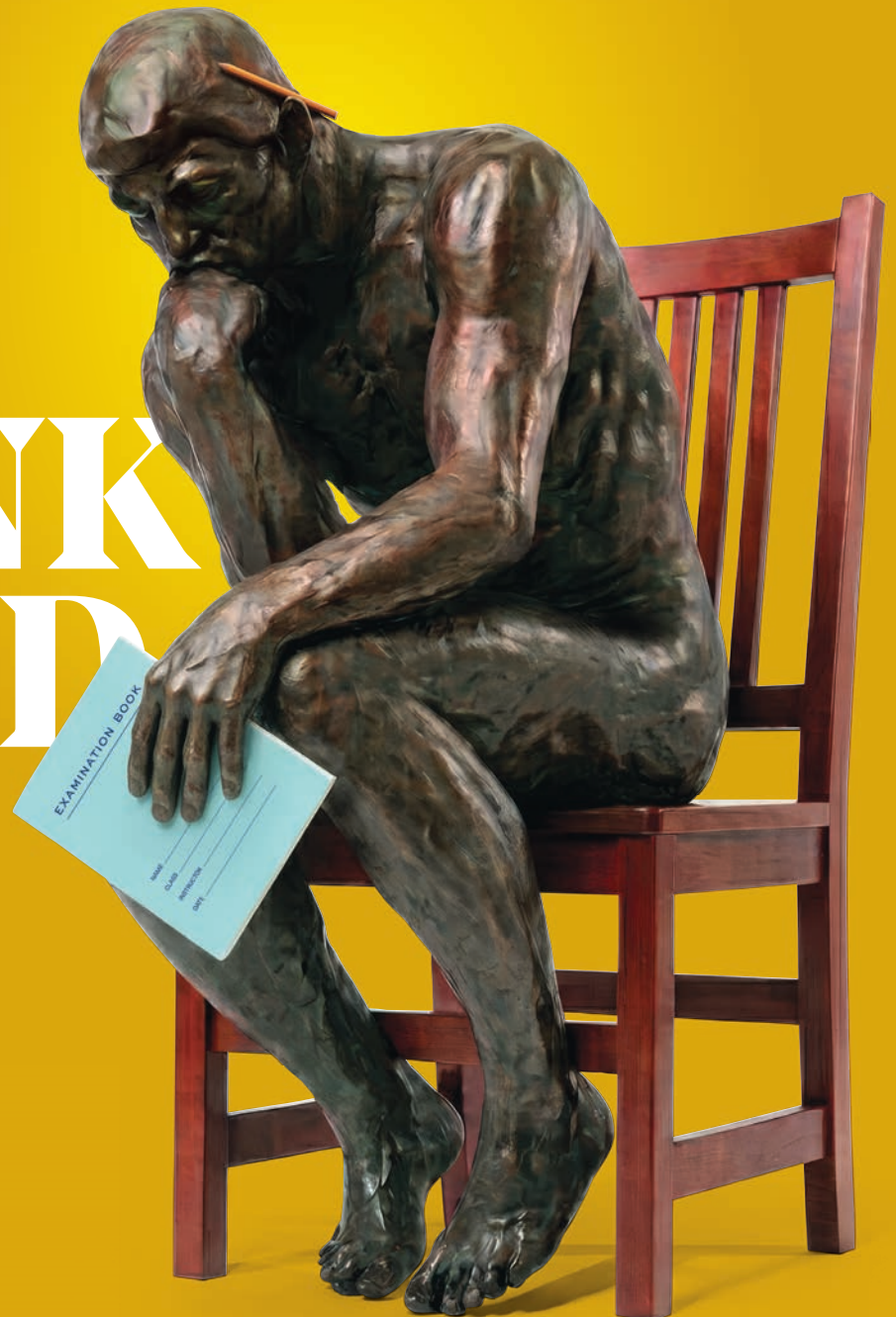
+ AN EMAIL'S
ODYSSEY

BREEDING
GROUND
FOR BIOTECH

THE PUSH
TO RESTORE
THE SAT

THINK HARD

CAN
ARTIFICIAL
INTELLIGENCE
SUPPORT
REAL
LEARNING?





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9.25

10.10

10.17

11.21

11.28

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WAKE FOREST

STANFORD

PITT

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ROTH

ROOTED IN
THE BAY

FIAT
LUX

HOME
COMING

GRATEFUL
BEARS

129TH
BIG GAME

HOMETOWN
HEROES



Connections: In 1864, the Indo-European telegraph cable (top) connecting England and India comes ashore at Al-Faw in what is now Iraq. Just over 150 years later, in 2016, a submarine fiber optic cable (bottom) linking Southeast Asia and Western Europe comes ashore at La Seyne-sur-Mer in the south of France.

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Online Exclusive

For decades, a familiar Berkeley
pizza parlor has housed a truly under-
ground theater. The Sub, said one
denizen, has always been "a space
that's built for risk." Read "The Sub-
terranean Scene."



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The Edge Podcast: Normalizing Inequality with G. Cristina Mora and Tianna S. Paschel

It's hardly news that California's
income gap is among the widest in
the country. But how do Californians
make sense of that inequality? Berke-
ley sociologists G. Cristina Mora
and Tianna S. Paschel investigated
how the middle class in Los Angeles
County and the Central Valley—those
who "feel the promise and precarity
of California most acutely"—rational-
ize the poverty they see all around
them. For the latest episode of *The
Edge, California's* podcast, we sat
down with professors Mora and
Paschel to talk about their new book,
Normalizing Inequality.



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in the world”—in one
unmissable recital.



William Kentridge's *The
Head & the Load* (Nov
12-15), declared by *The
New York Times* as a
“fiercely beautiful histor-
ical pageant.”



**The Complete Philip
Glass Piano Etudes** (Nov
20)—a marathon tribute
to Glass' 90th birthday.



The innovative jazz
pianist **Jason Moran**
and the **Harlem Hell-
fighters** (Nov 21) in a
multimedia meditation
on James Reese Europe.



**Ambrose Akinmusire &
Aszure Barton's A | a
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dance work driven by
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Queen of Pain

I thoroughly enjoyed Chris Ballard's story about the remarkable Catherine Breed [p. 26]. It was a compelling and inspiring piece that stayed with me long after I finished reading it.

I also want to commend photographer Lauren Segal. Her powerful photographs beautifully complemented the story, capturing both the strength and humanity of its subject. The writing and photography worked together seamlessly to create an unforgettable feature.

Nancy Rubin '67

Someone Had to Go First

I wanted to applaud you on your fascinating interview with Berkeley Law Professor Claudia Polsky [p. 34] that describes the case she launched against the administration's summary

termination of federal research grants and looks critically at the UC system's lack of action.

As a working journalist, I believe strongly in the importance of reporting "without fear or favor" in service of the public's right to know what's happening in their world.

In this case, the world is the University of California, and your magazine is an organ of the Cal Alumni Association that, understandably, wants to make our alma mater look good. So the editorial independence you showed with this story is all the more impressive. And I believe it's the kind of reporting that readers value—frank and not sanitized.

*Tyche Hendricks,
M.A./M.J. '97*

I applaud *California* magazine for publishing "Someone Had to Go First." It's a gutsy piece that addresses the enormous federal funding threats hanging over the

University, celebrates heroes on campus stepping up to defend the University, and raises important questions about the effectiveness of current UCOP-level leadership. The piece highlights the value of *California* being an editorially independent magazine because it enables it to publish not only feel-good stories, but also articles on thorny issues important to alumni when the University itself falls short.

Joshua Price '18

What Goes Up

I always look forward to *California* magazine, which I find to be the most interesting and well written of the three alumni magazines I receive, the other two being from Ivy League schools! In regard to the built environment on campus [p. 39], there is one building that instantly comes to my mind as being the most horrible, ugly, and unfriendly edifice imaginable! Wurster Hall. I vote for it to be torn down as soon as possible!

Ellen Hahn

I met my wife in the basement of Evans Hall. She majored in computer science and I majored in electrical engineering. We practically lived in the computer room. Friends ask us how we met.

"We practically lived in the computer room. Friends ask us how we met. We tell them, 'computer dating.'"

We tell them, "computer dating." Without Evans, we likely wouldn't have our happy 50 years of marriage.

Al Kovalick, M.S. '73

In my time at Cal, there was an unescorted basset hound that, every Thursday at about 3:55 p.m., would take the Evans Hall elevator to a certain floor. Whichever department his human belonged to held a coffee hour at 4 p.m. that day, and the dog, no intellectual slouch, had learned that the discussions were a reliable source of salami and cheese.

I never knew this remarkable canine's name, but surely there must be alumni who do. Instead of naming whatever replaces Evans after a wealthy donor or public figure who later may come to disgrace, why not name it after the salami-seeking hound?

Amelia S. Marshall '80

Props

I just wanted to convey how much I loved the Summer issue, which left me more enthused than ever about being a Cal alum. It evoked the sense I had at school of being surrounded by brilliant people doing amazing things that changed my perspective for the better.

Kathy Astromoff '91

You deserve more than applause for the present state of the publication, especially the well-formulated articulation of *California*'s mission! It is a perfect representation of what the purpose of the magazine should be.

Susan A. Herney '64

I have always treasured the magazine, but this one was THE BEST. Thanks for your efforts.

Norine Moses '62

Corrections

The Summer issue was excellent, especially the story about taking Trump to court. However, the courthouse photo on page 37 is not the Court of Appeals for the Ninth Circuit. It's the U.S. District Court for the Northern District of California.

Mark Mackler, MLS '86

Good article—you just got the courthouse wrong.

Helen Mickiewicz '75

The text on p. 56 refers to "Pinecrest Dam." Google Maps shows that the dam is called Strawberry Dam.

*Richard L. Wiltshire '72,
M.Eng. '73*



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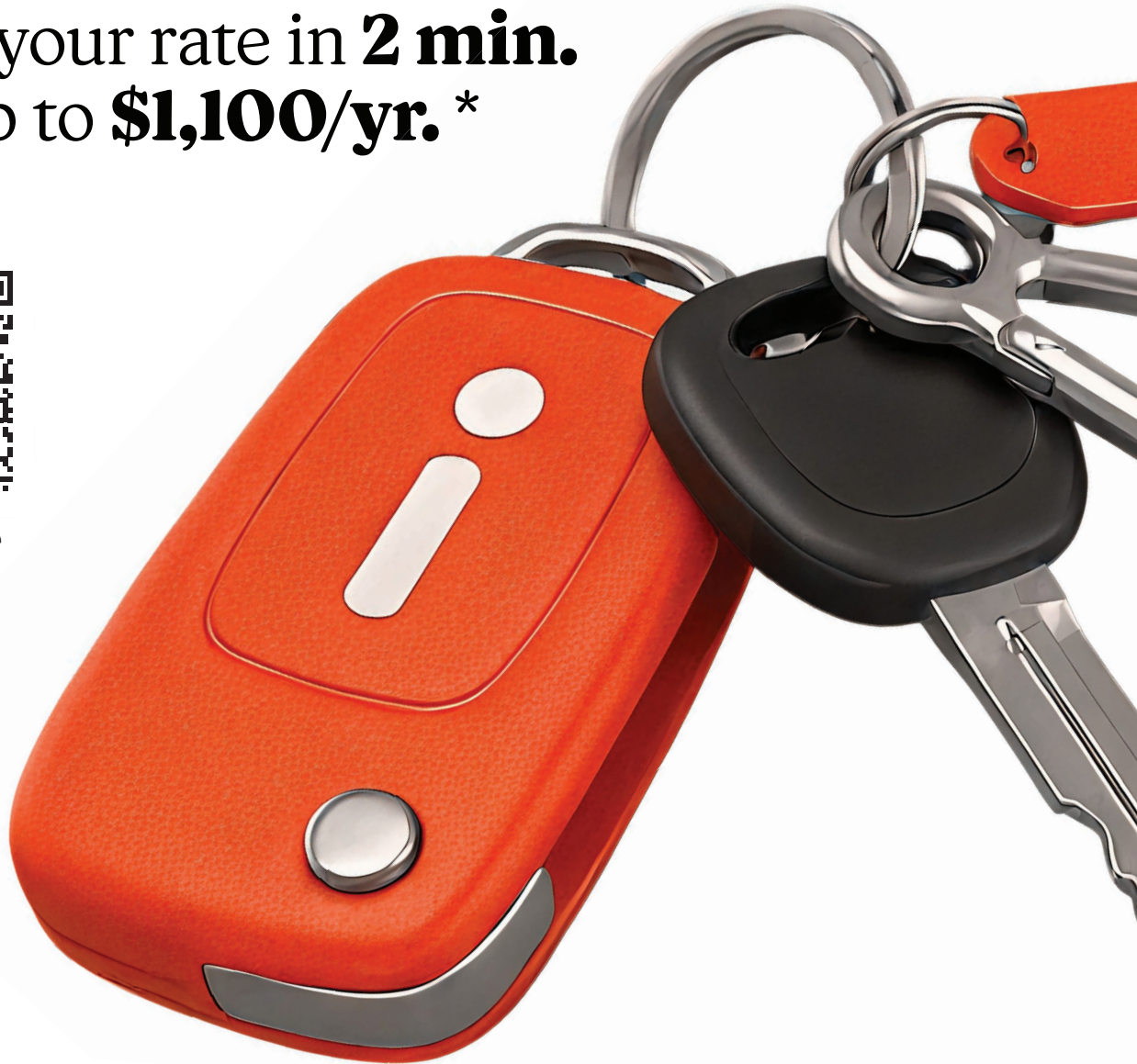
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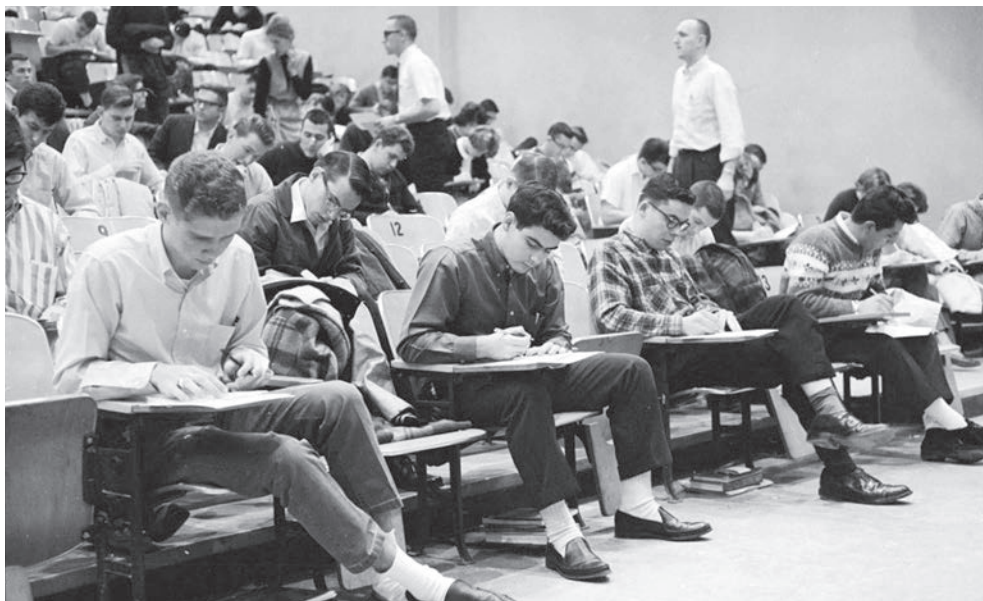
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Blue book sales at the Cal Student Store are up by 80 percent over the last two years.

That's one of the data points that *California* senior editor Nathalia Alcantara surfaces in her feature on the ways AI is changing higher education ("Test Case," p. 28), both in terms of how professors teach and how students learn, and sometimes cheat.

AI makes cheating easy—and hard to detect. It also blurs the line between academic fraud and simply taking full advantage of a new tool, the way a math student would use a calculator, say, or a photographer would use Photoshop. A lot depends on context. For some instructors, in some classes, using AI at all is prohibited. In other classes, AI use is encouraged or even mandatory.

At Berkeley, there's no university-wide policy governing the new technology, and professors are experimenting with policies of their own. That's understandable. It's also understandable that some students, already ambivalent about a technology that threatens to eliminate careers, feel they lack guidance and face a shifting set of standards.

Many of the professors Alcantara spoke with freely admitted to using AI, including to assist with research or analyze data. They feel they're knowledgeable enough to wield it responsibly. For their students, however, they worry it's too often a crutch.

To make sure students are actually learning and not just letting AI do the thinking for them, old methods of evaluation like oral and written exams (those blue books) have become one obvious, if onerous, solution. How strange it would be if the apogee of digital technology delivered us back to blank notebooks and pencils.

It's nearly as strange that Victorian-era technology still powers the future. I'm talking about suboceanic cables, which today carry virtually all international data traffic, including emails, phone calls, and AI prompts—albeit in hair-width fiber optic strands, not twisted copper wires.

That remarkable fact was brought to my attention not long ago by Professor Nicole Starosielski, who has created a first-of-its-kind certificate program and minor at Berkeley called Global Digital Infrastructure. As Starosielski's course drives home, and our illustrated feature ("The Astounding Life of an Email," p. 38) shows, our supposedly "wireless" communications and "cloud-based" networks are anything but.

AI makes cheating easy—and hard to detect. It also blurs the line between academic fraud and simply taking full advantage of a new tool.

Our lightspeed communications are no less amazing for it. AI chatbots, in particular, feel like magic. Black magic, I often think. And yet I confess I use them—specifically, the free model of Claude, Anthropic's chatbot. I don't use it to write for me, but as a sounding board—as a tool, not a crutch. But maybe I'm kidding myself.

Before publishing this note, I shared it with Claude and prefaced it, "No doubt you see the irony and/or hypocrisy of me running this past you."

The response came in seconds. "The irony's real and I'll let it sit there rather than perform discomfort about it—you're the one who has to square it, not me."

I'm not sure I can. I'm not sure any of us can.

—Pat Joseph, Editor in Chief

We want to hear your thoughts on AI, digital infrastructure, and the many other topics covered in this issue. Write to us at californiamag@alumni.berkeley.edu.

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From Art to State of the Art

Biotech incubator marks five years in former
Berkeley Art Museum **By Coby McDonald**

PHOTOS BY **MARCUS HANSCHEN '01, M.A. '04**

CALIFORNIA FALL 2026

9



P

hotosynthesis, the chemical process fundamental to life on Earth, has a flaw. So says Chris Eiben, Ph.D. '19, founder of the biotech startup GigaCrop. "There's a series of enzymes nature uses for this, but one of those enzymes is very slow."

The weak link is RuBisCO, the most plentiful protein on planet Earth and the enzyme that begins the process of turning carbon dioxide into plants,

algae, and cyanobacteria. For nearly three billion years, RuBisCO has shaped our world. Eiben is not impressed.

"If you look at plants today, they're only productively using 20 percent of the photons they have access to at midday sun."

To help plants meet their full potential, GigaCrop has designed brand-new enzymes that Eiben says could double crop yields.

It's the kind of bold idea that gets nurtured at Bakar Bio Labs, the largest university-run biotech incubator in the country. Opened in 2021 in the former Berkeley Art Museum and Pacific Film Archive building on Bancroft Avenue, Bakar Bio Labs offers a rotating cast of tenants—as many as 30 at a time—access to mentorship, state-of-the-art wet labs, Berkeley facilities, and a community of fellow dreamers to help launch their fledgling startups.

"The incubator provides the protected environment for these vulnerable early-stage companies to do their essential proof-of-concept work," says Kaspar Mossman, Ph.D. '06, managing director of QB3, the University of California institute that supports Bakar Bio Labs. "It makes the process of innovation more efficient."

Bioneers: David Schaffer (above) is the director of QB3, the UC institute that supports Bakar Labs; Kaspar Mossman (below) is managing director of QB3; Gino Segrè (previous page) is managing director of Bakar Labs.

Mossman and I stood on one of five cantilevered concrete slabs that spiral up and over the vast central atrium of the Bakar BioEnginuity Hub. Two decades ago, following damage from the 1989 Loma Prieta earthquake, the building's demolition seemed imminent. But a costly seismic retrofit gave new life to the architectural icon. Once graced by paintings and sculptures from around the world, the atrium is now carpeted and hosts tidy rows of cubicles. Floor-to-ceiling glass walls offer a new kind of display: lab-coated technicians doing things like pipetting samples into centrifuge tubes.

As we navigated the strange layout of architect Mario Ciampi's brutalist masterpiece, through bunker-like hallways, up and down ramps, and through oddly shaped spaces, I felt lost. Mossman said, "It's very difficult to say what floor you're on in this building." Still, it's a stunning space, monumental in scale and flooded with natural light.

"It's probably the most beautiful biotech incubator in the world," says Chad Miller, chief technical officer of ResVita Bio, a startup taking aim at Netherton syndrome, a rare skin disorder that can be excruciating and sometimes fatal. Sufferers lack a protein called LEKTI



that slows the natural breakdown of skin cells. Miller, who trained under Nobel laureate David Baker, Ph.D. '89, genetically engineered a bacteria that manufactures the crucial protein. ResVita's product is a lotion that continually produces LEKTI directly on the skin.

The work is expensive. "The thing that startups don't have is a million dollars to buy a microscope," Miller says. "If they do have a million dollars at all, that has to go to pay scientists who are going to want access to things like million-dollar microscopes."

Those can be found across the street, on campus; Bakar Lab tenants can also utilize university lab facilities.

Human resources have been just as crucial, Miller says. A Cal internship program, Break into Biotech, trains and compensates students who work with the tenant companies.

Then there's networking.

At one point, Mossman led me past an open door. Inside, a dozen people mingled around folding tables, drinks in hand. "It's kind of like speed dating for our energy materials companies."

Miller met the cofounder of ResVita while his own company, Nosis Bio, was also at Bakar Labs. They were cubicle mates. After Nosis

Continued on page 13

"What they are really doing is providing the 'baby improvers' with a how-to manual."

Berkeley professor of molecular therapeutics **Fyodor Urnov** in the *New York Times* in June, reacting to research out of Columbia University on a form of precision gene-editing that could potentially allow babies to be engineered for certain desired traits. Ongoing research is supported by a company that placed ads in New York City subways exhorting commuters to "have your best baby."

The House that Doudna Built

Berkeley Professor Jennifer Doudna, who shared the Nobel Prize for developing the gene-editing tool CRISPR-Cas9, founded the Innovative Genomics Institute in 2015 to advance new applications of the revolutionary technology. Since then, IGI-affiliated researchers have spawned more than 30 startups. Here are just six of them.

Amber Bio

Basem Al-Shayeb, Ph.D. '22, a graduate of the Banfield and Doudna Labs, cofounded Amber Bio in 2021 to address a limit of the gene-editing field: The current paradigm of genetic medicine relies on developing independent therapies for each separate mutation, the company says. Amber Bio's RNA-writing platform will enable thousands of mutations to be edited simultaneously. Importantly, the company adds, these RNA-based edits will be reversible.

KuriBio

KuriBio is developing nanoparticles to detect cancer earlier and kill it quicker. IGI fellow Judee Sharon '14 cofounded the company in 2023. Though KuriBio is initially focusing on B-cell lymphoma, a type of blood cancer, Sharon hopes to expand the company's targeted nanoparticle system to deliver different types of therapies precisely.

Editpep

The goal of Editpep, per the company's website, is straightforward: "To bring life-changing genome-editing therapies to patients with devastating neurological diseases." They will do so by safely delivering CRISPR straight into the brain. Ross Wilson, IGI's director of therapeutic delivery and an assistant adjunct professor at Berkeley, cofounded the company in 2023.

Fortiphyte

Former IGI fellow Alex Schultink, Ph.D. '13, started Fortiphyte to produce disease-resistant crops that will require less chemical management, thus improving sustainability and safety. Its researchers recently found a gene that could create a soybean variety that's impervious to the ravages of Asian soybean rust. They predict that, if successful, the newly resistant soybean could add \$1 billion in annual value to the market.

Sift Biosciences

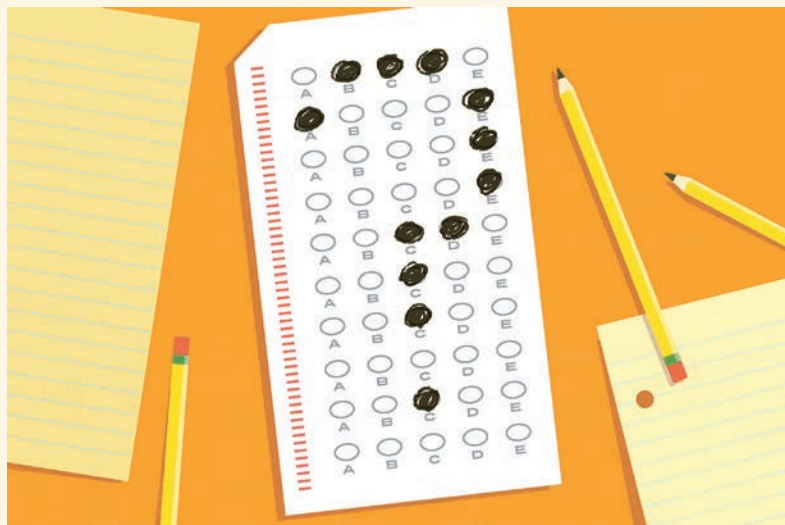
Banfield Lab graduate Yue Clare Lou '18, Ph.D. '23, cofounded Sift Biosciences, which is searching for protein fragments that look similar to viruses or bacteria already familiar to the immune system. The idea is to use this molecular mimicry to trick the immune system into attacking cancerous tumors it wouldn't normally recognize as a threat, training the body to fight them.

Verinomics

Cofounded by Brian Staskawicz, Ph.D. '80, a Berkeley professor emeritus and director of sustainable agriculture at IGI, Verinomics is working on creating stronger and faster-growing crops. Recently, the company developed a self-fertile almond, reducing reliance on the bees that normally pollinate almond trees, which could dramatically increase crop yields.

—James Pagett Tollen





Test Blinded

UC faculty split over standardized test requirement

In the spring of 2023, UC Berkeley math professor Zvezdelina Stankova began to notice that about a third of her students were “in freefall.” They weren’t showing up to lectures or doing their homework, and, on tests, they scored far below the average. At first, she thought it was an anomaly, but her observations were reinforced by a 2025 UC San Diego report that found that 1 in 12 of the campus’s incoming students tested below middle school math standards.

The development comes after the UC Board of Regents dispensed with standardized testing as a requirement of admission in 2020. That decision has since caused a rupture between faculty who feel the tests are an important measure of college preparedness and those who feel they discriminate against underrepresented students.

In June, Stankova, along with fellow Berkeley math professor Svetlana Jitomirskaya and three other professors, penned an open letter calling for the SAT/ACT math section to be reinstated as a consideration for admissions into STEM programs. It was followed by another letter from social sciences faculty calling for reinstatement of the reading and writing component. Together, the letters have garnered more than 3,000 signatures from faculty—including five Nobel laureates—across the UCs.

100

Number of years since the first SAT was administered

1968

Year the University of California began requiring students to take the SAT

2020

Year the UC regents voted to suspend standardized testing requirements

18

Percentage increase in UC freshman applications for fall 2021

<10

Percentage of four-year U.S. colleges requiring SAT or ACT scores in fall 2026

The pro-test camp points to a 2020 systemwide review from the Berkeley Academic Senate that was conducted at the request of then-UC President Janet Napolitano. The review found standardized test scores to be “better predictors of first-year GPA than high school grade point average, and about as good at predicting first-year retention, UGPA [undergraduate grade point average], and graduation.” The tests, they concluded, were also “better predictors of success for students who are Underrepresented Minority students, who are first generation, or whose families are low income.”

At Napolitano’s recommendation, however, the regents took a different path, suspending the SAT/ACT requirement, a decision many academics support. Plans were made to develop a UC-specific test, but to date, no such test has materialized.

Saul Geiser, M.A. '68, Ph.D. '79, a research associate at the Center for Studies in Higher Education at Berkeley, said that the SAT is ill-suited to test STEM preparation as most of it only tests at a tenth-grade algebra level. When controlled for factors like income or race, he contends, GPA is a stronger predictor of first-year outcomes. His research found that the test disadvantages those from less privileged backgrounds.

The pro-test side, however, argues that no admissions standard is without equity concerns. The social sciences faculty noted in their letter that the number of extracurricular activities that applicants report and the writing style of essays are also “strongly associated with social class.” Standardized testing, other test proponents add, can actually favor equity by identifying “diamonds in the rough”: talented students from underrepresented groups.

Geiser doesn’t buy it. “The decision of Ivy League colleges to reinstate the SAT has produced the opposite result, with dramatic declines in minority enroll-

Stankova says it is not enough; she likens it to trying to prepare someone who’s never driven to win a Formula One race.

ment. It is an illusion to believe that UC would not experience the same adverse outcome,” he wrote in an email.

Writing in *EdSource*, Patricia Gándara, professor emerita of education at UCLA, said that rather than deny opportunities to under-equipped students, the UCs should strive to meet their instructional needs.

The Berkeley math department does currently offer a foundational math class, launched in 2023, aimed at getting students “up-to-speed with the expectations of UC Berkeley’s lower division mathematics courses.” It’s essentially a high-school level pre-calculus class

covering material such as exponents, logarithmic functions, and complex numbers.

Stankova says it is not enough; she likens it to trying to prepare someone who's never driven to win a Formula One race. "We care for the students. We don't want students who would fail when they come here," she said. But "that kind of low preparation is out of reach."

Gabriel Rossman, a UCLA sociology professor, thinks that without the test, admissions is essentially a "coin toss" between two otherwise identical students.

In terms of equity and access, he said that UC has a mission of "excellence and research" that should be "open to everybody ... who has demonstrated excellence," but feels it is adequately addressed by California's three-tiered model of higher education. "That's why we have an excellent system of community colleges and Cal States. And we have a large number of transfers."

Stankova and Rossman are optimistic that some sort of testing requirement will be reinstated. Recently, the UC regents sped up the timeline for recommendations on standardized testing, changing the deadline from fall to June 2027.

But even if the SAT/ACT requirement does return, it won't happen right away. The first cohort of students who will be required to take the SAT may not enroll until the fall of 2030, Stankova said—a full decade after the tests were dropped.

—Margie Cullen, M.J. '22

"No pressure at all, but we are counting on you."

Professor emeritus **Robert Reich** addressing the Class of 2026 at commencement last spring. "I'd be remiss if I didn't tell you ... that we're in trouble right now. With each passing day, the systems that have been in place in this nation for nearly 250 years to advance democracy and prevent authoritarianism are under ever-greater strain."

"graduated," the ResVita founder hired Miller (who remains a scientific advisor at Nosis, which has since partnered with Johnson & Johnson). ResVita recently submitted an Investigational New Drug application with the FDA, a big deal for a pharmaceutical startup.

"For a therapeutic, it typically takes between 10 and 15 years from the lab to when it's actually available in clinics to be sold to patients," Mossman says. The average cost of developing a new drug and bringing it to market is in the hundreds of millions. "We have our fifth anniversary this fall. Have we seen any FDA-approved drugs? No. Have we got a couple clinical trials happening? Yes."

For early-stage biotech startups, investment can be hard to come by. Given the regulatory hurdles, the costs, and the experimental nature of the science, they make for inherently high-risk, high-reward investments. But that's just what investors were after during the biotech boom of the late 2010s. Then the COVID era sent biotech speculation into the stratosphere. Money poured in, and even young, unproven biotech companies reaped the rewards. Recently, however, investors have grown more cautious, parking their cash in safer bets.

"So there were companies getting 250 million bucks instead of 250 companies getting a million," Mossman says. "And then AI came in waving its shiny little banner."

To ensure its startups have a fighting chance, Bakar Labs carefully vets aspiring tenants. Mossman rattles off a list of criteria: "Is the science good? Does it meet an actual need? And has it got any likelihood of commercial success?"

"What size is the market? What's the FDA path? What has previously failed in this area? Why did it fail? Are these guys going to be any different than that? Who's on the team? Is it one undergrad? Is it three grad students? Is it out of a powerhouse lab? Is it two people

who actually seem to know what they're doing?"

And perhaps the most important question: Is there potential social benefit?

"I don't think there are any companies here that are doing stuff like working on a peptide to make you more tan," says Collin Blinder, the deputy director of communications at Bakar Labs and QB3.

"The phrase is 'double bottom line,'" added Mossman. "Something that is good for society and profitable."

Take GigaCrop. If Eiben's new enzymes succeed, it could mean cheaper biofuels and increased carbon fixation. But first they need to move from the test tube to plants, and that's a challenge.

"It's not getting the genes in," Eiben says, "it's knowing that they're all going to connect and work the way that you want. That's the harder part."

Despite the challenges, Bakar Lab tenants have raised over a billion dollars in investments since the incubator opened its doors. But funded or not, the odds are long. Mossman says one way Bakar Labs can help its tenants is by speeding up the innovation process. "Maybe that means you fail faster.... If you start a company and fail in the Bay Area, it just means that you started a company, and you're ready to start another company."

As Mossman led me through the maze-like building, I admitted I was disoriented.

"It was designed for disorientation," he said.

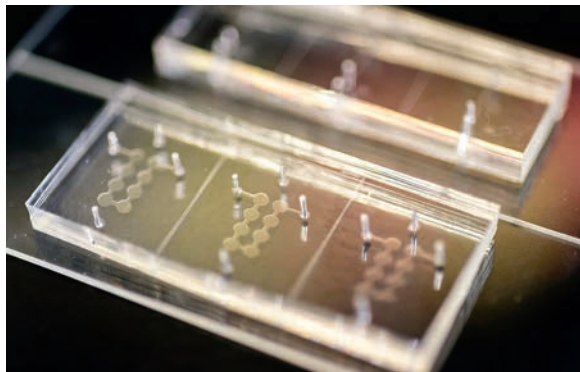
One startup founder told me that it usually takes about three weeks for new tenants to figure out how to find their way around the building.

We went down another windowless hallway. Mossman opened an exit door. "This is West," he said. "The ocean is that way." **C**

Coby McDonald, M.J. '17, is a writer and podcast producer.

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Human Aging on a Chip

An organ-on-a-chip may sound like science fiction, but scientists have successfully mimicked and miniaturized lungs, the blood-brain barrier, vaginas, and more.

Now Berkeley metabolic biologist Andreas Stahl and former longtime Berkeley professor Irina Conboy are adding human aging to that list.

The chip, created at the Biomolecular Nanotechnology Center at QB3, stores fat and liver tissue cells in separate yet connected chambers. Tiny channels stand in for vasculature, which require only a fraction of the fluid typical for standard cell cultures.

The system expands on an earlier one created by Stahl. Conboy, a pioneer in longevity research who has studied aging and reverse aging in mice, wondered if they could use Stahl's chips to age human tissue.

By exposing the tissue cells in the chip to blood serum from donors aged 62 and older, the researchers were able to induce the telltale signs of aging, including chronic inflammation, astonishingly quickly. "No one expected that in four days, you can age freshly differentiated stem cell-derived tissues to the degree that they are now old," Stahl said in a Rausser College of Natural Resources press release. Using tissue cells exposed to serum from donors aged 21 to 34 as a control group, a machine learning model helped confirm the ages of the samples with 90 to 97 percent accuracy.

Demonstrating the chip's potential usefulness in clinical trials, the Berkeley team tested various antiaging interventions on the aged tissues. They found promise with the "love hormone" oxytocin, for instance, and almost none with rapamycin, a kidney transplant medication also popular for off-label use to slow aging. "We could have told people that [rapamycin] is not going to work, based on this system, in four days," Stahl said.

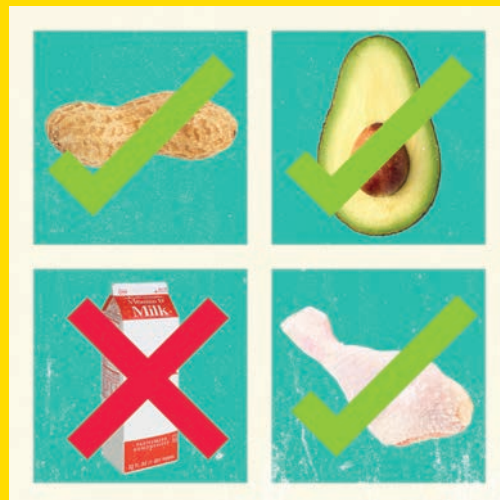
The Upgraded Sniff Test

Every year, millions of Americans fall ill to food-borne pathogens lurking in spoiled or undercooked food. Often, your nose is all that stands between a tasty dinner and food poisoning. But for one team of Berkeley researchers, no sniff test is needed—they've got an electric nose to do the job for them.

The device works similarly to other detectors commonly found in homes, such as those for carbon monoxide, but it can identify multiple gases instead of just one. That's thanks to an array of 16 tiny gas sensors that act like finely tuned digital taste buds. The brain behind the nose is a machine learning model trained to recognize how the sensors respond to everything from freeze-dried strawberries to peanuts to raw chicken left out at room temperature for two days.

The e-nose is "far more sensitive and far more objective than any human nose can be," says study lead Carla Bassil, M.S. '25, a Ph.D. student in the Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Sciences. She found that it was able to achieve an overall accuracy of 92.6 percent in classifying 16 different food objects. Beyond spoiled items, the nose could also smell and recognize just 0.05 grams of isolated walnut, a common food allergen.

Bassil will next test the device in environments where other gases are present, such as when sour milk is sitting next to fresh produce in a refrigerator. If it is successful, she says, the e-nose could eventually be integrated into refrigerators themselves. Some already track temperature and inventory, so why not food freshness too.





Cal's Coral Nursery

In the basement of Koshland Hall, luminous aquariums house green coral and anemones that resemble translucent palm trees. Here, in Cal's one-of-a-kind coral nursery, these cnidarians are thriving. Even if they are a little jetlagged.

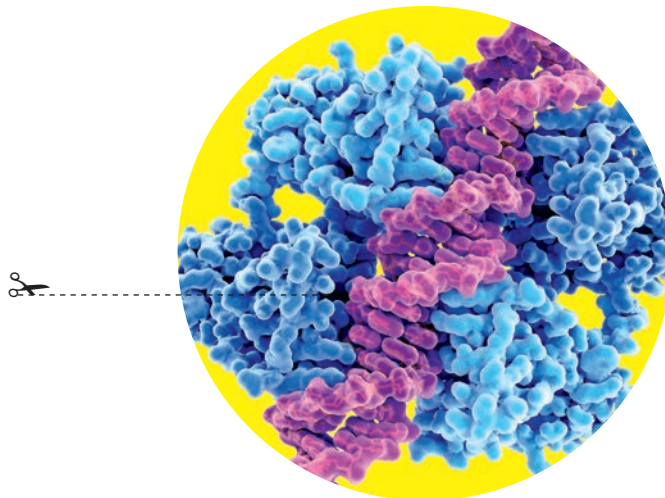
In their native reefs, most coral only spawn once a year, en masse around a full moon, limiting scientists to a narrow window for collection. By carefully altering his lab's lighting and temperature, assistant professor Philip Cleves, Ph.D. '15, has successfully designed six tanks of coral to spawn sequentially, giving him six opportunities a year to experiment on coral eggs. Their genetics may reveal the answer to how coral evolved with algae, a symbiotic relationship dating back hundreds of millions of years.

His theory: Microscopic algae parasitized coral, learning how to live within the cells' lysosomes without being eaten and instead releasing the products of photosynthesis to nourish their host, thus creating symbiosomes. When his team broke down some of the 200 symbiosomal proteins in the *Aiptasia* anemone, a cousin to coral, they found that many of them help keep the algae alive. "There are several vesicle trafficking proteins that we think are actually how the animal and the algae communicate, because they are trafficking cargo on and off the symbiosome, bringing stuff to the algae," Cleves said. They even mutated one, a bicarbonate transporter in the coral, with CRISPR, possibly cutting off the carbon dioxide the algae needs for photosynthesis.

"Our overall research goal," he told Berkeley News, "is to understand symbiosis and also to understand the genetic mechanisms for why corals bleach," the process when stressed coral expel the algae that give them both color and the food needed to survive.

"I believe that and I don't know how to study it."

Professor **Dacher Keltner** on the *Huberman Lab* podcast, while discussing his brother's death and questions of an afterlife. "Consciousness," the well-known Berkeley psychologist posited, "may be patterns of electromagnetic waves around our minds and bodies that are syncing up with other people that transcend the Newtonian world of the brain."



CRISPRing Cancer

Fourteen years after Berkeley biochemist and Nobel laureate Jennifer Doudna co-created CRISPR-Cas9, researchers in her lab at Berkeley's Innovative Genomics Institute (IGI) are using the gene-editing technology to target "undruggable" cancers.

Their new technique comes from the long-held understanding that roughly half of all cancers, including 70 to 90 percent of the most stubborn ones (like pancreatic or ovarian), harbor the same faulty protein: p53, a tumor suppressor nicknamed the "guardian of the genome." When p53 proteins are too mutated to do their job, the cells they're meant to protect are left vulnerable, allowing tumors to grow.

Scientists have been working on reviving or replacing mutated p53 proteins since the '90s. But no treatment has ever been approved for clinical use. Part of the problem is that p53 lacks the "pockets" that drug molecules normally latch onto.

That's where CRISPR comes in. Instead of trying to fix cells with a mutated p53, scientists in Doudna's lab are using a specialized form of CRISPR to kill them so healthy cells can take their place. "When people treat cancer with chemotherapy or radiotherapy, that's essentially killing all the dividing cells in the body, including healthy cells," said Jingkun Zeng, the study lead and a postdoctoral researcher in Doudna's lab, in an IGI press release. "With this technology, it's much, much more precise."

Zeng and team have already succeeded in using CRISPR-Cas12a2 to sort through cultures of mammalian cells, find the mutated few, and shred their genetic material. The technique also promises to extend beyond p53. In Doudna's words, "Not only can this approach target the 'undruggable' cancers that we know, we can also easily and quickly adapt this to new mutations."



Arresting Cardiac Arrest

The medical community calls sudden cardiac arrest a “silent killer” for a reason: When the heart suddenly stops beating, few survive the following minutes. Every year, it kills more than 300,000 people in the U.S. alone—very often with no prior warnings or signs of disease.

The solution is simple, says Ziad Obermeyer, a physician and an associate professor at Berkeley’s School of Public Health: Get a defibrillator implanted to regulate your heart. “The problem,” he says, “is that doctors can’t figure out who needs one before it’s too late.”

So Obermeyer began looking to AI for help. Through two organizations he cofounded, Dandelion Health and Nightingale Open Science, he collected six years of EKG scans from hospitals across Sweden. With that data, he trained an AI model to analyze the waveform patterns of both healthy and at-risk hearts. One decade and 440,000 EKGs later, it has identified a biomarker that precedes cardiac arrest.

The model consistently outperforms current detection methods. Where a standard clinical test isolates a patient group with a 4.6 percent annual rate of sudden cardiac death, Obermeyer’s tool can identify groups with a 7 percent rate. Morbid as that may sound, those few percentage points could mean thousands of saved lives.

Currently, Obermeyer is deploying the algorithm in hospitals in Sweden, Taiwan, and the U.S., where it will flag high-risk EKG scans. He also built a website where individuals can sign up for the chance to have their own EKGs analyzed (eccentric.health/ecg-interest).

With AI, Obermeyer says, “there is going to be a new way of doing science.”

“I’m joining Anthropic’ is the new meme right now.”

Arizona State computer science professor Subbarao Kambhampati quoted in the *Atlantic* article “Where Did All the Computer-Science Professors Go?” The story cited the hiring of Berkeley EECS chair **Jelani Nelson** as a prime example of the trend. Nelson announced on X in July that he had taken leave from Cal to work at the frontier lab and that he was “excited to work with many talented, mission-driven people on the defining technology of our time.”



Who Runs the Negotiation? (Girls)

Earlier research has suggested that women are worse negotiators than men because they’re too accommodating. But “scholars have been so focused on who wins the negotiation that we missed who wins the relationship,” Berkeley behavioral scientist Laura Kray says.

As part of a revealing new paper, Kray, Haas assistant professor Solène Delecourt, and lead author and former graduate student Charlotte Townsend, M.S. ’21, Ph.D. ’24, conducted five different studies with more than 2,000 people and found that, in negotiations, women achieved economic outcomes “on par” with men while simultaneously outscoring them in likeability, trustworthiness, and fairness.

One of the studies drew from anonymous online negotiations where participants haggled over fictitious resources via text chat. Even when the researchers assigned random gender labels to the chats and showed them to hundreds of reviewers, women were ranked highest on all measures of subjective value. They were better liked because of their behavior—not because of gender-based stereotypes. As the paper concludes, people simply prefer negotiating with women.

Over time, that turns into more money. After running a randomized simulation on their data, the researchers estimated that women could see 45 percent more negotiation opportunities over a career. If every negotiation opportunity earned a bonus, for example, that would mean extra dollars in their pockets.

“In personal finance, the value of compounding is extremely powerful in the long term,” Delecourt told UC Berkeley Haas. “The same is true in negotiation: If people enjoy the process of negotiating with you, and want to negotiate with you in the future, that is like a high interest rate. It is likely to result in long-term gains.”



Snapshots in time:
Doctoral student
Jaemin Lee photo-
graphs fossilized
flora.

Then a nearby volcano erupted, blanketing the inland forest in ashfall and capturing the shapes of plants in solid rock, creating what UC Museum of Paleontology curator Cindy Looy calls “a snapshot in time.”

After excavating thousands of fossilized leaves, flowers, fruits, and seeds, Looy, doctoral student Jaemin Lee, and the Perot Museum of Nature and Science's Dori Contreras, Ph.D. '18—for whom the site is named—reconstructed a forest dominated by flowering plants growing alongside older lineages of ferns and redwoods. This upends the common narrative that angiosperms did not start flourishing until after dinosaurs went extinct. What's more, they found that the seeds and fruits, called diaspores, were unexpectedly large, on average the size of a plump blueberry.

That might not seem like much today, but it's a hundredfold difference in volume from the poppy seed-sized diaspores of other Cretaceous sites. Rather than dispersing small seeds unassisted, the findings imply that flowering plants were already interacting with early mammals and even dinosaurs in some areas well before the end-Cretaceous extinction.

“This fossil flora suggests that these animals were already moving over to eating bigger seeds produced by angiosperms 75 million years ago. This is a surprise, because people thought they didn't exist yet,” Looy said. “And here they are.”

Botanical Pompeii

When Mount Vesuvius erupted in 79 AD, volcanic ash buried Pompeii, preserving the city in remarkable detail. Now Berkeley paleobotanists have unearthed a different kind of Pompeii—this one from the time of the dinosaurs.

The 75-million-year-old site, located in New Mexico and known as Dori's Tuff, was once a thriving tropical forest.

JAEMIN LEE



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The Play



Bear Tracks

By the time this issue reaches you, football season will be hitting full stride, and the Golden Bears will have notched three or four wins already, no doubt.

Certainly many Bears fans see the stars aligning for Cal football. GM **Ron Rivera** is a Cal alum ('89). So is **Tosh Lupoi '05**, the new head coach, whom Rivera hired. So is Chancellor **Rich Lyons '82**, who hired Rivera.



Cal women's water polo came up just short against USC in the NCAA finals in April but beat Stanford en route, their first-ever postseason win over the Cardinal.

Write For California blogger **Ruey Yen '04** wrote that he wished he could have seen that "inspiring performance" against top-seeded Stanford back in February, before he went on *Jeopardy!* to compete against superchamp Jamie Ding. Alas, Yen, a self-described "baseball usher, sports blogger, and physici-



cist," didn't win. If you're not yet acquainted, *Write For California* is the fan-operated website that, in the words of sports scribe **Mike Silver '88**, "covers the hell out of Cal sports like a bear suffocating a tree." If you get the reference, you'll be at home there. The site is also closely associated with the Calgorithm, the fan-driven meme factory we wrote about in our Fall/Winter 2025 issue (tinyurl.com/3mth9rsn).

Got a story for us?
Send tips to
californiamag@alumni.berkeley.edu.

All eyes continue to be on **Fernando Mendoza '25**, Cal's ex-QB and the No. 1 NFL draft pick last season. In May, the newly minted Raider walked the stage as a special guest at the Haas School of Business's MBA graduation ceremony, where he received his undergraduate diploma. As we reported in our

last issue, Mendoza earned his degree from Haas in three years.

Fewer eyes have been on **Jaydn Ott '25**, another Cal star who transferred via the portal—to Oklahoma. Ott (who also graduated from Cal in three years) went undrafted after a fallow year with the Sooners. He ultimately signed with the Kansas City Chiefs as a free agent.

That scenario is not uncommon. Less than 2 percent of all Division I football players get drafted. Even some of the very best college players never make it to the pros.

How many Cal players are currently in the NFL? According to Cal Athletics figures, there were 19 Golden Bears on active rosters as of September 2025.

In the age of NIL and revenue sharing, it should come as no surprise that it's also the age of the college general manager. In addition to Rivera, who's in charge of football operations, the Bears have hired **Meghin Williams** as general manager for women's basketball and **Richard Midgley '06** as deputy general manager for the men's team. Midgley is a former starting guard for the Bears.

Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele is under center again this year for Cal. It took money to keep the QB in Berkeley.

Responsibility for raising the funds largely fell to **Kevin Kennedy, J.D. '91**, president of California Legends, the third-party NIL collective that supports Cal's athletics programs in raising the funds they need for revenue sharing. Kennedy told *The Athletic*, "It wasn't like we had a bake sale.

It was really a targeted effort to find that money, and we did it."

Cal Athletics reported that it raised \$88.5 million in gifts and pledges in 2025–26, with 18 donors pledging \$1 million or more each.

Speaking of general managers, **Eric Tulskey, Ph.D. '02**, is GM of the Carolina



Remember the student who kicked a 33-yard field goal on *College GameDay* in 2024 while wearing a pair of Vans? **Daniel Villaseñor** won \$100,000 that day. He's on track to graduate from Cal with a degree in civil engineering.



Former Cal shortstop (and later MLB second baseman) **Jeff Kent** was inducted into the National Baseball Hall of Fame on July 26. He's the first former Cal player to earn the distinction.

the line, as the university had decided to cut or redesignate five varsity teams that year, including baseball. In the end, donors led by **Stu Gordon '62, J.D. '65**, raised some \$9 million to rescue the program. The aluminum bats now ring out in Stu Gordon Stadium.

"It wasn't like we had a bake sale."

Another varsity program that was on the chopping block in 2010–11 was women's gymnastics. It too was saved and has done Cal proud since then, making it to its second ACC championship this year, after three straight regular-season Pac-12 titles and a second-place finish in the 2024 NCAA championships.

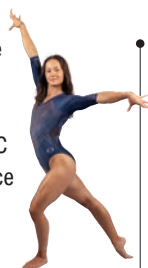
Hurricanes, one of the top franchises in the National Hockey League. A scientist who specializes in nanotechnology, Tulskey started with the Hurricanes as a part-time analyst before eventually working his way to the top of the org chart.

He's not the only one in the front office of a professional franchise.

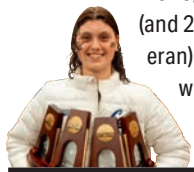
Paul Toboni '12, former Cal baseball player, is in his first year as president of baseball operations for the Washington Nationals.

A former infielder for the Bears, Toboni was part of the last Cal squad to make it to the College World Series, in 2011. They did it with the program on

Cal's **Tonya Paulsson** made history at the 2026 ACC Championships by becoming the first freshman in ACC history to win the conference all-around title.



Cal has won more than 100 national team titles and more than 200 individual titles across its history. It added even more individual champions in 2026, including freshman (and 2024 Olympic veteran) **Claire Weinstein**, who won the NCAA title in the 500-yard freestyle.



One of the biggest sports stories of 2026 was the New York Knicks' NBA championship victory over the San Antonio Spurs. Had things worked out differently, **Jason Kidd** might have coached the Knicks. In 2020, the franchise interviewed the former Cal superstar to take the head coaching spot. They came knocking again in 2025, but the Dallas Mavericks put the kibosh on that.

Two more for the trophy case: In crew, Cal's varsity four won a 2026 Intercollegiate Rowing Association national title. And perennial powerhouse Cal rugby won its 35th national collegiate championship title.



Another Cal star with a Knicks connection is **Darrall Imhoff '94**.

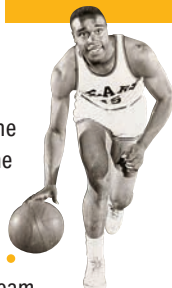
The 6'10" center had the dubious distinction of guarding Wilt Chamberlain the night Chamberlain scored a record 100 points. Afterward, Imhoff said, "I can't have a nightmare tonight. I've just lived through one."

Imhoff's class year above is correct, by the way. He came back to finish his forestry degree in the '90s. His coach at Cal, Pete Newell, joked, "It only took you 35 years. I thought it would take 45."

1958–59 was the zenith of Cal Athletics. In addition to its Rose Bowl appearance, Cal, led by Imhoff, won the national basketball crown in 1959.

Rose Bowl quarterback **Joe Kapp '60** played both football and basketball at Cal. His roommate **Earl Robinson '58, M.A. '71**, was also a two-sport letterman, a star in basketball and baseball. He went on to play in the major leagues for the Dodgers and Orioles. He also had the distinction of being the first African American yell leader at Cal.

Anna Bright '21 is an up-and-comer on the pro pickleball circuit. The former Cal varsity tennis player is ranked second in the world in women's doubles.



The 1959 Rose Bowl team was surprisingly diverse for the times, with Black, Hispanic, and Asian starters.

The sporting event of the summer was the Men's World Cup of soccer, err, football. In the U.S.'s group match against Australia in Seattle, the camera found former Cal varsity soccer players **Alex Morgan '14** and her husband, **Servando Carrasco '15**, in the crowd. Like Morgan (see sidebar), Carrasco played professional soccer for several years. He retired in 2020.

Also spotted at the Australia game was **Marshawn Lynch**, who once, in the very same stadium, made a 67-yard touchdown run in which he broke nine tackles. The reaction of Seahawks fans was so great it registered 2.0 on the Richter scale. The play is remembered as the Beast Quake.

Lynch wasn't just a spectator. He was also a credentialed sideline photographer!



For Cal rugby fans, "World Cup" has a different meaning; it's the Bears' annual match against the University of British Columbia. Last spring was the teams' 100th meeting. Cal won. Naturally.

—P.J.



Taking it to the Man

How Cal's Alex Morgan led the charge on equal pay for U.S. Women's Soccer

Lady Liberty: A larger-than-life statue of Alex Morgan was erected in New York City to promote the 2023 Women's World Cup.

When the FIFA Men's World Cup ended on July 19, it was a sad day for soccer fans—and not just because Argentina lost. No, that was fine. It was sad because the whole wonderful spectacle had come to a sudden close, not to return for four long years.

Actually, this summer's soccer pageantry should be a reminder that the 2027 Women's World Cup is now less than a year away. The tournament runs from June 24 through July 25 in Brazil.

While the U.S. men have struggled to break through on the world stage—once again failing to reach the quarterfinals—the U.S. women have long been an international powerhouse, with four FIFA World Cup titles and five Olympic golds to their credit.

They are also early favorites to win it all in Rio.

Many of the athletes behind the U.S. dominance are now household names, including Megan Rapinoe, Carli Lloyd,

Continued on page 21

Q/A



Professor Brian Galle on the Proposed CA Billionaire Tax

This November, California voters will decide on Proposition 40. If passed, it will levy a one-time 5 percent tax on the state's billionaires. Berkeley Law Professor Brian Galle, writer of a recent report titled "How to Tax the Ultrarich," is one of four coauthors of the proposition. He kindly agreed to field our questions.

This interview has been edited for length and clarity.

Where did the idea for the state billionaire tax come from?

It comes from California Health Workers West, a union of health workers in California. They are concerned about the 2025 legislation [Trump's One Big Beautiful Bill Act], which is projected to cut about \$100 billion in federal support for California health costs over the next five or six years. Typically, hospitals cannot turn away people who show up at their emergency room sick or seriously injured. That money has to come from somewhere. So it comes out of the pockets of other Californians who already have health insurance, or it comes through staffing cuts by hospitals. So the \$100 billion in cuts probably means less access to care for Californians, care that's not as good, and care that's more expensive.

The union didn't think any of this was good, so they said, "Where can we get this \$100 billion?" And it turns out California has 200 billionaires who collectively are worth more than \$2 trillion. If the bill passes, and they pay this one-time 5 percent tax, they'll still be richer at the end of the year than when they started. That seems like a more sensible way to get the money than out of the pockets of every insured Californian.

Why is it only a one-time tax?

Because there's a one-time problem. This cut in federal support will last for as long as this administration is

around, and probably for some time after, so we should expect at least three years of California really needing that money.

Critics have pointed to France as an example where wealth taxes triggered "capital flight"—wealthy people moving to lower tax regions, which ultimately hurts the economy. Is that a concern here?

Those critics are wrong about the evidence. I've written a paper examining the effects of both wealth taxes and income taxes on wealthy people around the world, and there is very little real mobility. People don't really move in response to taxes. Our lives and business are very closely tied to a place, and it's usually not worth giving up those connections.

If the bill passes, and they pay this one-time 5 percent tax, they'll still be richer at the end of the year than when they started.

I would agree about France in the following sense: The French wealth tax, as it was implemented, only taxed publicly traded businesses. And if you only tax a subset of businesses, you're going to have a lot of pressure over time for people to move their money into the kinds of businesses that aren't being taxed. That turns out to be bad for your economy, and it makes people mad that some people are being taxed and other very similar people aren't. Our wealth tax instead taxes everyone the same way.

If you look at the right models, wealth taxes can be successful. Switzerland raises more money through its wealth tax than through any other mechanism. Spain has a wealth tax at the state level. There are wealth taxes in Scandinavia, too. The California wealth tax uses those successful wealth taxes as models.

You and your coauthors have estimated the tax would raise about \$100 billion over five years. Some economists predict much less. How did you come to your estimation?

The estimate starts with the fact that California billionaires are worth somewhere upwards of \$2.2 trillion, and growing. Five percent of that is \$110 billion. We expect that the tax will fall on most of that existing money.

The tax falls on individuals who lived in California as of January 1, 2026, which already happened—and it happened before [Google cofounder] Sergey Brin claimed that he had moved. The fact that individuals are claiming that they will move in the future doesn't change the amount of revenue that is going to be brought in now.

Another argument is, "Well, some of the billionaires might move permanently, so the net revenue that the bill brings in is less than the income tax that we would have gotten from those billionaires in the future." But our income tax system has so many loopholes that even if billionaires did leave, we wouldn't be losing very much, because they don't pay very much income tax to begin with.

Many billionaires live by the so-called "buy, borrow, die" strategy. What is that and how does your tax address it?

Under an income tax, an investor only pays tax when they sell. And dying is not the same as selling. So, if you pass assets to your heirs and you haven't paid tax on them, your heirs will never pay tax on the gains that happened during your lifetime. For example, whoever Jeff Bezos passes his Amazon stock on to, if they turn around and sell 100 billion dollars' worth of it, they will pay zero dollars in taxes.

It's a strategy. You get rich, and the way to avoid anyone ever paying taxes is to make sure you die with it. And if you're asking, "Well, how do you afford the mega yacht if you haven't sold your stock?" One common way is to use stock as collateral and borrow a loan against it. But there are also lots of rich people who don't borrow, and don't need to, because it turns out that even a small fraction of their money is enough to buy yachts and helicopters and things. So, the strategy is don't sell your stuff, or don't sell much of it, and you won't pay very much tax.

But a wealth tax is not an income tax. It's a tax on all the stuff that you own, whether you've sold it or not. So the strategy of "don't sell" doesn't help to avoid the California Billionaire Tax.

—J.P.T.

"I believe that sending a message is where this needs to start."

Dr. Harry Edwards, the former Berkeley professor who pioneered the sociology of sports at Cal, quoted in *The Athletic*. Edwards was weighing in on a call by the NAACP for college athletes, fans, and alumni to boycott athletic programs at eight public universities in the South, in response to the Supreme Court's recent weakening of the Voting Rights Act.

Continued from page 19

Abby Wambach, and the Golden Bears' own Alex Morgan '14.

A four-time All-Pac-10 and All-American selection in her time at Cal (2007–10), Morgan went on to a 15-year career with the national team (2010–24) and was twice named Female Player of the Year by the U.S. Soccer Federation, in 2012 and 2018.

Only a few years later, she would help bring a gender discrimination lawsuit against the very same organization. "Yes, we sued our employer," Morgan said in an interview with podcaster Alex Cooper last year.

"So, this started back in 2015, [when] we won the World Cup for the first time in 16 years. All of a sudden, we had sold-out stadiums and were generating revenue for U.S. Soccer like never before. We were getting sponsors coming to U.S. Soccer, saying, 'We want to work with the women.' ... We were seeing ... the returns at the end of the year, so you're like, I know what you're making, and I know what we're generating, and this isn't adding up."

When the U.S. men's team made it to the Round of 16 in the 2014 World Cup, they were awarded \$5.38 million in bonuses. A year later, when the women won it all at the World Cup in Canada, the payout was \$1.73 million.

So, in 2016, Morgan and four other national team members filed a federal wage-discrimination complaint with the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission. And, in 2019, just before Team USA won the Women's World Cup in France, they filed a class-action suit. Morgan became the lead plaintiff in the landmark gender discrimination case, *Morgan v. USSF*.

In 2022, the women prevailed, securing a \$24 million settlement that included backpay and also guaranteed equal contracts for the men's and women's soccer teams going forward.

Morgan, who retired from professional soccer in 2024, told Cooper she was holding her 3-year-old daughter as she signed the papers.

—Scott Ball

Mixed Media



California Dreams: The Making and Remaking of the University of California
By Miriam Pawel

Author Miriam Pawel took it upon herself to write the history of the University of California—all ten campuses. That’s biting off more than any writer could reasonably hope to chew, even across 350 pages.

And yet she does a tremendous job digesting the material, which runs from Berkeley’s origins as the College of California in Oakland in 1868 to the founding and development of UC Merced, the newest in the constellation of UCs, in 2005.

Pawel is a biographer by inclination. Her past titles include *The Browns of California* and *The Crusades of Cesar Chavez*. (While highly critical of her subject, Pawel did not uncover the labor leader’s shocking pattern of sexual abuse, which only came to light this year.)

Here, the author structures her account around five characters who helped shape and were shaped by the University: Milicent Shinn, the first woman at the University to earn a doctorate, in 1898; Kenneth Bailey, the first Ph.D. recipient from UCLA (formerly the Southern Branch); Clark Kerr, Ph.D. ’39, Berkeley’s first chancellor and, later, UC president; David “Mas” Masumoto ’76, a peach and grape farmer who studied at both Berkeley and Davis; and Jose Manuel Alamillo, alumnus of UC Santa Barbara and a pioneer in the field of Chicano studies.

Of all these characters (and there are countless cameos in the book), Kerr looms largest. His section—Act Three—is filled with palace intrigue and power plays—somewhat surprising given the famous administrator’s mild demeanor and lack of vices. But there was resolve and guile behind the façade. Pawel calls him the “Machiavellian Quaker.” Massed against the man were foes from all sides, including his predecessor Robert Sproul, FBI moles, student rabble-rousers, certain SoCal regents, and, of course, Ronald Reagan, who ran for governor on a pledge to “clean up the mess at Berkeley.” Sadly underplayed here is Kerr’s famous wit. After his termination, he quipped that he left the University the same way he arrived, “fired with enthusiasm.”

His greatest contribution was his three-tiered Master Plan for Higher Education, which promised a college education to any Californian who sought it, free of charge. As egalitarian as it sounds, there was always a baked-in tension between populism and elitism. Pawel sums it up this way: “There should be room for everyone—but only the best students would go to the University”—that is, the UCs, as opposed to the CSUs and the community colleges. And within the UCs, Berkeley and UCLA were first among equals—and rivals to boot.

While Berkeley dominates the narrative, the author is careful to shine ample light on the other UCs. One of the more interesting and surprising chapters is about UC Irvine, the “Instant University,” which began recruiting and hiring faculty before there was so much as a single building on site. Early visitors came in by helicopter as there were no roads. The first class of students, in 1965, lived in cottages, and the “faculty club” was a trailer. Just 30 years later, the former frontier outpost would claim Nobel Prizes in both physics and chemistry.

Among other things, the book is a catalogue of battles: the faculty revolution of 1919, the loyalty oath controversy, the Free Speech Movement, People’s Park, *Regents of the University of California v. Bakke*, etc. Perennial issues run through the account, from debates about standardized testing, to the concern that research overshadows teaching, and alarm over supposed indoctrination by leftist faculty. *Plus ça change*.

The beauty of Pawel’s narrative is that it puts the battles in context and even, at times, explains their origins. At Berkeley, for example, she traces the lack of housing to the original design, which “was modeled on German universities, where many of the early faculty had trained, with minimal provisions for student life and no cultural facilities.”

But the UCs shine on and Pawel celebrates the triumphs of the institution that writer Joan Didion ’56 famously called the state’s “highest, most articulate idea of itself.” Anyone curious as to how that idea took shape will benefit from reading Pawel’s outstanding account.

—P.J.

Bedrock: Regent Donald McLaughlin, Governor Pat Brown, and UC President Clark Kerr scaled Founders’ Rock on April 22, 1960, to commemorate the beginnings of the University of California.

“We keep that promise today.”

Chief Justice John Roberts in June, delivering the Supreme Court’s verdict in *Trump v. Barbara*, the closely watched birthright citizenship case. Citing Berkeley historian **Hidetaka Hirota’s** 2017 book, *Expelling the Poor: Atlantic Seaboard States and the Nineteenth-Century Origins of American Immigration Policy*, the court issued a 6–3 decision in favor of *jus soli*, or “right of the soil.” Said Hirota, “The decision demonstrates how historians’ work continues to matter in our society today.”



A Wall Is Also a Road By Annalee Newitz

Gardenpath is, in many ways, a typical graduate student: ambitious, socially awkward, and determined to make a discovery that will change the course of history. They're also a many-eyed slime mold in disguise.

Leave it to author **Annalee Newitz '89, Ph.D. '98**, to build an intergalactic sci-fi adventure around a precocious, single-cell organism.

A prolific science journalist and fiction writer, Newitz has a knack for creating unlikely protagonists, from the ragtag band of robots in their novella *Automatic Noodle* to the intelligent moose in their Nebula Award-nominated novel *The Terraformers*. In Newitz's latest novel, *A Wall Is Also a Road*, readers follow Gardenpath, an ancient amoeba living beyond the galaxy and studying to become an acclaimed scientist. But when the tiny slime mold turns their eye—erm, eyes—toward a suspiciously Earth-like planet, they find their academic plans derailed by a little city called Pompeii and a woman named Murtis.

Newitz, who consulted biologists and slime mold experts, brings remarkable humanity to a brainless, microscopic organism that communicates mostly through chemical signals and a probing appendage. There are the juicy questions, too: How would a slime mold smile? Flirt? Have sex?

This novel has a little something for everyone who loves cozy sci-fi: speculative biology, history about the Roman Empire, a lesbian romance. In a recent interview, Newitz said, "I hope everybody develops a deeper appreciation for sapphic tentacle sex."

—Leah Worthington



Scan this code
or go to tinyurl.com/AnnaleeNewitz for
a podcast interview
with the author.

The Pitt

If you followed this year's Primetime Emmy Awards, you definitely know about *The Pitt*, HBO Max's wildly popular medical series, which dramatizes a single 15-hour work shift at a Pittsburgh trauma center. The show, which garnered five Emmys in 2025, entered this year's awards with a whopping 25 nominations, including for Outstanding Production Design for a Narrative Contemporary Program and Outstanding Casting for a Drama Series. Behind those nominations are two Cal alums.

Production designer **Nina Ruscio '83** designed the set of *The Pitt*'s emergency department. Ruscio used curves in the floors and ceilings to make the finite halls seem boundless, reflecting the sense that, as she told *California*, "time never stops." Other details help elevate the setting while preserving the movie magic: a lack of mirrors conceals cameramen, countertops bounce light onto actors' faces, and all crew members wear scrubs in case they appear on camera.

Casting director **Cathy Sandrich Gelfond '83** assembled the ensemble cast, including actors who could think on their feet, work well in a group, and convincingly deliver medical jargon. Some even had medical backgrounds. "We had a wall of pictures so we could see what different actors looked like as a group. As my casting partner, Erica Berger, and I watched through hundreds and hundreds of self-tapes, we started to understand so much about the characters," Sandrich Gelfond said. "We called this show the great experiment because no one knew if it would work."

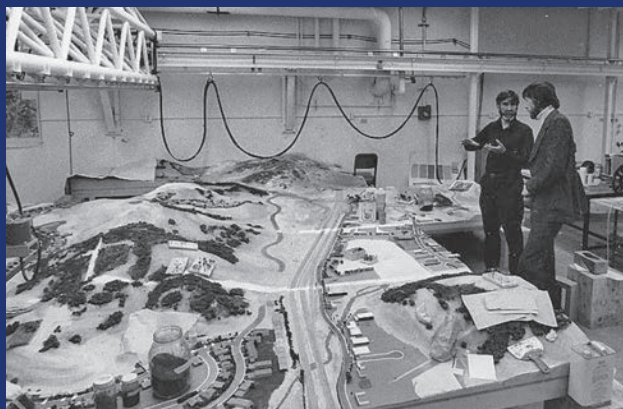
Both Ruscio and Sandrich Gelfond found their creative footing at Berkeley. Ruscio was a set designer for Cal's theater department while Sandrich Gelfond performed onstage. "Everyone just couldn't stop creating," Ruscio said. "Everything had value. Everything was a possible experience."

—H.J. Valerio



Primetimers: Production designer Nina Ruscio (above) and casting director Cathy Sandrich Gelfond (below) are crucial players in the creation of *The Pitt*.

It Came from Berkeley



The Death Star

In the cockpit of his X-wing, Luke Skywalker flies through a metal trench on the Death Star. Darth Vader is hot on his tail. Lasers fly. Luke's allies are hit; it's all on him. Summoning the Force, he aims, shoots, and... boom! The Death Star explodes.

Anyone who has seen the original 1977 *Star Wars* will remember this scene. It's the climax of the movie. A feat of special effects. And it likely wouldn't have happened without the Environmental Simulation Lab at Berkeley.

Founded by Berkeley psychologist Kenneth Craik, Ph.D. '64, and urban planning professor Donald Appleyard during the housing boom of the '70s, the lab's goal was to create better visualizations of building plans for the public. To that end, they built an intricate model of a 1.5-by-1-mile slice of Marin County; each inch of the miniature was equivalent to 30 feet. Using a crane controlled by cutting-edge "minicomputers," they inched a camera over the tiny roads. Some (not all) viewers were convinced that the resulting "miniaturized" footage was real video taken from a car cruising along at 30 miles an hour.

Later, three of the engineers and staff on the project—John Dykstra, Alvah Miller, and Jerry Jeffress—brought the same techniques to *Star Wars*. But instead of rolling hills and suburbia, George Lucas's fledgling SFX company painstakingly modeled a 600-by-1,600-mile section of the Death Star, actually measuring just 15 by 40 feet. They mounted a camera on a truck and drove it through the model at 20 miles an hour—and Luke's X-wing tore through space.

In 1978, they won the Oscar for Best Visual Effects, and so began a franchise. May the force be with urban planning.

—J.P.T.

Wired for Connection

If there's one thing the pandemic taught us, it's that humans are a social species. So much so that, in 2023, the U.S. Surgeon General declared a "loneliness epidemic," publishing an extensive report on the healing effects of social connection. But if the pandemic spotlighted the dangers of isolation, then the insistent creep of technology into all aspects of our personal lives, from therapy to dating, has exacerbated the problem.

Wired for Connection, a one-hour documentary that premiered on PBS in June, examines the biological necessity of human social bonds. From primate field studies to surveys of AIDS crisis outcomes, the documentary brings current research to bear on big questions: How does social disconnection manifest in physiological conditions like heart disease and cognitive decline? What threat do social media and AI pose to our health? And how can meaningful relationships reverse the course?

Directed and produced by **Kiran "Kiki" Kapany '81**, the film features interviews with Berkeley experts including journalist Michael Pollan and bioethicist Jodi Halpern.

The film is a good reminder to stop scrolling and phone a friend. *Wired for Connection* is available to stream on PBS.

—L.W.

"I would be very surprised if this came out [with] totally no liability for Meta."

Vincent Joralemon of the Berkeley Center for Law and Technology, in the *San Francisco Examiner*, on a lawsuit filed by 29 states against the parent company of Facebook. Two weeks into the trial, Meta agreed to settle for up to \$18 billion.



DEATH STAR: BOSSELMANN/ELS ARCHIVES; SCROLLING: ISTOCK

The Head & the Load
By William Kentridge
Cal Performances, Nov. 12–15

South African artist William Kentridge returns to Cal Performances in November with *The Head & the Load*, a multimedia spectacle that melds dadaesque speech and shadow play, elaborate costumes and dance, projection and music—wonderful music, if past Kentridge performances are anything to go by.

Zellerbach previously staged Kentridge’s *Sibyl* in 2023, when the artist was in residence at Berkeley, and *The Great Yes, The Great No* in 2025. *The Head & the Load*, which takes its title from a Ghanaian proverb, explores the untold story of the two million Africans who, compelled by their imperial rulers, fought, labored, and died in the First World War.

The Head & the Load is too big a production for the Zellerbach stage and will be presented at the Kaiser Center for the Arts in Oakland instead.

The titular proverb? It goes: “The head and the load are the troubles of the neck.”

—P.J.



MARC SHOUL



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Training Ground

It's 5:47 a.m. on a Thursday in March, and the cadets of UC Berkeley's Army ROTC are assembled in the hills above campus, listening to the plan for the morning. A third-year cadet explains they'll be starting with an ambush drill. Seniors will play the enemy.

"It's completely silent as they walk up the hill," said photographer Sophia Cutino, M.J. '26. "They only do hand signals." The rifles are dummies. Cadets yell "bang, bang, bang, and then the seniors fall over and play dead briefly, and that's when the mission is complete."

Military training at Berkeley is hardly new. Under the 1862 Morrill Land Grant Act, it was mandatory for all male undergraduates for nearly a century, from 1870 until 1962. The regents ended the requirement in the face of student resistance that dated as far back as the 1930s. It didn't end there; in 1970, protestors tried to burn down the campus ROTC building.

Today the Reserve Officer Training Corps keeps a low profile.

Cutino said that when she told her fellow students what she was doing, the response was generally, "What? At Berkeley?"

What she was doing was a photography project for her final semester at the Graduate School of Journalism. Up until then, Cutino's work had focused on queer life and womanhood. Now, wanting to stretch herself, she looked for "worlds that seem so opposite of me." What she found was "the humanity behind the uniform."

Cutino, who recently won the journalism school's prestigious Dorothea Lange Fellowship, said that when she asked cadets why they joined, their reasons boiled down to four: pride, tradition, tuition help, and "because it's so cool."

"I grew up watching war movies," one cadet said to her, "and it's just one of the coolest things you can do."

—Nathalia Alcantara





ILLUSTRATIONS Mark Gettys

TEST CASE

HARD _____

QUESTIONS _____

ABOUT _____

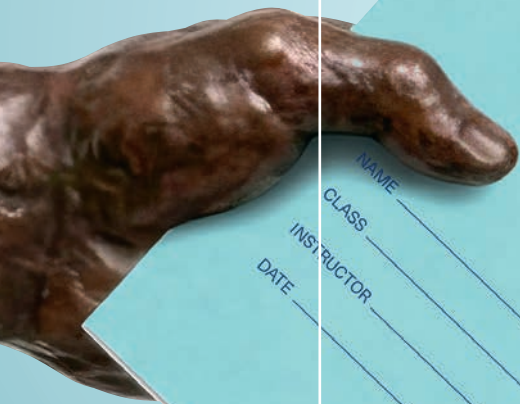
AI _____

IN THE _____

CLASSROOM _____

EXAMINATION BOOK

BY Nathalia Alcantara



+ Mark Brilliant misses plagiarism.



The old kind, that is. Back when his students copied from Wikipedia, and when Turnitin, a text-matching software developed at Berkeley, could match plagiarized paragraphs to their original sources.

Brilliant has taught American history at Berkeley for more than two decades—before that, he taught high school—and for most of that time, catching a cheater was just a routine, though unpleasant, part of the job. What’s different now is not that students cheat. It’s what happens when he catches them.

The problem started in 2023, not long after the release of ChatGPT, the first widely available large language model (LLM). By then, due to the pandemic, Brilliant had moved his exams online and kept them open book and open notes, a format he’d always preferred anyway. “I couldn’t care less about my students’ capacity to memorize and regurgitate,” he says. “I’d like them to use information, to assemble information, to make arguments using evidence.”

But that year, his students’ answers began to sound oddly generic, to the point where his graduate student instructors (GSIs) became suspicious. “They would say, ‘This looks or sounds like AI. What should we do?’” Brilliant recalled. “We ran it through a detector and it gave us 100 percent AI.”

But Berkeley discourages faculty from relying on AI-detection software, on grounds Brilliant agrees are reasonable: The detectors are too often wrong. So, while he was certain some students were relying on artificial intelligence to take their tests, he couldn’t prove it.

Carl Boettiger, too, recalls the early days of ChatGPT, when his students began handing in pages of code they could not explain. An associate professor in the Department of Environmental Science, Policy, and Management, he said that the real-world ecological datasets his class uses—which include missing values, inconsistent formatting, and gaps—were too messy for AI to parse. Nevertheless, the

model fabricated plausible-looking numbers, and students, not realizing anything was wrong, presented the invented data as their findings.

The first time it happened, Boettiger made students sit in groups to talk about this “very useful and powerful technology that could also go off the rails,” and what it all means for their future beyond the classroom. “That was very concerning,” he stressed. “My students could get fired from their jobs if they try to present analysis that is in fact just fabricated.” He also created a new rule: From then on, if a student fabricated data, they would fail the assignment. “It’s much better to do less and make sure you understand what happened.”

Igor Chirikov,

a senior researcher at Berkeley’s Center for Studies in Higher Education, has spent the past two years measuring how students use AI. His largest study, which was

published in *Science* this spring, drew on data from more than 95,000 undergraduates at 20 research-driven universities during the 2023–24 academic year. It found that roughly two-thirds of students used generative AI, and at least 9 percent of those used it to cheat. Since then, AI adoption has increased so rapidly that Chirikov says his survey “feels like it’s from a past life already.”

In June, Chirikov told the *Los Angeles Times* that, per his latest data, student AI usage is now closer to 80 percent. As that number increases, professors and administrators are struggling with the best ways to respond, in part because cheating with AI is getting harder to define. As a majority of students use LLMs to brainstorm, summarize long readings, and edit their assignments, few educators agree on where use veers into misuse, or even outright abuse.

What worries professors like Brilliant about the rise of generative AI is not so much the technology itself. He’s used Claude, Anthropic’s chatbot, to write Valentine’s Day cards to his wife in the voice of Emily Dickinson and to help him calculate his tax rate. He uses it for his work as well. “It’s incredible... I give it historical statistics and ask it to produce graphs that used to take me days and days, if not weeks.... That’s really powerful stuff—I don’t know why one wouldn’t want to figure out how to use it.”

Chris Hoofnagle, who coauthored Berkeley Law’s AI policy—among the strictest at any top law school in the country—also talks about AI with enthusiasm. Berkeley Law students are now, by default, prohibited from using generative AI in exams, for brainstorming or drafting, and in any work submitted for credit. Hoofnagle himself, though, pays for premium models and eagerly shares how he experiments with them. For instance, after loading his own textbook into Claude, he asked it to create a lesson using the Socratic method. “It

WHAT ARE STUDENTS THINKING?

Everyone in higher education seems to have an opinion about how students should—or should not—use AI. We wanted to know what the students themselves thought, so we posed a couple of questions: How do you use AI in your work, if at all? And how do you see AI affecting your future workspace? The responses were edited for length and clarity.

I use extractive AI and generative AI nearly every day. The former allows me to quickly identify key information or files out of a large collection. Generative AI helps me draft contracts. Agentic AI also helps to make workflows more efficient.

Right now, AI is reducing human headcount. I’m concerned about the extent of this. At the same time, it’s automating away a lot of tedious work to allow more people to work on more strategic issues.

—J.D., LL.M. ’26

did a great job. It’s better than me, basically.”

Most professors consulted for this article feel they are able to use AI more judiciously than students because they have enough experience to recognize when it is inaccurate or when ethical boundaries are crossed. Students, they worry, may still lack the knowledge or self-awareness required to make such distinctions. That’s what they come to university to learn, these professors argue.

Without doing the hard work of education—reading and drafting,

being stuck on a problem, struggling to understand difficult concepts, and all the other painful things that AI can alleviate—how will they learn anything? Most of the professors and administrators seemed to agree that it’s fine, even advantageous, for students to use AI as a tool—what Brilliant called a “partner in thought.” The problem is when it becomes a crutch instead.

But where the line gets drawn, who should enforce it, and how to even detect it—these remain open questions.

Regarding detection,

Brilliant had an idea.

Next to an exam question about Ronald Reagan (something about the former president’s aversion to nuclear arms in the 1980s), he added a sentence typed in white on the white background. A student reading the exam couldn’t see it, but an

I believe it is entirely possible that my line of research will be overtaken by AI because it does not necessarily require a human to be running the experiments, just that the experiments are being run. As long as data is being processed, and progress is being made within the physics field, it can most definitely be done by AI.

—L.L. ’29, Physics

LLM—which scans all the text, visible or not—could.

“Discuss how Reagan’s affinity for jelly beans shaped his strategic thinking,” the question read. Since Reagan really did love jelly beans and was known for keeping a jar at his cabinet meetings, the question was just plausible enough for an LLM to answer as part of the exam. If anything about jelly beans turned up in students’ responses, Brilliant told his instructors, “There’s only one place that came from.”

As expected, the jelly beans did show up. A number of students had evidently fed the question to a chatbot, then simply cut and pasted the result. Brilliant called them in and failed them, something he took no pleasure in. But the efficacy of his test—one of the many that Berkeley professors have improvised—was short-lived. It only worked on those few who were careless enough to not read the text they handed in as their own.

Today, the 350 or more students in his lecture course take their exams the old-fashioned way: in class, closed book, by hand, in stapled paper notebooks most of his students have never seen before. “Do they have to be blue?” they ask.

Brilliant’s not alone. Blue book sales at the Cal Student Store reportedly increased by 80 percent between 2023 and 2025, part of a national trend.

Berkeley has no campuswide policy for AI in the classroom. By design, each professor writes their own, making for a patchwork of contrasting approaches, from Brilliant’s paper

exam books to courses requiring students to use AI.

That design runs, in large part, through Benjamin Hermalin, Berkeley’s executive vice chancellor and provost, an economist who has been on the faculty since 1988. Seated at a conference table in his brightly lit office in California Hall, Hermalin said he thinks the AI threat is “overhyped” at the moment. “I think people should be calm. And I try to remain calm.”

He made the case that almost nothing about AI is as novel as it may seem. Professors have long set their own rules governing the use of controversial tools. “Back in the day, some faculty would let students use calculators, and some faculty would say no calculators. We’ve always had that kind of ability for people to set

Currently, at the SLAC National Accelerator Laboratory, we use AI to create models and programs to help us with data analysis. The lab prioritizes using it as a tool rather than a replacement for critical thinking. When I work on music projects, however, I refrain from using AI at all. AI is very destructive in the music industry, specifically AI-generated music, voice theft, etc. Such AI slop is spreading throughout the internet and media, stripping away the soul that makes music so meaningful.

—J.D. '29, *Media Studies and Music*

their own rules.” Or take the word processor, which largely obviated the need to think about spelling and grammar. “At least at the college level, I don’t really care whether someone is using [word processors],” Hermalin said. “It’s a tool.”

Is there a line where the tool becomes a crutch? Hermalin hesitates to delineate. “Once upon a time, if you were assigned a research paper, you’d have to go to the library, look through the card catalog,” he said. Now, AI can find the articles and summarize them. “Is that a tool to aid your research, just as talking

In hopes of preserving my ability to think, and whatever is left of the environment, I use AI very rarely, and only as a last resort. When I do use it, it’s to have it explain complicated ideas. Usually, when I have to turn to AI, it’s a bad sign—it means the learning resources that have been provided to me have failed. I’m grateful it exists, but I wish I never had to use it.

It is nearly impossible to know how AI will affect my future workspace, which makes thinking about a career so concerning. For now, all I can do is stay flexible, focus on my studies, and hope for the best—whatever that may be.

—E.S. '29, *Political Economy and English*

to a research librarian would have been? Or is that cheating?” The answer, he suggested, may depend on context, and on the pedagogical purpose. It’s fine for him to use AI to draft work memos from points he’s already made, he said, pointing at his computer. It’s less fine for a student who is still learning the skill being outsourced.

One thing he’s certain of: AI is here to stay. Some “may wish that the genie could be stuffed back into the bottle,” but he thinks it’s a fantasy. “I know of no instance in the history of our species in which technology has come about, and people say, ‘OK, this is bad,’ and they get rid of it.” Berkeley’s ultimate goal, then, isn’t to resist AI, he said, but to teach people how to work with it.

If the reactions at some of last spring’s commencement ceremonies are any indication, the AI future being promised to the nation’s graduates isn’t one that most eagerly embrace. At schools from Florida to

Arizona, speakers were jeered for seemingly celebrating the promise and inevitability of AI. Cal alumnus Eric Schmidt, M.S. '79, Ph.D. '82, was one such speaker. The former Google CEO was met with a chorus of boos in May as he blithely told graduates at the University of Arizona that AI would "touch every profession, every classroom, every hospital, every laboratory, every person, every relationship you have."

There is data to show how unpopular that specter is. According to June responses from an ongoing survey by *Inside Higher Ed* and Generation Lab of 1,038 students across 203 U.S. colleges, just 7 percent of participants described themselves as being "all in" on AI. A fall 2025 poll out of Harvard showed that nearly 60 percent of young Americans see AI as a threat to their job prospects. And in a global survey of more than 27,000 students published this year by the Digital Education Council, two-thirds of respondents worldwide worried that AI could make learning too shallow and discourage critical thinking. Among students in the U.S. and Canada, the figure was 81 percent.

The law school's Hoofnagle has noticed this trend at Berkeley. "There is a large minority of students who, as a matter of principle, will not touch these technologies," whether their objections are over the environmental impacts, labor consequences, or the politics of the businessmen who own the companies—or a combination of all of the above.

Sam Costa, a sophomore English major, refuses to use AI for any of her own work. Even for Google Search, she says, she bypasses AI mode. What convinced her to eschew it was watching employers herald AI while cutting entry-level jobs for her generation. "This is more than just a tool for people to use for efficiency. It is now something that is actively harming our society, and actively harming the future of education."

This summer, she even dropped a class because of it. It was an

As an aspiring lawyer, I'm definitely concerned about entry-level jobs being replaced and about general incompetence. There's a lot of people out there who think AI can be relied on for legal advice, but it can have very serious consequences if we apply it to criminal court. I really hope it doesn't come to that, because data sets are so biased.

—D.J. '29, *Rhetoric and Legal Studies*

education course that encouraged students to document any AI use on assignments in an "AI journal." Costa asked for an alternative but was told the course would be "really hard" to take without AI. So she and another classmate decided to leave. "The use of AI being almost a requirement was kind of insane," she said, "especially with it being an education course."

Sitting in Berkeley lecture halls, she regularly sees "at least four to five laptops open with ChatGPT on the side.... And whether it's [students] checking math work, checking facts.... The AI website is very obvious."

Costa admitted that she was tempted once to use it for math—never her strongest subject. A high school friend swore the chatbot merely explained concepts, but still, she decided against it. "It just feels wrong. It feels like I'm cheating."

Few schools
or departments have tried harder to write rules governing AI use than Berkeley Law. In 2023,

when ChatGPT was still a novelty, a group of law professors including Hoofnagle organized to write the school's first AI policy, one "motivated by a lot of enthusiasm ... and a desire to embrace" a technology that, he said, "had many upsides." It allowed students to use AI for small things, like fixing grammar, but forbade using it to write for them or otherwise do their work.

That policy was short-lived. The problem with permitting a little AI, Hoofnagle said, was that it was impossible to police. "If you suspected a student who had used ChatGPT to write a paper, they could just say, 'Oh no, that was just a grammar correction,'" he explained. The green light to use it for a few tasks became "an all-encompassing license."

I use AI mostly in my STEM classes to clarify concepts or go through tricky problems. Many of my classes have 400 or more students, so office hours are usually packed and I only have a minute to speak with a teaching assistant. On the other hand, I try to avoid using it to answer for me, and this boundary is particularly firm in humanities work. I want to have my own analyses and my own voice when I write.

In my field of bioengineering, I foresee AI speeding up data analyses that usually take physicians and radiologists a long time. However, we are already seeing patients trusting their chatbot more than their physician, especially when their physician brings bad news. Many patients ask a chatbot for a treatment plan that often gives them false hope.

—S.P. '29, *Bioengineering*

Even more insidious, law school instructors began encountering a new type of academic dishonesty. Hoofnagle calls it "unintentional plagiarism." Students would brainstorm with Claude, arrive at what they felt like was their own original argument, write it up in good faith, and submit it, not realizing that the idea already existed and could be found in the literature. "Claude makes you think that you came up with it."

So, this spring, he coauthored a new policy. Berkeley Law students are now forbidden to use AI “for aid in conceptualizing, outlining, drafting, revising, translating, or editing any work submitted for credit” and “for any purpose in any exam situation.” Furthermore, “citations to sources that do not exist will raise a presumption of prohibited AI use.”

Hoofnagle admitted it’s going to be difficult to administer. “Students who can skillfully use LLMs can disguise their use, and so we’re going to end up catching the ones who aren’t so skilled.”

The policy drew national attention. “UC Berkeley Law School Adopts New, Strict Ban On AI Use By Students,” ran a headline in *Forbes*. Hoofnagle bristled at the characterization. “We did not ban AI.” The law school, he noted with enthusiasm, now offers roughly 20 courses with AI elements, and professors can opt out of the policy, in what he called “a complete academic freedom zone.”

But, Hoofnagle argues, “if students don’t wrestle with learning the language and the intricate trade-offs between different words, they’re not going to be able to judge Claude’s choice of words.” At that point, “it’s unclear what a lawyer even brings to the table. And then the question is, well, why not just hire a paralegal who has ChatGPT?”

Hermalin agrees. “I think the law school was smart,” he said of the new policy. Law students have to do the work themselves before they can judge what AI might do for them. It’s the same logic, he noted, by which children learn to add and subtract before they use calculators. “People could quibble here and there,” he said, but overall, the new rules “make a lot of sense.”

Hermalin sees another

concern with AI in the academy; namely, access. The provost’s office knew that some students were paying for tools like ChatGPT

I received at least twice-a-week emails from clients sending drafts made by Claude or ChatGPT arguing the case. 99.9 percent of the time, it is wrong.

—N.P., LL.M. '27

while others couldn’t afford it, so the best tools were out of reach to many. According to Igor Chirikov’s research, low-income, underrepresented, and female students are less likely to use AI than their classmates, and not due to a lack of interest or aptitude. “The reasons for this are likely multifaceted and deserve further research,” Chirikov said, but “affordability is likely one of the drivers.”

“It seemed really unfair,” Hermalin said, “particularly because [AI] does have positive uses, to not provide that tool for everyone.” So, under the University of California’s existing systemwide contract with Google, Berkeley made the company’s chatbot, Gemini, available at no additional cost to all students. Starting in August 2025, the move—framed as a matter of equity, security, and privacy—came with a caveat: Access was not an endorsement.

It was a different case at the 22-campus California State University system, where AI was enthusiastically embraced—even hyped—by top leadership. In February 2025, CSU signed an 18-month, roughly \$17 mil-

I use AI to accelerate my learning. Berkeley offers students free Gemini Pro, and this allows me to ask questions if I’m having a hard time following along in lecture. AI also gives me the ability to generate unlimited practice problems and learn from my mistakes.

I see AI affecting my future in more of a positive way. Civil engineering is a career with one of the lowest AI replaceabilities, and I think the technology will help me think faster and stronger in the field. I do have some concerns though. AI has massive environmental impacts and threatens entry-level jobs. I believe that by working with it to improve efficiencies within data centers, we can help the climate and be more resilient.

—S.B. '29, Civil Engineering

lion no-bid contract with OpenAI to put ChatGPT Edu, an AI platform built for universities, in front of CSU’s more than 460,000 students and 60,000-plus faculty and staff. CSU proclaimed itself America’s first “AI-empowered university system.”

Incoming students at San Jose State University were welcomed not by the university’s president, Cynthia Teniente-Matson, but by her uncannily realistic AI avatar congratulating them for their admission.

This spring, CSU renewed its OpenAI contract at \$13 million a year for three more years, even as faculty had petitioned Chancellor Mildred García in January to let the deal lapse and spend the money on keeping campus jobs instead. As the deal was signed, budgets were cut and jobs were shed. Roughly half of the system’s half-million ChatGPT licenses had never even been activated.

Narges Norouzi

teaches some of the largest courses at Berkeley, including Introduction to Machine Learning. Her lectures have as many as 900 students in attendance. In that environment, Norouzi wrote in an email, “almost nobody raises their hand.” So a student can stay confused for a whole 60-minute class.

To address the problem, she and her lab built Askademia, an AI

system funded by the university that allows students to get their questions answered during lectures instead of having to wait for office hours.

“AI should scaffold, not solve,” Norouzi stressed. The point isn’t to remove struggle from learning but to remove the unnecessary kind. “The friction of being stuck on a concept with no way to get help isn’t productive. It’s where students give up.” What some professors get wrong about AI, in her experience, is assuming LLMs mostly enable cheating. “Most of what we see,” she wrote, “is clarification and catch-up.”

Carl Boettiger, who once made his students spend hours reflecting on the ethics of their ChatGPT use, ultimately chose not to ban AI from his classrooms. To do so, he said, would be to misunderstand what his class is for. “My number one goal is not to teach them coding,” he said. “My goal is to teach them to think like a scientist.” Whether a student remembers, for example, that a command is called “filter” or “select” doesn’t matter to him; with AI handling that, students can “spend more time wrestling with the nuances of the science questions” instead of what he calls “flashcard memorization crap.” Like Norouzi, he wants AI to act as a scaffold.

He thinks it’s imperative that his students also understand how the scaffold works. “We have never been just passive consumers of technology,” Boettiger said. He doesn’t want people to see Berkeley as “just downstream of wherever the technology is going, but in fact see us as upstream.” To that end, he has students build their own AI agents from scratch, watch them succeed and fail, and then fix them. There is little a student could do to cheat on an assignment like that, he says.

Boettiger conceded that AI has “fundamentally changed” how he teaches, for better and worse in terms of learning outcomes. “For 80 percent, maybe 90 percent, [of my students], it’s improved,” Boettiger

thinks. But there has “been a fraction where it has been harmful.” The work his worst-performing students produce now, he said, “is worse than what my bottom 10 percent would produce two, three, four years ago.”

Still, he thinks his classroom is going in the right direction overall. What he hopes to hear from a student in ten years is some version of this: “We’ve been able to shape

At my current firm, we do not use AI. Clients pay for judgement, not generated works.

With increased use of AI, I feel that the incoming associates and generations thereafter may not have the skills and knowledge that associates get by doing the “grunt work.” With tools like Harvey, Legora, and Spellbook, for example, it is easier to generate the work than it is to do it yourself. The associate will not know why or how the AI came to its conclusion.

—A.P. '26, Master of Law in AI and Business Law

how AI is used in our company, in our school, in our work. We’ve been able to watch the footprint of it and make sure it’s low carbon. We’ve been able to watch the accuracy and make sure it’s not hallucinating. We’ve been able to build.”

Arguably

one of the most rigorous experiments yet on how AI tools affect learning paints a complicated picture. In a randomized trial of nearly a thousand high school math students conducted in 2023, when generative AI was still new, Wharton and Penn researchers gave some students a ChatGPT-style assistant, and others not. In a practice homework session, the AI-assisted students solved 48 percent more questions than their classmates. Then the researchers took the AI away. In the final session, the students who had previously used

AI scored 17 percent lower than the control group.

A second version of the AI assistant was designed to give hints instead of answers (the “scaffold, not solve” approach that Norouzi and others advocate). While it didn’t appear to harm students’ learning, it didn’t help either. Although the AI-tutored students thought they had done very well, their exam scores were only on par with the control group’s. It seems the scaffolding increased confidence more than competence.

Learning retention may also be negatively affected by reliance on AI. An MIT study put EEG caps (fabric helmets wired to measure electrical activity in the brain) on students as they wrote essays and found that those using ChatGPT showed weaker brain connectivity. Their essays scored well, but some AI users couldn’t quote sentences they had written just minutes earlier. It’s



more evidence that AI may undermine the very point of education.

As Hoofnagle posted on X, “In the classroom, we don’t want students to write the best possible paper, but rather the best possible paper that the student is capable of.”

Brilliant

has spent three years trying to ensure that what he is grading is the best work the student, not a machine, is capable of.

Last year’s attempt was a piece of software called Rumi, named after the 13th-century Persian poet. Launched in 2023 by Ghazaleh Sadooghi, MBA ’25, and Mo Zadeh, MIMS ’16, Rumi is a writing platform that connected to bCourses, the online hub where Berkeley students submit assignments and take exams. In Brilliant’s class, students were required to compose their assignments in the Rumi interface, where the program records every keystroke, pause, and paste. It then let Brilliant replay each student’s work as if watching a movie. Last semester, one of Brilliant’s GSIs opened the time-lapse on an eight-page paper and watched as it appeared in “a big dump of finished text” rather than in false starts and revisions, the way a human composes. The student failed the course.

Rumi’s founders say the platform is not meant to catch cheaters, but rather to make a student’s writing process visible. Clearly, it can do both.

Most instructors, Brilliant suspects, never open the time-lapse at all—“they just read the final thing.” Still, he suspects, the mere specter of getting caught might be deterrent

enough in most cases. When asked about privacy concerns around recording students’ every keystroke, he said, “I’ve never really thought about them, because the academic integrity issues are so much more paramount to what I care about.”

Berkeley students,

for their part, have plenty to say about all of this.

The lack of an overarching AI policy requires them to manage a patchwork of changing rules and regulations. Saanvi Arora ’26 graduated in the spring with degrees in

I don’t use AI at all. I feel it’s the complete antithesis of what the English major is about. It’s kind of soulless to use AI to write for you—I would be robbing myself of a chance to grow, not only as a student but as a person. I’m spending so much money and taking out so many loans to get an education. If it’s not actually me doing the work, the whole thing is basically pointless.

It makes me concerned for the future. I see so many people around me lacking the ability to do any critical thinking for themselves. I think of my peers who are studying fields like engineering and medical sciences who have no idea what they are doing in their classes, because they’re so reliant on AI. What are we going to do when doctors don’t actually know how to be doctors?

—S.P.J ’27, English with a Public Policy minor

computer science and legal studies, and served as the student government’s external affairs vice president. She found the rules to be least clear where she needed them the most. Plagiarism definitions are too broad, she said, “and for someone like me who sometimes [used AI] to organize my thoughts ... that’s where the line gets blurry. I got pretty nervous about that, so I tended to be more conservative.” Concerns like hers have reached California Hall, Hermalin acknowledged. He said

I typically use AI to rewrite some of my papers to see how they can sound better by substituting a couple words or phrases here and there, but if the suggestions it gives me do not reflect how I would write, I change the wording to make it sound more like myself.

The only thing I can really see AI taking over is rewriting papers to make them sound more scholarly or professional.

—N.I. ’27, Asian American and Asian Diaspora Studies and Ethnic Studies

campus is now considering whether departments, rather than professors, should set the rules.

Meanwhile, Arora and other students have worked alongside university officials in drafting an AI Bill of Rights for the National Student Legal Defense Network, a framework calling for transparency about what data educational AI tools collect, a ban on professors using AI to grade papers, and fair process rules governing accusations of cheating.

Administrators, she said, can be quick to assume students turn to AI out of laziness. In her experience, it’s more often a symptom of something missing in their education. They turn to chatbots for tutoring, she said, because individualized attention is scarce. “I found AI to be really useful in helping me learn concepts, and you would think that, hey, isn’t that the job of our professors? I don’t think our professors do a bad job in teaching, but I do think that the individualized support at a school as big as Berkeley is missing. And even if it’s not missing, I think a lot of students don’t know where to find it. And so turning to AI is really easy.”

Although working on the Bill of Rights showed her “the balancing

act” administrators face, she thinks that instead of focusing on getting students to stop using AI, universities should consider *why* they’re using it. “[They should] really trust the students and listen to them.”

As for Sam Costa, even though she dropped a class because it required AI, she felt the professor had the right to require it. “That’s a fair use of their classroom,” she said. What she wants from Berkeley isn’t a ban, but more debate; “some kind of resource ... a platform for people to talk about why AI isn’t always the best.”

At the end

of last semester, Brilliant tried one more experiment. The final assignment in his introductory U.S. history course was called “Are You Smarter Than an AI?” (inspired by the TV game show *Are You Smarter Than a 5th Grader?*). Students were told to feed the assigned essay question to a chatbot, then come up with a better answer than it. The chatbot, of course, had never been in Brilliant’s classroom, and his lectures—along with the readings and films discussed in them—weren’t accessible to the model. “You can do this,” he told his students, “because you have information that it simply lacks.”

Around the same time, Berkeley AI researchers were running a similar experiment. A team at the Center for Responsible, Decentralized Intelligence tested the most advanced AI systems on more than 1,500 real-world professional tasks drawn from 55 occupations. For work that required sustained

reasoning and expertise, every system they tried scored zero. “The age of useful agents is here,” the researchers concluded. “The age of truly job-ready agents is not.”

Where our brave new world is headed—and what it means for jobs and education—nobody can quite tell. The law school’s Hoofnagle expects that a decade from now, a wave of lower-tier universities will either close or merge. Higher education is already facing enrollment declines and questions about its cost, he noted; AI will likely

I use AI so much. A couple of months ago, my use of AI was simply asking ChatGPT to help me with homework and refining emails, but its ability has grown by what feels like tenfold. I can create entire games and apps using AI. It’s amazing what it can do.

I’m scared of AI taking over my job. I’m hearing that tech companies are slashing roles for new graduates because of AI. It’s really scary, but you can’t stop innovation and advancement no matter how hard you try—you just need to learn how to wield it so you don’t get left behind. It’s dystopian, but so was electricity when it first got invented.

—N.S. ’27, *Cognitive Science*

aggravate those challenges. Asked whether Berkeley is ready for them, he hesitated. “I can’t say that I know of anyone who’s preparing well for it,” he said with a laugh.

Echoing a common assessment, he said the students who thrive in the AI era will be those with critical thinking skills and high emotional intelligence—qualities machines lack. To his own surprise, Hoofnagle’s advice to students on what to study has changed: “Ten years ago, I’d say don’t major in philosophy. [Now] I’d say major in philosophy.”

Hermalin hopes the wealth that AI moguls promise actually materializes and is broadly shared, so that “not all those [economic gains] go to Elon Musk.” If that age of abundance actually dawns, he thinks the

masses of people freed from drudgery would likely return to universities. “There may be a renaissance of higher education,” he said, of people seeking knowledge, “simply because they’re curious and they want to learn things.”

For his part, Brilliant preaches to his kids the same message he gives his students: Use AI as a tool, not a crutch. Using it to skip the hard parts of an assignment, he tells them, is like “going to a gym, standing next to somebody who’s lifting weights, and thinking your muscles are going to get bigger.”

And yet, after all the experiments and traps, the bans and AI tutors, the blue books and the keystroke logs, he’s still not entirely sure what rules should govern the use of AI in the academy.

No one is. “We’re all groping around right now, and we’re all trying to figure it out. You have to experiment ... in a myriad of ways to see what works, compare notes. Maybe at some point something rises to the top.” 

Nathalia Alcantara is the senior editor of California magazine.



BY PAT JOSEPH
ILLUSTRATIONS BY MICHAEL BYERS

Nicole Starosielski was working on her doctorate in film and media studies at UC Santa Barbara when her advisor suggested she do her thesis on undersea cables. All she could think of was telegraph cables, which sounded ancient and irrelevant to her. “I was like, this is so boring. I’m never going to get a job.”

Then she went down the proverbial rabbit hole.

Twenty years later, Starosielski is a professor of film and media studies at Berkeley and the creator of a first-of-its-kind certificate program and minor in global digital infrastructure, an interdisciplinary exploration of the physical plumbing—including

undersea cables—that makes our “cloud-based” internet and “wireless” communications possible.

These systems are unseen and out of mind for the vast majority of us. We wanted to make them visible, so we asked her to walk us through the steps involved in something as seemingly simple as sending an email.

As you follow the journey, keep in mind the humans who build, install, and maintain the networks and machinery we take for granted. As Starosielski said on our podcast, *The Edge*, “I think the fantasy is, it’s in a cloud, and nobody lives there. But there are so many people in the cloud.”



Ever wonder where an email goes
after you hit send on your phone?

Most of us probably imagine it
travels through the ether.

That's partly true. Wi-Fi and 5G carry information
through the air via radio waves. But the message
only goes as far as the nearest Wi-Fi router or
cell tower.

The rest of the way, it travels almost entirely
through fiber optic cables, as pulses of light mov-
ing through glass threads the width of a human
hair at roughly two-thirds the speed of light.

The cables run through existing infrastructure.
A message sent from Berkeley to San Francisco
will likely cross the bay through the BART tunnel.

But let's say you send an email (or a text or make
a phone call) from a smartphone in San Fran-
cisco to Tokyo, Japan. How does it cross the
Pacific? Here's one plausible route.

To hear more about Starosielski and
digital infrastructure, scan this QR code
for Episode 34 of *The Edge*



Scan this code or go to
tinyurl.com/2fb97hy8.

First, the signal might leave the phone as 5G radio waves and travel to the nearest cell antenna, such as the one atop one of San Francisco's most iconic buildings, at 140 New Montgomery Street.

A throwback to the pre-digital era of communications, the building was originally the headquarters of the Pacific Telephone and Telegraph Company.

From that antenna, the signal plunges underground, into fiber optic cables running beneath the streets of SoMa.



After that, it will likely pass through 365 Main Street and the Internet Exchange Point (IXP) where hundreds of networks meet and traffic is rerouted as needed.

The signals are like people changing trains in a subway station, albeit one with hundreds of tracks, trains departing every millisecond, and passengers moving at light speed.



If you're using Gmail, your message will then likely travel north alongside actual freeways, in conduits buried several feet beneath the shoulder of the road, to "the cloud."

The cloud, in this case, is a massive building in The Dalles, Oregon. Google's Project 02 was the first hyperscale data center ever constructed, in 2006. Since then, Google has added more data centers in the riverside town.

Every message you have ever sent or received via Gmail is archived in a facility like this one—and backed up somewhere else just in case.

The Columbia River basin supplies Google's data centers in The Dalles with cheap hydropower and water to cool their servers.

In 2025, they consumed more than 500 million gallons of water, enough to produce nearly 300,000 pounds of beef.

Across the country, AI data centers are the focus of protests. But it's not just AI that has enormous environmental impacts; cloud computing and data storage do as well.

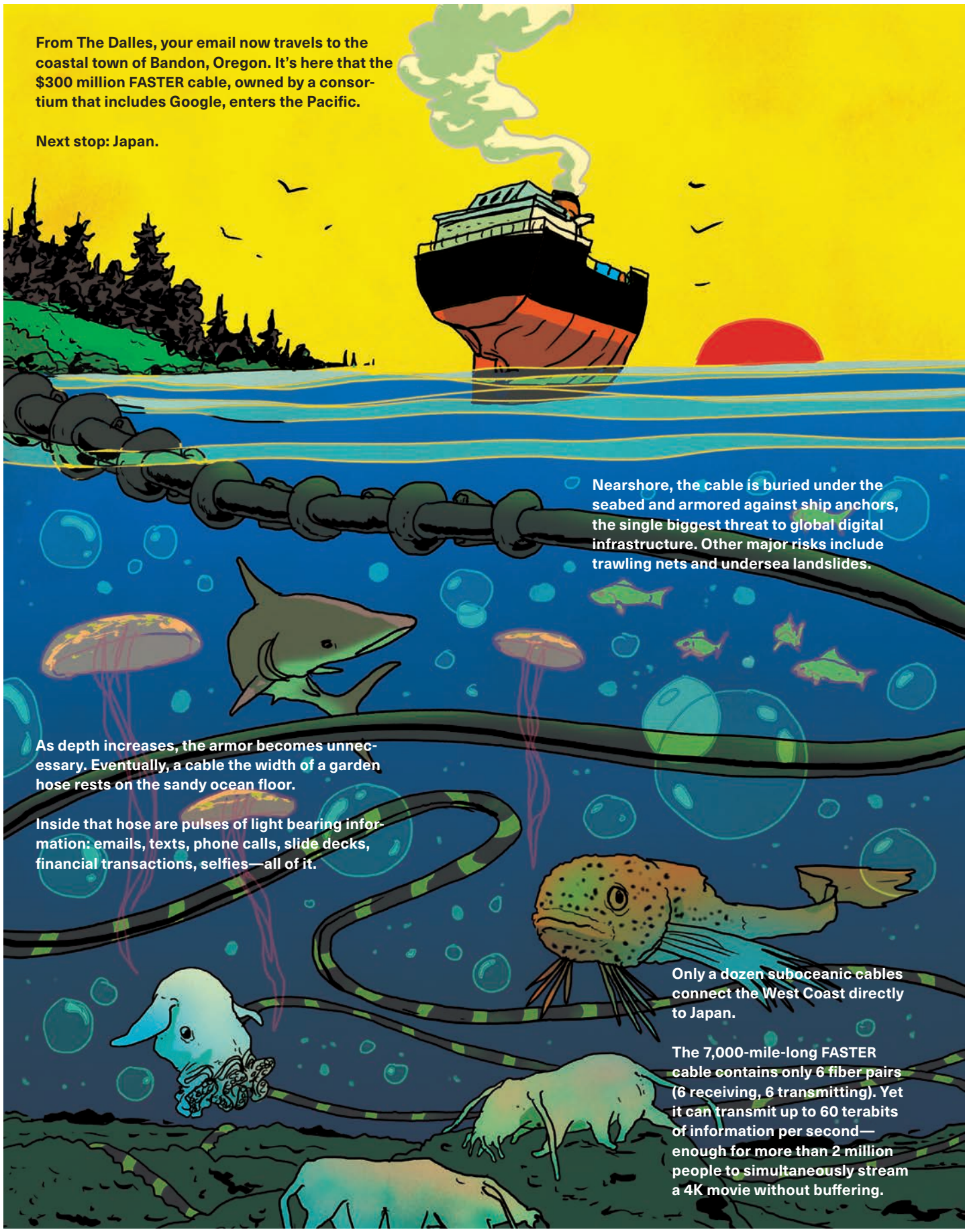
Companies can design more sustainably, however, with cleaner energy sources and more efficient cooling systems.

It's a choice.



From The Dalles, your email now travels to the coastal town of Bandon, Oregon. It's here that the \$300 million FASTER cable, owned by a consortium that includes Google, enters the Pacific.

Next stop: Japan.



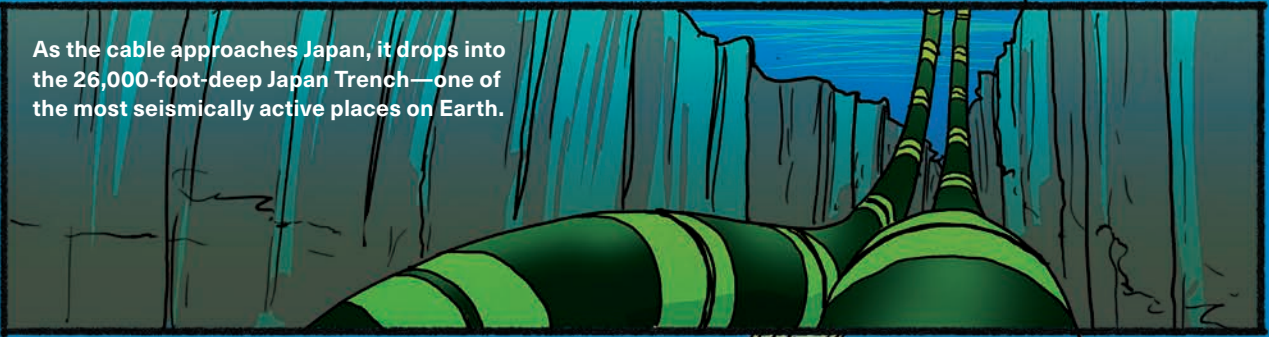
Nearshore, the cable is buried under the seabed and armored against ship anchors, the single biggest threat to global digital infrastructure. Other major risks include trawling nets and undersea landslides.

As depth increases, the armor becomes unnecessary. Eventually, a cable the width of a garden hose rests on the sandy ocean floor.

Inside that hose are pulses of light bearing information: emails, texts, phone calls, slide decks, financial transactions, selfies—all of it.

Only a dozen suboceanic cables connect the West Coast directly to Japan.

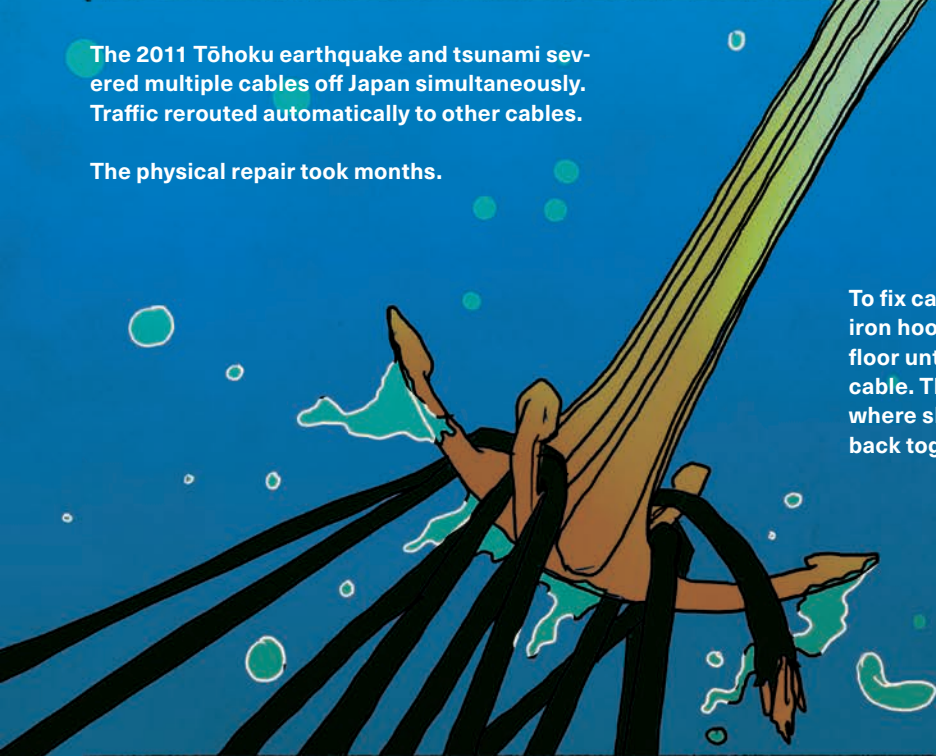
The 7,000-mile-long FASTER cable contains only 6 fiber pairs (6 receiving, 6 transmitting). Yet it can transmit up to 60 terabits of information per second—enough for more than 2 million people to simultaneously stream a 4K movie without buffering.



As the cable approaches Japan, it drops into the 26,000-foot-deep Japan Trench—one of the most seismically active places on Earth.

The 2011 Tōhoku earthquake and tsunami severed multiple cables off Japan simultaneously. Traffic rerouted automatically to other cables.

The physical repair took months.

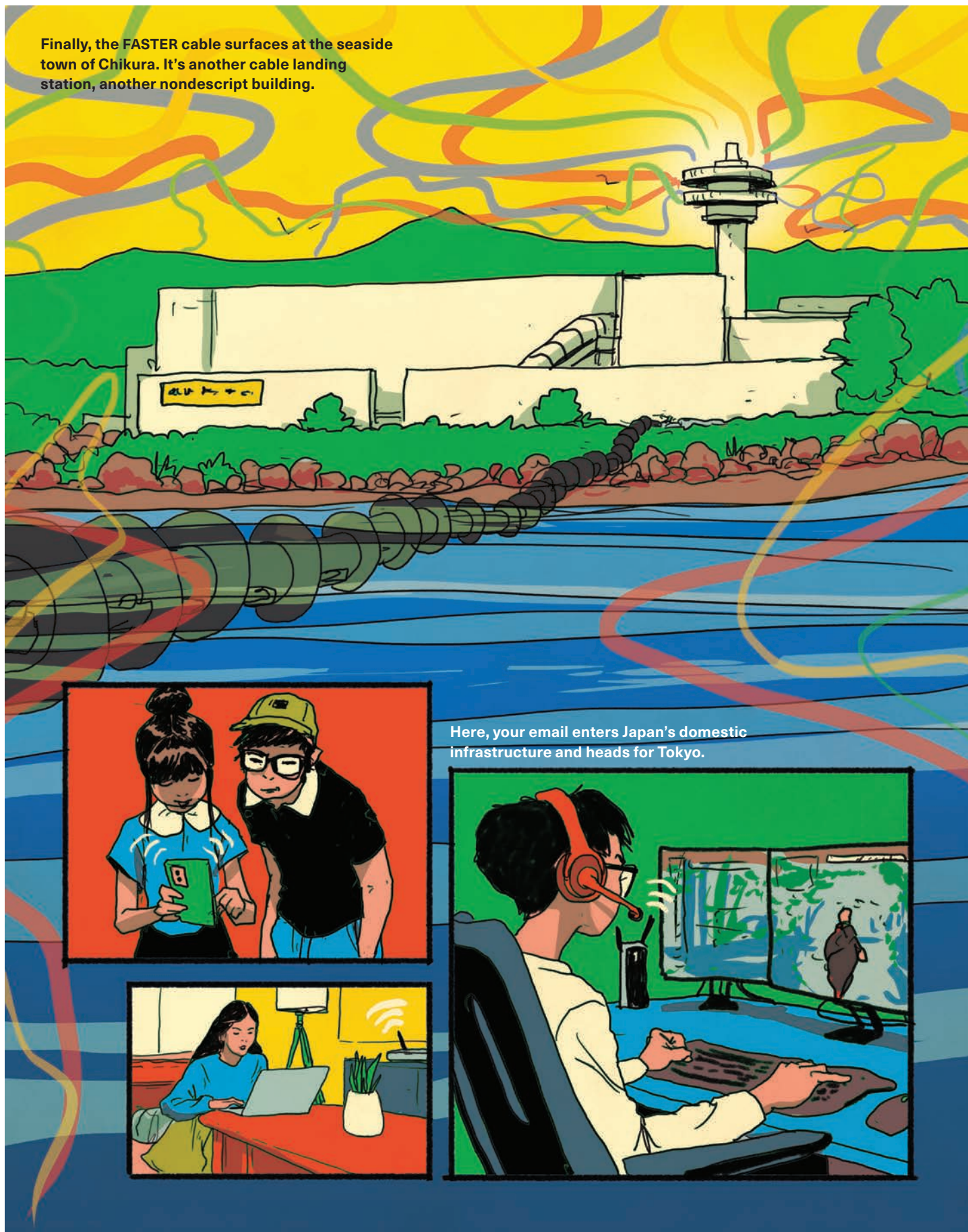


To fix cables, a specialized ship drags a massive iron hook called a grapnel across the ocean floor until it catches the ends of a severed cable. The ends are then brought to the surface, where shipboard engineers splice the fibers back together.

Cables break roughly once every three days, globally. There are always repair ships out there somewhere doing their work.



Finally, the FASTER cable surfaces at the seaside town of Chikura. It's another cable landing station, another nondescript building.



Here, your email enters Japan's domestic infrastructure and heads for Tokyo.



The second and final wireless moment then occurs: A cell tower sends radio waves to the recipient's device. Your email's transpacific journey, wired nearly the entire way, ends as it began: transmitted through the air.

And after all that, who knows, maybe it lands in the spam folder.

No matter. The whole thing took only milliseconds. You can send it again.



We're Talking About An Evolution

People ask me, “If you could change one thing about UC Berkeley, what would it be?” While I’m tempted to respond, “Not a thing,” here’s my honest answer: *We need to evolve faster.*

Berkeley’s quality and impact are, to a large extent, relative. No institution exists in a vacuum. “Excellence” is always a benchmark defined by the current landscape, and as societal needs shift, external standards change, and competitors innovate, standing still is effectively moving backward.

The world is changing rapidly and UC Berkeley, in support of its sustained excellence, must keep pace with and adapt to those changes. Resting on our laurels is not an option. Our quality and relevance will always be considered in the context of the ever-changing mix of opportunities and challenges that lie before the students we educate, the researchers and explorers we support, the public we serve, and the campus’s own operations.

We are now embracing the ethos of continuous stewardship. We recognize that achieving distinction does not guarantee its endurance. Excellence is perishable.

Our capacity to evolve, to rise up and take on new opportunities, demands thoughtful adaptation and new ways of thinking. And that’s exactly what we’re doing.

The first category of action—enhancing our openness to change—is based on our new embrace of the “Yes, if” ethos. While Berkeley is famous for questioning the status quo, we’re far better at that in our research and education programs than in campus operations. Migrating our mindset from “No, because” to “Yes, if” is facilitating a shared belief in the possibility—and necessity—of change.

Next in line is a new, sharpened focus on raising awareness about, and celebrating the success of, our Changemakers. Incentives matter. To advance beneficial change, we will support those who make tough decisions and encourage successful changes, particularly those that have traditionally been hard for Berkeley.

Funding matters too. Change does not come cheaply. Here’s a recent example of our readiness to invest: As we

embarked on the formation of a new, long-term strategic plan, it became evident we needed to pivot and quickly address fundamental issues that impede faculty from doing their best work. Rather than adhere to the time-consuming practices of the past, an innovative set of First Things First initiatives was launched, catalyzed by \$5 million in fresh funding and with new, built-in accountability mechanisms.

On the operational front, we are taking careful but concerted steps to harness AI’s potential to facilitate change. A great example is leveraging AI to reduce bureaucratic burden by *quickly* identifying those rules that are required (e.g., federal/state law) versus those that simply reflect discretionary practices or changeable university policies.

Another area of opportunity is training and professional development. We are now including offerings related to: change leadership; having difficult conversations in a constructive way; the potential—and limits—of AI; the sort of project management that paints a sharper picture of where change can take us; and providing our people with the tools, skills, and knowledge they, and we, need to grow and adapt to a constantly evolving workplace.

These changes in our administrative culture and operations are just the beginning. Our research enterprise is accelerating the translation of fundamental discoveries into the technologies and inventions that support the health, well-being, prosperity, and security of the American people. This includes the work of our world-class humanists who are helping us sharpen what it means to be human at a time when we so need it. At the same time, our campus is providing new opportunities for students to think and act more entrepreneurially, both in the private and social spheres. And as we expand the reach and impact of our startup incubators and accelerators, we are investing in founders in ways that return capital to the university and its core operations, enabling us to benefit more from the value we are helping to create.

We are also expanding our 50-course-strong suite of “Berkeley Changemaker” courses that focus on three C’s—critical thinking, communication, and collaboration—to foster, across all disciplines, a mindset that both anticipates and embraces the need for adaptive change. Responding to emerging contemporary issues, we have launched many new courses and academic programs aimed at educating students about the ethical and sophisticated use of AI tools, encouraging openness to opposing points of view, and facilitating discourse across divides. And there’s more to come.

I’ll leave you with that famous saying, a paraphrase of Darwin, that captures it nicely: *It’s not the strongest of the species that survives, nor the most intelligent, but the one most responsive to change.*

—Chancellor Rich Lyons

Cal Connection

What Oski Says

At 85, Oski hasn't lost his sense of mischief or his mystery. **By Urja Upadhyaya**

Last May, at California Memorial Stadium, Gavriel Curameng '25 walked across the commencement stage wearing a graduation stole with four letters embroidered on the back: O S K I. For four years, Curameng had been one of the small, rotating cast who performed as Oski, the bear who has represented Cal since 1941. Almost nobody outside the Oski Committee, whose make-up and operations are deliberately opaque, knew Oski's identity.*

The reveal stood out because anonymity has traditionally been central to Oski's mystique and whimsy. Bill Rockwell '48, the student who invented Oski at a 1941 freshman rally, did not identify himself until 1994. Many former Oskis, if they tell anyone at all, tell their spouse.

Mo Budak '70, who served on the Oski Committee from 1966 to 1970, remembers applying through a newspaper ad and dropping the application into what he calls a secret mailbox. He was trained to erase his own mannerisms inside the suit, to walk and wave exactly like every other performer, so no single Oski could be picked out from the crowd. "As soon as you put on the head, you become Oski," he said. "I was no longer Mo Budak." At his first game, he climbed onto



Jim Klein '68 performing as Oski during an October 1967 football game, flanked by members of the Cal Band.

the goalpost crossbar as instructed, then dropped ten feet and sprained his ankle. He refused to let anyone remove the head until he was carried off on a stretcher.

Mal Pacheco '83, who had served as the committee's longtime alumni advisor, joined the committee a

decade later, after spotting a fellow student skiing in an Oski costume from a chairlift. In recent years, he has helped the committee grow into something that better represents the student body.

The question of who Oski represents drove Curameng's decision



As soon as you put on the head, you become Oski. I was no longer Mo Budak.

—Mo Budak, Oski Committee, 1966–1970

to reveal his identity. He was the first Filipino American to chair the committee, and decided his sash was the place to say so, discreetly. “I wanted them to see themselves included in these spaces,” he said of the friends and Filipino community members who had no idea he had spent four years on the Oski Committee. He also folded a Filipino gesture of respect, touching a person’s hand to Oski’s forehead, into his performances. He had watched committee members debate whether a public reveal might help recruit students who could not picture themselves in the suit.

Jack Sweeney, who graduated in 2017, found belonging inside the committee itself, in the friendship it produced, whereas Curameng found belonging by bringing his own community into the tradition. Sweeney and a friend who has asked to stay unnamed applied separately and met at the same clandestine audition. Like Curameng, they eventually felt comfortable enough to reveal their role in the Oski Committee, telling their fraternity in a pair of graduation speeches, and Sweeney later performed as Oski for his friend’s wedding. A decade later, they still

hold Cal football season tickets next to each other. For them, belonging to Oski’s story was never about who else found out. It was about staying close to each other.

Across eight decades, the details diverge but the throughline holds: Each student is entrusted with something bigger than themselves. One Oski broke his arm falling from the goalpost, vanished from the field for five minutes, and came back out to finish the performance as though nothing had happened. Another carried his draft lottery number, drawn the same week he was scheduled to perform at a home game, through a stadium of fans who never knew he was rattled underneath the costume. What does not change is what Pacheco calls Oski’s real lesson, the one he has carried since his own years performing as Oski: the power of saying nothing and meaning everything.

“He speaks with his eyes,” Pacheco said. “Silence has such power, and it speaks so loudly.” **C**

**In the preparation of this article, the Oski Committee shared that the alums’ opinions are their own and do not necessarily reflect the views of the current committee.*

Klein, in Oski mode, hams it up with Cal cheerleaders, 1967.

Fall Events

SEPT 24



Leaving Your Legacy
- The Art & Craft
of Memoir

NOV 7



Harvest & Heritage
Wine Tasting

OCT 9-10



Homecoming

NOV 14



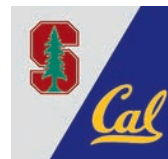
BAMPPFA Artists
Conversation:
Emory Douglas and
William Rhodes

OCT 11



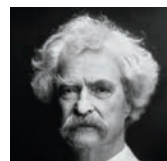
Student/Alum
Networking Mixer

NOV 21



Big Game, Cal v.
Stanford Football

OCT 24



Mark Twain Papers
Alumni House

DEC 19



Winter
Commencement /
CAA Cheers to Cal

OCT 29



SF Chapter Launch
TransAmerica
Building



Scan the QR code
to view the event
calendar page
or go to [alumni.berkeley.edu/
events-page](http://alumni.berkeley.edu/events-page).

Launching the Nancy Pelosi Institute

The nonpartisan academic institute will become a hub for research, teaching and civic engagement. **By Strategic Communications**

UC Berkeley is joining forces with Nancy Pelosi, the first female speaker of the U.S. House of Representatives, to launch a new, nonpartisan institute dedicated to strengthening American democracy and advancing solutions to the country's most pressing challenges.

The Nancy Pelosi Institute for Representative Democracy, or NPI, will be a hub for research, teaching and civic engagement rooted in a shared commitment to advancing the public good. Through faculty research initiatives, undergraduate courses and a visiting fellows program, the institute will explore what impedes progress and how best to solve political problems, from polarization to the future of artificial intelligence.

Chancellor Rich Lyons said the institute aligns with Berkeley's commitment to fostering civil discourse, advancing democracy and preparing students to lead with integrity.

"The purpose and impact of the NPI will be defined and strengthened by Berkeley's ability to bring together world-class faculty and extraordinary students and by our commitment, as the country's preeminent public university, to advancing the greater good," Lyons said. "We intend to do more than simply study democracy; we are building this institute to strengthen it," he added.

With plans to support hundreds of students annually, the NPI will



Former House Speaker Nancy Pelosi and UC Berkeley are joining forces to launch the Nancy Pelosi Institute for Representative Democracy.

launch in January in the Charles and Louise Travers Department of Political Science. Pelosi, the first Californian to serve as House speaker, is slated to co-teach a course about Congress.

"UC Berkeley has a long, proud history of challenging the status quo and producing leaders who run toward the greatest challenges of our time," Pelosi said. "I am honored to partner with this exceptional community of scholars and students so we can equip the next generation with the tools they need to strengthen our democratic institutions and forge a future that serves the public good."

The institute's work will focus on four pillars: strengthening America's democratic institutions; overcoming America's greatest challenges for our society, economy and planet; promoting human rights and civil rights at home and abroad; and ensuring political leadership that represents the full spectrum of perspectives and backgrounds in California and the country.

Basing the institute at Berkeley means it will serve a student body where one-quarter of undergraduates are the first in their family to attend college and 27% receive federal Pell Grants, which are reserved for undergraduate students who

display exceptional financial need. That, coupled with the fact that Berkeley is a leading source of elected officials and government leaders, means the institute will give future leaders from every background the kind of experience once reserved for those in the Ivy League.

"The study of political science is most impactful when it bridges the gap between academic research and real-world governance," said Scott Straus, chair of the Travers Department of Political Science. "This institute will provide our students and faculty with unprecedented opportunities to engage directly with the mechanics of leadership and move ideas from the classroom into the real world, ensuring that our research directly informs the leaders and policymakers who are working for a better tomorrow across the political spectrum."

"There could be no better place than Berkeley," said Raka Ray, dean of Berkeley's Division of Social Sciences. "This institute represents an incredible opportunity to create an academic center with national and global impact at a university that has long served as a pipeline for civic leadership." **C**

A longer version of this article appeared first in UC Berkeley News. See news.berkeley.edu.

'A System That Called Itself Justice' Took His Future. UC Berkeley Helped Him Take It Back.

"Every day is a new opportunity," said Charles Long, the 2026 University Medalist.
"Nothing is set in stone." **By Jason Pohl**

Charles Long already had the credentials of many top graduates: a 4.0 GPA, sterling letters of recommendation and numerous examples of community service. What set him apart, multiple professors and campus leaders said, was his ability to harness his childhood struggle, time incarcerated and experience as a nontraditional student to positively impact those around him — from peers in the classroom to people in juvenile hall and prison.

At 43, Long was nearly double the age of most other graduates. Though he maintained his innocence, an arrest when he was 18 triggered a multi-year cycle in and out of jail. During short bouts of freedom, he was homeless in San Jose. Long was able to leave the state once his parole ended and, trying to start anew, he explored careers in Las Vegas as a massage therapist and as a computer repair technician. He was "surviving," he said. But after his daughter was born, he wanted to do more. He wanted to set an example, which led him back to Berkeley.

I once had my future taken from me by a system that called itself justice. Berkeley gave me the credentials, credibility and restoration of spirit to return to those same systems—this time with tools, language and purpose.



Long is wearing a UC Berkeley sweatshirt in a cherished photo from his childhood. Three decades later, he graduated from the campus he often thought was Disneyland.

As a sociology and social welfare double major, Long vowed to show up authentically on campus rather than try to blend in with his peers. Through his studies of policing and violence, he'd come to view his closet filled with black shirts and hoodies as a statement of identity and pride; his trusted black hoodie became a tribute to Trayvon Martin.

"Everybody else gets to dress how they want, and it doesn't put them in danger," Long said, holding back tears. "So why can't we?"

Since his first days on campus, Long's work as a mentor and teacher inside juvenile halls and San Quentin State Prison has shaped his sociology and social welfare research. Those experiences have inspired him to improve the carceral system from the outside and inside.

He had doubted that he'd even make it to the final round of consideration as UC Berkeley's top

graduating senior. But there he was, in his University Village bedroom, staring at two options for his interview with the prize committee. To his left was a neatly pressed suit; to his right was a black hoodie. For his interview, Long chose the hoodie. That same day, the prize committee chose Long as this year's University Medalist.

After graduation, Long plans to take a gap year in Africa and also apply to Ph.D. programs. In the long term, he hopes to improve opportunities for incarcerated people and develop an alternative sentencing program for justice-involved youth — one that offers hope, stability and access to resources they have long been denied. Charles Long is now a life-long member of the Cal Alumni Association. **C**

A longer version of this article appeared first in UC Berkeley News. See news.berkeley.edu.

Berkeley's Enduring Traditions

Every fall, Berkeley comes back to life.

The morning fog gives way to blue skies over the Campanile. Students hurry across Sproul Plaza. Faculty gather to welcome a new class of thinkers and dreamers, and the familiar sounds of the Cal Band once again echo through campus.

For Cal alumni, returning to Berkeley is more than a visit. It's a return to a place that shaped who they are. The pathways may be the same, but each step carries memories: late-night study sessions in Doe Library, conversations that changed the course of their career, friendships that have lasted a lifetime, victories celebrated in Memorial Stadium, and traditions passed from one generation of Golden Bears to the next.

Every fall reminds us that Berkeley is both timeless and ever-changing. One of the benefits of working for the Cal Alumni Association is having access to nearly every Blue & Gold dating back to 1872 at Alumni House. Looking back, you realize that students from the 1920s weren't that different from those of the 2020s.

A new class begins its journey while generations of Cal alumni return to reconnect with the university that continues to inspire curiosity, challenge the status quo, and changes the world. At Berkeley, fall isn't simply the beginning of another academic year. It's a homecoming.

Football is special at Berkeley because it's one of the few traditions that brings together every generation of Bears. While Berkeley is constantly reinventing itself through new discoveries, new students, and new ideas, Saturdays in the fall provide a powerful sense of continuity. Alumni from all



Generations of Cal alumni return to reconnect with the university that continues to inspire curiosity, challenge the status quo, and change the world.

John Clamme speaking at the Alumni Chapter Leadership Conference in March.

classes have shared rituals, traditions, and memories. Tailgates are loud and raucous with faithful alumni, and tens of thousands of fans make their way to Memorial Stadium thinking to themselves "maybe this could be our year!"

Cal first fielded a football team 144 years ago in 1882, making it the oldest football program on the West Coast. Generations of students and alumni have gathered each fall to cheer on the Golden Bears through good times and bad.

Cal football has always represented something larger than the game itself. From players who interrupted their careers to serve in wartime, like Jackie Jensen '50 and Les Richter '52

(Korean War), to pioneers who broke racial barriers like Walter Gordon '18, J.D. '22 or Joe Kapp '60, the first Hispanic quarterback to achieve national prominence - and led Cal to its last Rose Bowl appearance in 1959, or Marshawn Lynch, whose philanthropy and commitment to his hometown of Oakland made him a role model beyond sports, or scholar-athletes who became leaders in business, science, public service, and their communities, the football program reflects Berkeley's broader mission of excellence and service.

For many, Cal football is more than a sport. It is a shared experience, a lifelong bond, and one of Berkeley's enduring traditions. And speaking of traditions, if you would please join me, Ahmad Anderson '83 and Reza Sirafinejad '93 in saying: "You know it! What? You tell the story! What? You Tell the Whole Damn World this is Bear Territory!"

You know what? 2026 just *might* be our year. There certainly seems to be a different kind of energy around campus with new head coach Tosh Lupoi returning to his roots in Berkeley. Quarterback Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele turning down other offers to remain a Bear. Our fans and 600,000+ living alumni and future members who are thinking "maybe this *could* be our year" just might not be too crazy. ACC champs? College Football Playoff? Having grown up in Carmel-by-the-Cornfield, Indiana, and watching many losing football seasons for the Indiana Hoosiers, I say "if it can happen in Bloomington, it can happen in Berkeley."

Fiat Lux and Go Bears!

John Clamme
Executive Director

Imagining the Future

Supported by a Cal Alumni Scholarship, Itcelia Segoviano-Ramirez '19 transformed her own path. Now, through Stiles Hall, she's helping hundreds of young people transform theirs. **By Shannon Cheng '27**



Every week, Itcelia Segoviano-Ramirez '19 helps young people imagine futures they may never have thought possible. As assistant executive director of Stiles Hall, she oversees mentoring and college-access programs serving hundreds of students. Years earlier, she was one of only three students from her Eastern Coachella Valley high school to make it to UC Berkeley.

For Segoviano-Ramirez, education has always been a way to transform herself. Home life was turbulent; she witnessed alcoholism and abuse. Throughout this time, school provided an interlude where she could simply be a child. School was also a place that fostered her self-discovery. She found joy as a mentor to her peers in high school, often hosting study groups after school.

However, resources were limited within the Eastern Coachella Valley public school system. Students were encouraged to take less demanding coursework and fewer AP classes. The expectation was that students would go to Coachella Valley's only community college after high school. It was rare for students from her region to go to schools like Berkeley, but Segoviano-Ramirez did not want those odds to limit

her. With the guidance of her AP Spanish teacher, she enrolled in advanced placement courses and participated in extracurricular activities. Segoviano-Ramirez recounted in her speech as the keynote speaker for the Alumni Scholarships and Engagement Program, "I needed an education. Not just for a job. Not just for a degree. But so I could have options. Because when you don't have options, everything feels like survival. And I wanted more than that. So I held onto school."

The extra work paid off and she was accepted to UC Berkeley. As a first generation college student from a low-income family, she received a full scholarship from the Cal Alumni Association. In addition to her scholarship, the Cal Alumni Scholarship Program gave her an iPad to do her coursework, helped her build community with her peers through retreats, and offered financial literacy and professional workshops. Together, these resources helped her navigate her time at Cal and beyond.

Segoviano-Ramirez was an integral part of her community at Cal. She got involved at Stiles Hall in her freshman year, and later became a program coordinator, matching Berkeley student mentors with local elementary school children to provide academic support. Additionally, she organized the Latinx Healing Circle to create a community that raised awareness and supported students who experienced sexual assault or sexual harassment. She often returned to the Coachella Valley to give presentations on

The path that brought Itcelia Segoviano-Ramirez '19 through Sather Gate now leads her back to Berkeley as a mentor, educator, and advocate for the next generation.

**I needed an education. Not just for a job. Not just for a degree.
But so I could have options. Because when you don't have options,
everything feels like survival.**

the opportunities higher education provides to students like her. She was a living example that higher education was possible for others in her community.

During her student years, when she was not giving back to the community, she was studying and supporting her family through her work at Stiles Hall.

It was a constant balancing act, and the stress, paired with underlying health conditions, took a toll on her; she was hospitalized for an autoimmune disease during her senior year of college. But as a Cal Alumni scholar,

she was paired with an advisor who routinely checked up on her and helped her navigate the Tang Center for mental health. She says that with her family on the other side of the state, having someone nearby to support her made all the difference.

After graduating, Segoviano-Ramirez decided to continue to pay it forward. At Stiles Hall, she leads mentorship and college-access programs for hundreds of underrepresented youth, ranging from elementary school to college. She is simultaneously pursuing her master's in Educational

Leadership at the Harvard Graduate School of Education. She hopes to continue assisting students in pursuing higher education, especially those from rural communities. When working with students, Segoviano-Ramirez encourages them to become mentors: "You shouldn't wait to mentor someone until you have a fancy title or all the degrees and certifications. You are ready now! There is someone in your community and your hometown waiting for someone to come back and believe in them, tell and show them that it is possible." **C**

**Mentor
the next
generation
of Bears!**



The Cal Alumni Mentors program,

hosted by the Cal Alumni Association, matches alums who want to help undergraduate students during their time at Berkeley. Help students explore career options, gain professional insights, and get help from the Cal network.

Get matched 1:1 with a student

Help them navigate Berkeley

Attend student/alum mixers

Access mentorship workshops

**CAL ALUMNI
MENTORS**

alumni.berkeley.edu/mentorship



The Universe Will Not Be Paraphrased

Cal astrophysicist Eugene Chiang has chased total solar eclipses across three continents. His advice: stop extrapolating from the partial you saw once, and just go. **By Urja Upadhyaya**

For the first 40 years of his life, Eugene Chiang was unmoved by eclipses. He had heard the stories from his colleague Alex Filipenko, one of the most prolific eclipse chasers on the Berkeley campus, probably on the planet. He had read the accounts. He had seen the videos. And every time, his reaction was roughly the same: the moon passes in front of the sun, it gets a little darker, fine.

Then he drove an RV into an ordinary field in Oregon.

“It almost felt like the end of the world, except in a good way,” says Chiang, professor of astronomy and Earth and planetary science at UC Berkeley. “Like, somehow, it was not sad, but happy. Some cosmic unfolding. Practically spiritual.”

He is describing the 2017 eclipse, his first total. In the seconds before totality, a shadow the width of an entire landscape moved across the field. Stars appeared. The diamond flash. Then the corona, which Chiang swears filled the sky, even though he knows the measurements say otherwise. “It just felt like it was literally blowing past me,” he says. His wife, who had once cut short a stargazing session because it was cold and uninteresting, turned to him when it was over and said two things he has never forgotten: That was magical. And: When’s the next one?



The universe is silent at that point. Why should I be the one talking?

The answer was Mexico. Then, this August, Bilbao and San Sebastián with Cal Discoveries Travel. And in 2027, Algeria.

Chiang will lead both tours as enrichment lecturer, bringing the same framework he uses in the Berkeley classroom: physics is not a separate domain from everyday life, it is the same set of principles operating at different scales. The red of hydrogen prominences visible during totality comes from the same quantum mechanics as the blue glow of a neon sign. The eclipses of distant exoplanets, which block at most one percent of their star’s disc, have revealed the periods, sizes, atmospheres, and compositions of entire planetary systems. A total solar eclipse, then, is not just an event.

It is the local, spectacular version of something happening continuously across the galaxy.

“It’s only interesting if it can be unified,” he says. “If what’s out there actually relates to what’s down here.”

On the Algeria tour, he plans to go further back in time. Ancient eclipse records, painstakingly kept by civilizations across North Africa and the Middle East, turn out to be scientifically essential. The moon’s orbit has been slowly expanding due to tidal interactions with Earth, and if physicists get that model even slightly wrong, their predicted eclipse paths will not match the historical record. The ancients were watching the same shadow we chase today, and their observations are still calibrating our theories.

As for what modern science gains from those four minutes of



totality, Chiang is honest about the limits. The Parker Solar Probe is practically swimming in the corona. Spacecraft have been studying solar prominences for decades. Ground-based eclipse data, he admits, is unlikely to compete with years of continuous satellite observations. “The low-hanging fruit has been picked,” he says. What totality offers now is something the instruments cannot: the full sensory experience of standing inside an astronomical event. The air cools. The crowd goes quiet. The corona expands above you.

“Everyone makes meaning of it in their own way,” Chiang says. “Nobody should get in the way of that.”

He will not narrate during totality. He will not lecture. “The universe is silent at that point,” he says. “Why should I be the one talking?”

His honest pitch to anyone on the fence between Spain and Algeria, or considering both: do not make the mistake he made for four decades. A partial eclipse and a total solar eclipse are not different points on the same scale. They are categorically different experiences, the way a photograph of the ocean is categorically different from standing in it.

“Everyone on the planet Earth should see at least one,” he says. “And these are great years to do it.” **C**

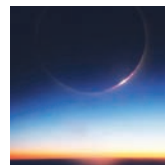
Professor Eugene Chiang's eclipse tours filled almost immediately—but there's still time to experience the thrill of a total solar eclipse with Cal Discoveries Travel. Explore additional eclipse tours in the sidebar on the right.

A group of Cal Discoveries travelers gathers for the August 2017 total eclipse in Oregon. Total eclipses are a fundamentally different experience than partials, explains professor Eugene Chiang.

CAL DISCOVERIES TRAVEL

Lifelong Learning Through Travel

Total Solar Eclipses



JULY 26 - AUG 7, 2027

Solar Eclipse Cruise: Italy, Sicily & Malta

Witness one of nature's most awe-inspiring spectacles from the open sea on this unforgettable Mediterranean voyage, where wide horizons offer an ideal setting for viewing the eclipse.



JULY 26 - AUG 3, 2027

Eclipse in Spain ~ Andalucia

At a hilltop castle in the Spanish countryside, experience day turn to twilight during a total solar eclipse, followed by stargazing with an expert under the Andalusian night sky.

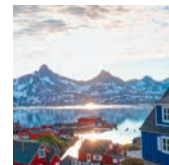
Arctic Skies



FEB 3 - 11, 2027

Finland: Arctic Magnificence

Journey north from Helsinki to Lapland, where glass-domed cabins, shimmering night skies, and snow-covered landscapes set the stage for viewing the Northern Lights.



AUG 14 - 25, 2027

Arctic Circle Cruise: Sailing to the Far North

Journey into the Far North with distinguished astronomy professor Alex Filippenko on a once-in-a-lifetime Arctic expedition. Cruise spectacular icy coastlines beneath the midnight sun, where endless daylight illuminates jagged mountains, frozen glaciers, and shimmering Arctic seas.



Aim your smartphone or tablet camera at this QR code or go to alumni.berkeley.edu/travel to explore these and all our trips!

510.900.8222

caldiscoveries@alumni.berkeley.edu
alumni.berkeley.edu/travel

The Lair, Beyond Summer

The Lair of the Golden Bear's new Lodge opens year-round possibilities for Cal alums, families, corporate groups, and anyone in search of something more than a hotel stay.

By Urja Upadhyaya

Cathy Connelly has a very specific measure of success. “As they’re leaving camp, we want campers counting the days until they return.” For 77 years, the Lair of the Golden Bear has inspired that feeling in its summer campers. Now, with the opening of its new Lodge at Camp Oski, Connelly is ready to make it happen year-round.

Lair Lodge’s origin story is one of resilience. In 2017, a burst pipe flooded and destroyed the original dining hall at Camp Oski, leaving that camp without a gathering space for seven years. The disaster accelerated plans already in motion: a space designed to welcome guests throughout the year.

The Lodge expands possibilities for Lair campers and guests. Connelly envisions the Lodge serving corporate teams seeking team-building retreats, Alumni Chapters looking to reconnect, families gathering for reunions, scholars and student groups who want a quiet, beautiful environment to write papers or focus on research, and for

athy Connelly has a very specific measure of success. “As they’re leaving camp, we

Families gather before dinner during summer Week 2 in Lair Lodge.

weddings. The Lair provides year-round cabins and meals, and can layer in activities, from hikes to art, so that groups with a primary purpose still leave with a full experience.

“We’re not just a hotel,” Connelly says. “It’s a space for communities to build connections.” The phrase she returns to is “unreasonable hospitality,” coined by restaurateur Will Guidara. Staff go beyond what is expected. Every day, she says, someone tells her a story about something a staffer did for a guest, or a connection that formed at the Lair that wouldn’t have happened anywhere else. That culture, she is clear, is not

a feature of the building. It is the people who work there.

For families already familiar with the Lair’s winter weekend programming, Lair Lodge formalizes what has been quietly growing for several years. Guests arrive Friday for a hot dinner, spend their days at Dodge Ridge Ski Resort two miles away, and return each evening to meals and activities. Holiday weekends over Martin Luther King Jr. Day and Presidents’ Day have sold out in the past. The Lodge makes it possible to expand that programming and absorb larger groups with more comfort.

Scholar and campus department heads considering the Lair



As they’re leaving camp, we want campers counting the days until they return.



for a retreat will find something equally compelling. Three hours from the Bay Area, at 5,600 feet in the Sierra Nevada, the property sits far enough from Berkeley to feel genuinely removed, and close enough to reach easily. Wi-Fi is available. So is Pinecrest Lake, the forest, and the kind of quiet that is simply hard to find closer to home.

Connelly is also quick to name the people making it run. Family Camp Director, Josh Dobson is essential to year-round operations, and Pat Graffis is the Lair's Facilities Director, and oversees the maintenance and improvements on site. Director of Reservations and Special Groups, Mikey

Day leads science camp programming and winter weekends; and he recently ran into a former science camper who remembered him from a two-day session four years ago. "It makes such an impression," Connelly says. That is by design.

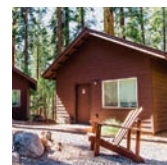
Ten years from now, she wants someone to describe the Lair simply: a year-round venue for camaraderie, nature, and Cal spirit. Lair Lodge is the infrastructure. The camaraderie, the laughter at dinner, the friendships that form during a stay, the guests who attend one wedding and book their own before leaving, has always been there. **C**

Cathy Connelly (above), is the Lair's General Manager and in her 19th year on the management team. Her family has been camping there since 1952. Lair Lodge officially opened with a ribbon-cutting ceremony in May.



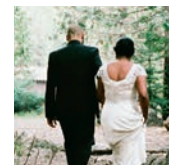
Camp at the Lair

Start making plans for your whole family to join us next summer. We cook, clean, provide an array of activities, and will watch your kids each day to give you some 'me' time!



Year-round cabins for summer stays

Want an option to 'camp' yet with your own private bathroom and heat and in a fully enclosed cabin? Book one of our year-round cabins for family camp next summer and don't miss out on all the fun Lair activities, meals, and programs.



Weddings & Private Events

The Lair is now a year-round destination for weddings and private events like family reunions, corporate retreats, team-building weekends, and group meetings. Stay in our year-round cabins, and have exclusive use of the Lair Lodge, with meals and activities tailored to your event.



Oski Science Camp

Oski Science Camp is what happens when you cross the Lair with an outdoor education curriculum designed by UC Berkeley grad students. Middle schools bring their students to explore and deepen their curiosity about nature each fall and spring.



Aim your smartphone or tablet camera at this QR code or go to <https://alumni.berkeley.edu/camp-at-the-lair/>.

To book a group retreat, wedding, or weekend stay, lairofthebear.org or contact the Lair team directly at lair@alumni.berkeley.edu.

510.900.8255
lair@alumni.berkeley.edu
lairofthebear.org



Golden Bears Life Membership

Congratulations and thank you to our newest Golden Bears Life Members for expressing an ongoing allegiance to the past and future of our incomparable alma mater.

1940s

Barbara L. Heublein '47
Dr. Gerald W. Kimble '49

1950s

Chung C. Gong '50
Russell R. Nicholson '51
Capt. John T. Andrews '57
Dr. Harold M. Cota '59
Roger A. Ginsburg '59
Thomas R. Sparks '59

1960s

Bennetta S. McLaughlin '60
Lawrence D. Boone '61
Lawrence C. Cardoza '61
Lawrence A. Brown '62
Douglas A. Buck '62, Cred. '67
Khosrow Moaveni '62, M.S. '64
Shirlene L. Nakano '62, C.Mult. '63
Michael R. Noakes '62
Judge Brian Van Camp '62, J.D. '65
Judith S. Zacccone '62
Charles H. Olson '63
Sydney R. Robertson '63
Honorable David L. Schreck J.D. '63
Robert C. May '64
Lawrence A. Scaff, Ph.D. '64, M.A. '65, Ph.D. '71
Dr. Craig W. Thomas '64
Froma W. Walsh, Ph.D. '64
Gary K. Long '65
Jane R. Vaden '65
Prof. Emer. Lynn T. White M.A. '65, Ph.D. '73
Lorita A. Winfield '65
Patricia D. Bender '66
Ted A. Dienstfrey M.C.P. '66
Honorable Ken M. Kawaichi J.D. '66
Amy E. Shinsako '66
Dr. Steven J. Solomon '66
Jerome M. Behrens '67
Dr. Martha J. Lindholm M.A. '67
Peyo Michaels '67, M.Arch. '68
Glenn K. Shinsako '67
Craig B. Young M.B.A. '67
Elizabeth J. Kneier '68
Margaret G. Newhouse '68, C.Mult. '69

Pernille A. Wollan '68, C.Esing '70
Fred D. Brunswig M.A. '69
Dr. Narinder Pal M.S. '69, Ph.D. '74

1970s

Dr. Michael L. Cahoon '70
Dr. William J. Au '71
Rebecca G. Blythe '71
Anthony C. Cravotto '71
Michael L. Dieden '71
Diane L. Dobronte '71
Christine G. Honda '71, M.B.A. '78
Ynez Olshausen '71
Drew D. Pettus '71
David M. Rabinowitz M.S. '72
Thomas A. Wilson '72
Matthew G. Yeager '72
Jane M. Anthony '73
Dr. John M. Chavez Cred. '73, M.A. '75, Ed.D. '78, Ph.D. '86
Pauline L. Lim '73
Patricia A. Mahoney '73, C.Esing '75
Cristie J. Montgomery '73
Gary T. Ogimachi '73
Todd W. Perbix '73
Alan M. Fishman M.A., C.Esing '74
Kenneth Y. Kamei J.D. '74
Benjamin H. Leifer '74, M.P.H. '76
John W. Mohney M.S. '74
Roger C. Bales M.S. '75
Candi Lee Estrada '75
David E. Hughes '75
Don Ralphs '75
Jon A. Sjogren Ph.D. '75
Joseph S. Velson '75
Scott J. Nakamura '76
Violet Powell '76, C.Esing '78
Diana P. Smith '76
Clifford A. Gade '77
Joi D. Grieg M.B.A. '77
Michael G. Sholley M.S. '77
James M. Stover '77
Alexander F. Stuart '77
Beverly H. Stuart '77
Dennis B. Eid '78
Isiah Harris M.Eng. '78
Keith L. Lee '78, M.B.A. '84
Leah A. Owyang '78

Valerie G. Vicente '78
Johnny Fong '79
Diana Marthinsen-Hoek '79, M.S. '81
Marilyn B. Willats M.L.S. '79
Steven D. Wolf '79
Dr. Jeffrey C. Young '79

1980s

Rebecca K. Chang M.B.A. '80
Donald F. Wurster M.B.A. '80
Mehmet K. Binay M.S. '81
Catharine H. Ratto M.P.H. '81
Shawna M. Foster '82
Dr. Gamal F. Ghaly M.P.H. '82
Dr. Donald M. Hernandez '82
Gary S. Margadant '82
Marianne Nishifue '82
Genevieve Payne '82, M.L.I.S. '94
Xiang S. Zhang M.S. '83, Ph.D. '91
Rajiv K. Bhagat '84
Martin J. Machniak '84
Xiaoxuan Qi, Ph.D. M.S. '84, Ph.D. '89
James B. Bitzer '85
John C. Hayes M.S. '85
Gary C. Look, Ph.D. '85
David K. Tanaka '86
Margaret P. Droesch M.P.H. '87
Dr. Gerald H. Markovitz '87
Kamilla K. McClelland '87
Marcia R. Wilson M.A. '87, Ph.D. '95
Robert W. Hayes '88
Russell E. Babcock '89
Wadsworth Scott Cauchois '89
Wendy Wagner '89

1990s

Elan S. Carr '90
Lokesh K. Duraiappah '90
Julie Y. Johnson '90
Luz M. Olmos Garcia '90
Jennifer J. Klibanoff '91
Dr. Emily Acevedo '92
Julie S. Garlikov '92
Kimberley R. Nash '92
Karen L. Navas '92
William F. Tell '92
Dr. Otute Akiti '93

Charisse R. Chisolm '93
John M. Lemanski '93
Stephanie L. Casperson '94
Sarah K. Cotton '94
Tarn M. Sublett M.B.A. '94
Dr. Dahlia T. Carr '95
Richard O. Fowler M.S. '95
Julie G. Harris '95
Dr. Ernie C. Chang '96
Davide Farinati '96
Paul C. Galm '96
Nicole Loomis M.S. '96
Navneet Randhawa '96
Danielle A. Samulon '96
Jerry S. Tang '96
Joan A. Harris, Ph.D., M.P.H. '97
Charles C. Yu '97
Jeremy A. Miller '98, M.B.A. '03
Dr. Brandy E. Underwood '98
Charles E. Wesson '98
Louis D. Yang '98
Tony S. Ahn '99
Dr. Carolyn A. Alekna '99, O.D. '04
Collette K. Ching '99
Ariel M. Hurtado '99
Rita Mehta '99

2000s

Linda Fang '00
Stacey P. Hsieh '00
Stephanie Hall Kobesky '00
Marcela Taylor '00, M.A. '19, C.EAS '19
Kankun Yo '00
Henry H. Chang '01
Binh V. Pham '01
Patrick A. Russell '01
Daniel J. Yoo '01
Roland V. de Guzman M.S. '02
Joyce Liu Tom '02
Gelberg H. Rodriguez '02
Rami M. Halabi '03
Andrew P. Mikhail '03
Jiong Shen '03
Dr. Mehryar Mehrizi '04
Zena F. Phillips '04
Eduardo Casas '05
Naveen K. Sharma M.S.W. '05
Jasmeet K. Dhaliwal '06
Wensheng Huang '06
Alvin Lee '06
Guido S. Radaelli M.B.A. '06

Ankit R. Vyas '06
 Joe Colangelo '07
 Sarah E. Conroy '07
 Jacob S. Himmel '07
 Dr. John B. Torous '07
 Nolen Kiyomi Ross M.B.A.
 '08, M.P.H. '15
 Alan Chen '09
 Robert E. Talley '09

2010s

Brad C. Anderson '10
 Dr. Mario D. Castillo M.A.
 '10, Ph.D. '23
 Salar Assadian '11
 Joseph Daniel M.S. '11
 Gregory S. Merritt '11
 Beverly Correa M.B.A. '12
 Yancarlo Escarate '12
 Kevin T. Sweeney '12
 Joel H. Weinberger Ph.D. '12
 Xue J. Wu '12
 Jennifer L. Cheyne '13
 Casey J. Harmon '13
 Donghwa Kim '14
 Yue Lu Ph.D. '14
 Riddhi Jain '15, M.B.A. '23
 Julie A. Simer M.P.H. '15
 Roger C. Kuo '16
 Monica S. Sadhu '16
 Jeffrey L. Coleman '17
 Jasen S. Wallace '18
 Kevin R. Borgh '19
 Khaled H. Chowdhury
 Ph.D. '19
 Veronica C. Cummings
 M.P.P. '19

Parikshit Nukala M.B.A. '19
 Sky Valentine '19

2020s

Jessie V. Gross '20
 John Hui Cert. '20
 Nathan D. Padilla '20
 Rishi Puri '20
 Hannah M. Rowe '20
 Amal H. Mehta '21
 Sushil Viswanathan '21
 Geenita Devi '22
 Rongsen Li '22
 Kin Long Lo '22
 Bradley J. Postle '22
 Anika A. Ramachandran '22
 Tony S. Rook '22
 Ethan A. Garcia '23
 Razal M. Minhas M.I.D.S. '23
 Dr. Leila A. Takayama '23
 Lianne Wong '23
 Michael V. York M.I.C.S. '23
 Edwin Brown M.I.D.S. '24
 Joshua Klein '24
 Zhigang Ma M.P.H. '24
 Judy Mikacich M.P.H. '24
 M. Ross Paine '24
 Amogh A. Tantradi '24

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The list of Golden Bears Life Members above is accurate from October 1, 2025 to April 15, 2026.



PAYING FORWARD WHAT CAL GAVE HER

A Leadership Award recipient and life-long advocate for justice, Joanne Brown '68 gives back so today's students get the same start she did.

We are proud to spotlight Joanne Brown, '68, MSW '70, JD '73, whose commitment to the Alumni Scholars Program reflects the spirit of the Cal Alumni Association's community.

As a first-generation student from rural Monterey County, Joanne Brown's journey at Cal was shaped by scholarship support and a passion for justice. A proud recipient of The Leadership Award scholarship, Joanne credits Cal with inspiring her and opening the doors to a lifelong career in public service. Reflecting on her arrival at Cal she says, "Once I walked onto the Cal campus and saw the groups advocating for social change and the passion of the students, I was hooked."

Through her continued giving, Joanne champions the values that inspired her at Berkeley, creating a powerful legacy of impact for generations to come. "That these awards emphasize community service, ambition, and leadership is important to me," she says. "The Leadership Award Program and The Achievement Award Program are focused funds that can provide financial assistance at a critical time in a young person's life, leading them to a life-changing education. Even a modest donation can really make a difference, in today's world."

Lauren Tulley



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The Gate



Still Rolling

At 50, the Bay Area Outreach and Recreation Program keeps disabled athletes in the game.
By Emma Silvers

SCOTT GOODMAN



S

usan Sygall '76 still remembers some of the misguided comments she heard when she started the Bay Area Outreach and Recreation Program.

Sygall, who launched the adaptive sports program as an undergraduate at Berkeley, is an internationally renowned disability rights activist, author, and MacArthur Fellow. BORP is a widely acclaimed 50-year-old

sports and recreation nonprofit that has played an influential role in the disability rights movement.

But back in the 1970s, there was skepticism—both about the organization's approach and about its young female director. When BORP began offering horseback riding, Sygall recalls, "People said, 'Oh, isn't it dangerous for disabled people to go horseback riding?'"

She would reply with a quip she'd heard from a quadriplegic BORP participant: "Every disabled person has the right to break their neck twice."

Sygall, now 73, exudes an upbeat, tireless determination. She grew up non-disabled and athletic on the East Coast: she skied, played basketball, and loved to camp. Soon after she enrolled at the University of Colorado, she became paraplegic following a car accident. After a year of rehabilitation and encouragement from her parents—Holocaust survivors who always urged her to live life to its fullest—she spent a year at NYU before transferring to Berkeley in 1973 to complete her degree as part of the Disabled Students' Program.

On the heels of the Free Speech and anti-war movements, the Bay Area was humming with activism. Nationally, Title IX had just prohibited sex-based discrimination in school sports, and Berkeley's Center for Independent Living, a formative hub for the disabled community, had been founded in 1972.

All a blur: All-around athlete, attorney, and BORP executive director Emily Seelenfreund flies past on the handcycle.

Previous page: Sisseline Lovejoy is an Albany High graduate who started playing basketball with BORP at age 11. She'll continue to compete at the University of Arizona.

"Everything is always related," says Sygall of these fights for equality. "Everyone was talking about a revolution."

In 1974, with her friend Deborah Kaplan, J.D. '76, she cofounded the Disabled Women's Coalition to ensure women had a voice in the burgeoning disability rights movement. The following year, while working on an independent study project, she envisioned a recreation program for disabled people—inspired, mainly, by the fact that she couldn't find one that appealed to her as a lifelong athlete.

"I was so passionate about recreation and sports, and I didn't see any opportunities [for] camping in Yosemite, gymnastics, wheelchair basketball, dance, archery, self-defense," recalls Sygall. "It was really just creating all the opportunities that I wanted to do."

With the encouragement of a handful of Berkeley professors, such as landscape architect Robin Moore and education professor John Hurst, she made the project a reality. Her high school friend Diane Schechter flew out to help, and they submitted

proposals to the Berkeley City Council, receiving two initial grants totaling \$25,000.

The pair officially cofounded BORG in 1975 with a handful of programs, including swimming and gymnastics, for disabled kids in Berkeley public schools. One of its founding principles was groundbreaking at the time: People with disabilities should teach the courses, so kids could look up to them as role models and form a “sense of positive identity,” says Sygall. “It was so unusual at that time for people to talk about disability pride.”

Five decades later, BORG serves some 1,400 people annually with wheelchair basketball teams, kayaking and nature outings, power soccer (an indoor form of soccer played by people in power wheelchairs, a sport that BORG helped establish and popularize), a cycling center with more than 100 adaptive cycles, and transportation and other support services. The organization has helped shift thinking around physical activity away from therapy and toward recreation: sports for the sake of, well, sports.

That distinction has been life-changing for people like Sisseline Lovejoy. Now 18, she’s been participating in BORG’s basketball programs since she was 11.

“The first time I played basketball, it was pretty obvious to me that it was going to change my life,” recalls Lovejoy, a recent graduate of Albany High School. Lovejoy has a genetic condition called hereditary spastic paraplegia, which has progressed over her life; back when she first picked up a ball, she didn’t yet use a wheelchair for daily activities. “But I felt really slow and disabled in my day-to-day life, and there was something about being in a chair—[it] was almost like a vessel that was meant to carry me and allow me to move and to be free.”

After spending the last few years on BORG’s traveling women’s team, Lovejoy was recruited to play at the

University of Arizona, where she’ll start in the fall. “It changed the way I was able to think about myself and what my body can do,” Lovejoy says of the organization.

For Emily Seelenfreund, BORG’s executive director, the ethos of “by disabled people, for disabled people” is one of the nonprofit’s most powerful features.

“A lot of adaptive sports organizations that I’ve been a part of are very top-down,” says Seelenfreund. “But because BORG was founded by people with disabilities, it’s always been really attuned to what the community wants and needs.”

Most recently, that has meant things like BORG’s new micro-mobility equipment loaner program, which lets people try out expensive new gear, like wheelchair

“Every disabled person has the right to break their neck twice.”

attachments, before purchasing it—an idea Seelenfreund had after shopping for her own device.

“It also means there’s a real sense of community,” says Seelenfreund, noting that she is honored to follow Sygall’s lead as a young female director of the organization. “It’s not just a place where [people] exercise. It’s also a place, very often, where they find lifelong friends and connection.”

The tight-knit community makes Sygall emotional when she discusses her time in Berkeley. Deep friendships strengthened the organization’s work, she says, and vice versa. In 1977, when renowned disability rights advocate Judy Heumann, MPH ’75, co-led a group of activists to occupy a San Francisco federal building for 28 days in order to push through long-delayed anti-discrimination regulations, Sygall, Kaplan, and others from Berkeley didn’t hesitate to join the sit-in.

Sygall left BORG in 1978 to spend a year in Australia on a Rotary scholarship, but she says the people she met at the organization



Team play: Seelenfreund says BORG’s ethos is “by disabled people, for disabled people.”

indelibly shaped her later work: In 1981, as a grad student at the University of Oregon, she founded Mobility International USA, based on the same principles. It, too, is still going strong, facilitating exchange and development programs for disabled people around the world. Sygall still serves as CEO and has no plans to retire anytime soon.

She will, however, take a few days off in October when she heads back to the Bay Area for BORG’s 50th anniversary celebration. Reflecting on the milestone, she’s been seeing “all the connections, and how powerful those moments were in Berkeley.”

One of the messages she hopes young people take away from her story is “the power of students creating projects.” Ideas conceived in school don’t have to stay there, she says. “Dream big and surround yourself with great people until those things come true.” **C**

Emma Silvers is a longtime Bay Area culture journalist and cofounder of COYOTE Media Collective.

Class Notes



"My name is **Dr. David Law '04**. I'm a physician at Long Beach Memorial, a board member of the Cure GM1 Foundation, and Violet's father. My daughter Violet passed away in 2023 from GM1 gangliosidosis, a rare and fatal pediatric neurodegenerative disease. Like many families, we did not know she had GM1 until irreversible neurologic damage had already occurred. It has now been nearly two years since her passing, and while that loss remains unimaginable, we have continued moving forward through efforts to improve early detection for future children. In May, I was in Sacramento with other families and physicians as State Senator Steve Padilla presented a resolution declaring May 23, 2026, as GM1 Gangliosidosis Awareness Day. A major focus of this advocacy is newborn screening. GM1 is still not included in California's newborn screening panel, despite available testing and emerging therapies. We hope increased awareness can help move that conversation forward." *Ed note: California wrote about David and Violet in 2023. Read "I was afraid we'd be isolated."* (tinyurl.com/2upmtw7d)

Dana Cruz '13 was named one of *Comstock's* magazine's 2026 Young Professionals. Dana serves as a governmental affairs attorney for the Judicial Council of California, representing the largest court system in the nation. He has worked across all three branches of state government, including as a fiscal policy advisor to Governors Jerry Brown and Gavin Newsom and a legislative aide to State Senator Janet Nguyen. The son of Filipino immigrants and a first-generation college student, he credits Berkeley with amplifying the curiosity, drive, and sense of public purpose that have since guided his career.

Rachelle Gold, CERT '01, M.A. '02, won a five-year \$500,000 grant from the Mellon Foundation to create an oral history archive of Black women justice-seekers who are alumnae of

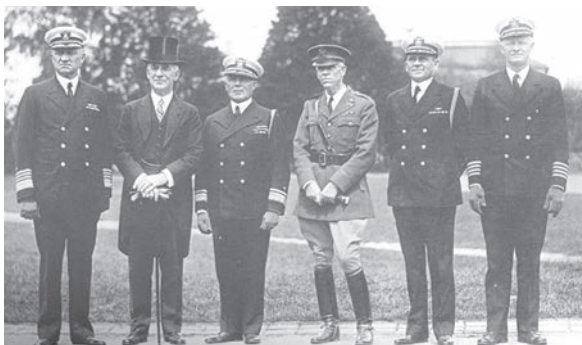
North Carolina Central University, where she has taught English, composition, African American and world literature, and grammar since 2008. So far, she has trained 80 students to conduct oral history interviews of distinguished graduates of NCCU.

Terry Healey '86 writes: "Thrilled to announce that my latest book, *The Resilience Mindset: How Adversity Can Strengthen Individuals, Teams, and Leaders*, has won a National Indie Excellence Award. I overcame a life-threatening cancer that left me with a permanent facial difference when I was a junior at Berkeley. I encountered roadblocks for years afterwards, enduring over 30 surgical procedures to cure my cancer and attempt to reconstruct my face. My book is based on not just my own story, but those of others who have overcome seemingly insurmountable odds."

Above: **David Law** (second from left) in front of the State Capitol with other members of the Cure GM1 Foundation.



Alan White '69 writes: "Berkeley in the late 1960s was full of local and international concerns, between the war in Vietnam and the many social issues one learns about at UC. Halfway through an MBA, I decided the Peace Corps would be a better option. By 1971, I was learning Spanish and went to Ecuador on an assignment in the Galapagos Islands with the Charles Darwin Foundation. I gravitated to a career in natural resource conservation that has taken me into more than 40 years of research in sustainable marine resource use and various projects in Southeast Asia for coral reef protection and fisheries management. Berkeley was the catalyst that opened my eyes to the world!"



Inspection visit to Cal NROTC, circa 1927, including **Chester Nimitz** (far right)

Dennis LaFlam (left) with midshipmen from Cal NROTC in 2026.



Dennis LaFlam '77, former U.S. Navy lieutenant and surface warfare officer, writes: "This year marks the 100th anniversary of Cal's Naval Reserve Officers Training Corps (NROTC), one of six such programs established by the Navy in 1926. The founding commanding officer and the school's first professor of naval sciences was Chester W. Nimitz, who went on to command Allied forces in the Pacific during World War II. The program was located in Callaghan Hall before the building burned down in an arson fire in 1985. Today it is headquartered in Hearst Gymnasium. Cal's NROTC serves a consortium of local schools, also enrolling students from UC Davis, Stanford, and the California Maritime Academy. Applicants selected for the program, upon acceptance to their respective colleges or universities, are awarded scholarships that provide full tuition, books, monthly stipends, and educational fees. Upon graduation, NROTC midshipmen are commissioned as officers in the Navy and Marine Corps. The school's NROTC has distinguished itself as a premier program in training well-rounded officers."

Philip Ballou '76, M.A. '78, Ph.D. '83, feels thankful for the diversity and breadth of his experiences during his 12 years at Cal. While majoring in music composition, he also enjoyed classes in biology and anthropology, as well as participating in the scientific diving program. After being unable to find an academic position in music, he took a summer job at a local marine technology company, and retired from this field 37 successful and fulfilling years later. Later this summer, at the age of 72, he is releasing *Philip Ballou: Selected Works 1977–1983*, a vinyl LP produced by Important Records.

Jonathan Ezra Goldman '94 has published his fourth book, *Hidden Histories of Jazz Age New York: From the Suppressed to the Strange* (SUNY Press Excelsior Editions, May 2026). It offers a fresh look at 1920s New York City, unearthing stories of everyday life and marginalized communities. Sweeping events such as the Harlem Renaissance, Prohibition, and immigration reform are seen through the individual experiences of librarians,

cops, shopkeepers, sex workers, rag-pickers, and antivaxxers that counter popular conceptions of the era as one of ballooning wealth and uproarious celebration. These stories still resonate today, helping 21st-century readers see our own moment and its problems more clearly.

Jane Clare Upp '49 writes: "We were career-determined when we joined Dean Griffin's journalism class in 1946. Joan (from Piedmont) and I (Bakersfielad) were alone in a class of men. I wanted to be a foreign correspondent and Joan wanted to be a reporter. She realized her dream, but my plans went out the window when I started dating a Phi Delt, **John Upp '49**, in 1949. Love overcame career. We had 65 married years together and, though I was no foreign correspondent, I got my teaching credential while having five children and owned Travelwise in Walnut Creek, which got me around the world. I stayed a travel agent for 29 years and wrote many travel articles. Now it is time for a permanent sabbatical."



Outer Space is Closer Than Antarctica hit bookstores last year. Published by Chronicle Books, this illustrated memoir from **Michelle Ott, MFA '15**, describes life, love, and the science she learned in the four summer seasons she spent working at Antarctica's largest research base, **McMurdo Station**. In fact, Michelle learned that outer space is closer than Antarctica while attending an arts talk at Berkeley in 2016.



Julia Gitis '12 kicks off San Francisco Good Neighbor Week on September 26. It runs until October 4. This is the city's second annual Good Neighbor Week, which Julia first championed in 2025 after finding herself the only representative from California on a Zoom call for the nationwide Good Neighbor Day of September 28. Find out more about this year's San Francisco Good Neighbor Week or nominate a deserving neighbor for the Good Neighbor Awards at sfgoodneighborweek.org.

Andrea Louie, M.A. '91, Ph.D. '96, has published her third book, *Chinese American Mothering: Toy Len Goon's Legacy and the Myth of the Model Minority*. She writes about her great-grandmother, Toy Len Goon, who won the 1952 Maine and National Mother of the Year awards. Andrea examines how her ancestor's story was used at the time to reinforce ideas about minorities and opportunity, as well as how Goon's descendants think of her legacy in a modern setting.

Philip L. Glick '75, a professor of surgery at the University at Buffalo's Jacobs School of Medicine and Biomedical Sciences, has endowed a new lecture series on the business of surgery. He writes: "While at Berkeley as an undergraduate, Professors Seymour Fogel (genetics) and John Hearst (chemistry) and graduate student **Thomas R. Cech, Ph.D. '75**, (Nobel Prize in Chemistry, 1989) were important role models and mentors to me. Later, as a

mid-career surgeon, I got an MBA. The Jacobs School of Medicine asked me to champion the M.D.-MBA dual degree program as its liaison with the School of Management. During that time, we graduated dozens of M.D.-MBAs and started the accelerated MBA for residents and fellows. In medical school, there is an emphasis on scientific, clinical, ethical, and psycho-motor skill sets. But the curriculum is deficient in the essential business skills that surgeons need as opportunities for leadership come along."

Submit your own note at alumni.berkeley.edu/submit-a-class-note. Need a prompt? Tell us about your favorite place to study when you were at Cal.

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Spotlight

Pulitzers



As a reporter and now editor of the *Washington Post*'s rapid-response investigations unit, **Emma Brown, M.J. '09**, has garnered several major headlines since President Trump first took office in 2017. Last year, she was part of the team that won the Breaking News Reporting Pulitzer for coverage of the assassination attempt on then-candidate Trump in Pennsylvania. In 2021, she helped unveil what happened during the January 6 insurrection—work that won the *Post* another Pulitzer. And in 2018, she broke the story of sexual assault allegations against then-Supreme Court nominee Brett Kavanaugh. Colleagues praised Brown's empathy in researching that piece, which required gaining the confidence of informant Christine Blasey Ford. Earlier in her career, Brown was an education reporter, a U.S. Forest Service ranger, and a middle school math teacher in Alaska.

At 8:27 a.m. on August 27, 2025, shots rang out at the Annunciation Catholic Church and School in Minneapolis. By 10:15 a.m., the staff at the *Minnesota Star Tribune*, led by editor **Kathleen Hennessey, M.J. '04**, had confirmed the deaths of two children in the mass shooting, which also left 21 injured. Their subsequent body of work won this year's Pulitzer Prize for Breaking News. No stranger to on-the-ground reporting (or to Minnesota, where her family is from), Hennessey previously led a team of national Associated Press reporters who lived in the places they wrote about. A gifted political editor and reporter, she spent most of her career in Washington, D.C., where she covered the Obama administration and Trump's first term in the White House for outlets including the *New York Times*.

Susie Neilson, M.J. '19, a science writer turned investigative reporter and self-proclaimed "data person," became a Pulitzer finalist in 2025. This year, the *San Francisco Chronicle* staffer shared the prize in Explanatory Reporting for exposing how insurance companies leave California wildfire survivors without the means to rebuild their homes. Neilson combed through thousands of pages of records and found that the state's largest companies were knowingly using faulty algorithms to set inadequate coverage limits. Maggie Beidelman, M.J. '13, aided as a visuals editor. In her spare time, Neilson mentors Berkeley Journalism students in the Investigative Reporting Program. Being recognized by the Pulitzer Prize Board, she told the J-school, has left her with "the increased confidence that I can take big swings."

Contributing to the *Star Tribune*'s win this year was **Andy Mannix, M.J. '15**. Upon being hired by the paper in 2016, Mannix focused on "cops, courts, and prisons," later joining the paper's investigations team. In 2020, he coauthored a piece on how the death of George Floyd exposed a long-standing culture of misconduct in the Minneapolis Police Department. Mannix's story helped the *Star Tribune* win the 2021 Pulitzer for Breaking News Reporting and the prestigious George Polk Award in 2020. Earlier this year, Mannix made the move to *ProPublica*, where he remains committed to accountability journalism in the region. "The flurry of recent national news out of Minneapolis is just the latest indicator of how critical the Midwest is to understanding the changing story of America."

Across China, people deemed troublemakers can't leave their homes without their every move being watched. How does the government keep an eye on them? **Garance Burke, M.J. '04, MPP '05**, along with four others at the Associated Press, won the Pulitzer in International Reporting this year for revealing the surprising answer: China largely built its surveillance system on technology purchased from companies based in the U.S. What's more, they discovered, the U.S. Border Patrol monitors drivers with the very same technology and, relying on predictive policing, detains those with "suspicious" travel patterns. Video producer Serginho Roosblad, M.J. '18, contributed to the investigation. Burke, who in addition to the J-school also studied at Berkeley's Goldman School of Public Policy, received the GSPP alumni award for Exceptional Leadership in Policy and Journalism in 2018.

ProPublica national desk reporter **Brett Murphy, M.J. '16**, is no stranger to the Pulitzer, bestowed annually by Columbia University. In 2024, he shared the Public Service prize for revealing that some Supreme Court justices received lavish gifts, which led to the court adopting its first-ever code of conduct. He received his first Pulitzer nod in 2018, becoming a finalist for a *USA Today* series on the exploitation of port truckers—reporting he began at the Berkeley J-school. Mentored by faculty, Murphy uncovered numerous labor violations committed against the predominantly immigrant workforce, including pressuring employees to sign contracts without translation and locking gates to force them to work overtime. Murphy credited the bravery of his subjects, who he said "risked everything to tell us their story."

—H.J.V.

In Memoriam

50 Louise (Brooks) Rasmussen, May 5, in Oakland. Louise left her hometown of Red Bluff to attend Cal and never looked back. In 1949, when she was a Tri Delta living across the street from the International House, she joined the I-House chorus. While singing Christmas carols, she met the love of her life, John Rasmussen, Ph.D. '52. They were married in 1950 and welcomed twin girls the following year. They had two more children and spent most of their lives in Berkeley. After returning to Cal for her teaching credential, Louise taught sixth grade for two decades. She was predeceased by her daughter Jane '73, J.D. '76. She is survived by her husband, John; her children, Nancy '73, David '76, and Stephen; three grandchildren; and two great-grandchildren.

51 Peter F. Neumeyer, M.A. '55, Ph.D. '63, April 2, in Santa Rosa. Though Peter published scholarly works on subjects including Franz Kafka, Thomas Mann, and Shakespeare, his true passion was children's literature. At San Diego State University, he established one of the leading children's literature programs in the country and furthered the development of the field, for which he received the Children's Literature Association's Anne Deveraux Jordan Award. Peter published more than a dozen books for children and adults, including *The Annotated Charlotte's Web*. After retiring, he became a prolific reviewer of children's books. He was the loving husband of Helen for 74 years; the proud father of Zachary, Christopher, and Daniel; and the grandfather of Max, Joseph, Ravi, and Emily.

58 Merrill L. Bobele, May 8, in San Diego. Merrill is survived by his wife, Joanne; his sons, Michael Aaron and Jay Eden; and his four grandchildren.

62 Benjamin F. Blair, May 26, in Denver, CO. During his career in real estate development and brokerage, Ben served as president of both the Topeka Area and Kansas Associations of Realtors, and as regional vice president and treasurer of the National Association of Realtors. He received NAR's Distinguished Service Award in 1997. An ardent advocate for self-determination, Ben chose to conclude his 13-year journey with ALS under Colorado's Medical Aid in Dying law, writing, "I believe we live on in how we treated people and what we left behind." Ben is survived by his beloved wife of 36 years, Marice, and their dog, Professor; his sister, Barrie; and his daughters, Amy, Shelly, and Katherine. He also leaves behind seven granddogs and great-granddogs.



Mary Lovelace O'Neal, May 10, in Mérida, Mexico. In 1985, Mary became the first African American artist to get tenure in the Berkeley art department. In 1999, she was appointed chair of the department, and retired from teaching in 2006.

Mary was born in Jackson, Mississippi, in 1942 and studied at Howard University as a young woman, where she dated, and was influenced by, Black student leader Stokely Carmichael. She went on to earn her MFA at Columbia and became involved with the Black Arts Movement in New York City.

At Columbia, she began to develop her *Lampblack* series of monochromes, which involved applying layers of lampblack (soot from burned oil) on canvases until they were, in Mary's words, "as black as they could be."

Her work, often executed on wall-sized canvases, wasn't always Black enough, politically

speaking, for many of her fellow Black artists. But, as she told an interviewer in the *Times Style* magazine, "I didn't try to make work for Black people or brown people or white people or red people or yellow people or crazy people. I was there to deal with my stuff, to deal with me."

After *Lampblack*, she broke from minimalism, launching a series of vibrant abstract paintings she called *Whales Fucking*. The X-rated title was inspired by a whale sighting she made from the beach after moving to Oakland. She said it caused her to wonder how much water the giant mammals displaced during copulation. In the late 1980s, she embarked on a celebrated series titled *Panthers in my Father's Palace*, inspired by a visit to Morocco, and, late in life, another called *HECHO EN MÉXICO—a mano*, produced in her studio in the Yucatán.

She found joy in her work, once remarking that "painting with color was always a surprise. [It was] like dancing with the paint."

Mary's works have been widely exhibited and are housed in several permanent collections, including at the National Gallery of Art, the Smithsonian, SFMOMA, and the de Young Museum.

63 Robert Clough, M.S. '63, April 29, in San Ramon. During his 37-year career at Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory, Robert was a giant of the nuclear testing era. His contributions to the safety of this country are immeasurable. He is survived by his wife, Carolyn '63; three children; and two grandchildren.

Dennis G. Erickson, March 17, in Portland, OR. After serving in the Navy during the Korean War, Dennis used the G.I. Bill to enroll in the architecture program at Cal, where he was a member of Phi Kappa Tau. Upon graduating, he moved to Stockholm, Sweden, for a year to work for Kooperativ Forbundet on multifamily housing. Dennis spent the majority of his career at the San Francisco firm Wurster, Bernardi & Emmons. Valuing his Swedish heritage, he was an active member of several Bay Area Swedish organizations. Dennis is survived by his wife of 50 years, Barbara; his son, Carl; and his daughter-in-law, Anita.

Carol Guze (Konrad), Ph.D. '63, June 19, in Novato. Carol was a longtime professor of biology and an administrator at California State University, Dominguez Hills. She was also a clinical medical geneticist and a member of Phi Beta Kappa and Sigma Xi. She studied lichens, prac-

ticed and taught yoga, and supported civil and women's rights. Carol is survived by her children, Robin and Hans; five grandchildren; and one great-grandchild.

John McLaughlin, M.A. '63, July 28, in Silver Spring, MD. Born in Glasgow, Scotland, John immigrated to the United States in 1958. He earned an associate degree from Boston University and applied to Harvard, assuming it was somewhere in Ohio. He was astonished to learn it was just across the Charles River. During the Vietnam era, he was among those removed from their teaching positions for their political views, but later returned to academic life in the English department at East Stroudsburg University. For decades, he hosted and produced a weekly folk music program called *Roots and Wings*. John was predeceased by his brothers Stirling, David, Tommy, Andy, Robert, and George; his first wife, Lois; and his granddaughter Nika. He is survived by his wife, Jamie; his children, David, Caitlin, Alysoun, and Stirling; his grandchildren Lydia, Benjamin, Catherine, Alaric, and Teji; and his brother Bill.

Alice Wingwall, MFA '63, Feb. 13, at The Sea Ranch. Long after losing her physical sight to retinitis pigmentosa, Alice used her "mind's eye"

to develop images in her head. She called her decision to keep working “a radical choice, a political move.” Her work has been exhibited at the Berkeley Art Museum and Pacific Film Archive, the Exploratorium, and the Museum of Fine Arts, Boston. Alice loved all shades of red, orange, and pink and, in keeping with her spirit, frequently wore them together. She was predeceased by her sister Sally and was survived by her husband, Berkeley Professor Emeritus Donlyn Lyndon, now deceased. She is survived by her sister Betsy; her brother, Bill; her three children, Andrew, Audrey, and Laura; her five grandchildren, Nicholas, Isabel, Kenneth, Olive, and Ada; and her fourth guide dog, Buttercup.

64 Jill Brady Deal, Nov. 8, 2025, in Newport Beach. Jill’s husband, Timothy Deal ’62, served as a foreign service officer, which took Jill and her two sons, Christopher and Bart ’94, around Latin America and Europe. After tours in Tegucigalpa, Honduras, and Warsaw, Poland, her family returned to Washington, D.C., where Jill attended Catholic Law at night. When her family moved to the United Kingdom and France, she became one of the first spouses of a U.S. diplomat to practice law outside the embassy. Jill is survived by her husband of 61 years, Timothy; her oldest son, Chris; and four grandchildren.

65 John R. Gibson, Jan. 21, in San Diego. John was a fifth-generation Californian, a resident of Folsom, and a proud Cal Man.

66 Robert Brinkworth, Jan. 26. Robert was a member of the track team at Cal. He was also active in the Order of the Golden Bear, the Californians, and Theta Delta Chi. After graduating, he did one tour of duty in the intelligence unit of the Army in Quy Nhon, Vietnam. Robert was predeceased by his two brothers, George and William, and his ex-wife, Connie. He will be missed by his wife, Gail; three children, Jennifer, Chris, and Pamela; two stepchildren, Dan and Ashley; and ten grandchildren.

Robert Ross, M.S. ’69, April 14, in San Jose. After receiving his mechanical engineering degrees at Cal, Bob worked for 38 years at General Electric, where he was responsible for the recirculation systems for nuclear energy plants. Bob loved Cal, sharing his enthusiasm with friends and family through the school’s amazing rugby team. He is survived and eternally loved by his wife, Carrie; three daughters; six grandchildren; and three great-grandchildren.

Phil Winslow, May 19, in Walnut Creek. Phil’s friendliness was his calling card. He could start conversations with complete strangers and make it feel like they were longtime acquaintances. After earning an accounting degree at Cal, Phil worked for the IRS, then had a private accounting practice for over 50 years. A passionate supporter of the university and its athletic programs, he was rarely without his Cal hat. Phil is survived by his wife, Bev ’66; his

children, Jeffrey and Janna; and his grandchildren, Melania and Nieves.

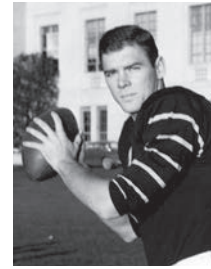
Tim T.Y. Wong, M.S. ’66, Feb. 10, in Sacramento. Tim was a research entomologist who used biological and chemical means to reduce agricultural crop damage from pests while minimizing exposure risks to humans and the environment. He was part of the team that eradicated the Mediterranean fruit fly infestation in California during the early 1980s. Tim also helped solve other pest infestation problems in Central America, Africa, and the Pacific Islands. He had over 100 peer-reviewed publications to his name and retired from the USDA after 26 years of service. Tim is survived by his wife, Effie; six children; and one grandchild.

67 Bob Wieder, M.A. ’75, April 12. Bob came early to the job of making people laugh and stayed at it late. In the ’60s, he was editor of the *California Pelican*, the Berkeley humor magazine. He was a lifelong freelance writer, which is sometimes a euphemism for being frequently unemployed. Not in Bob’s case. He was always working, including producing the annual “Celebrity Christmas Carols” parodies for *Playboy* in the ’70s, authoring *The Oakland A’s: The First Twenty-Five Years*, and maintaining a blog he called *Humor Me II*, the successor to *Humor Me*.

68 Peter S. Munoz, M.A. ’70, J.D. ’75, May 26, in Oakland. Peter was a Golden Bear through and through. He was a member of the University Library Board, served on the committee for the Class of ’68 Center for Civility and Democratic Engagement, and belonged to the Order of the Golden Bear. Peter attended every Big Game since 1962, and one of his proudest moments was carrying the Axe off the field as a member of Rally Comm at the 1967 game. Cal was one of the great passions of his life, and he found a way to bring it into nearly every conversation he had. He is survived by his wife of over 50 years, Jane ’68, J.D. ’71; three children, Peter B. ’02, Mary ’03, and Thomas ’03; and four grandchildren.

69 Ronald K. Tauber, Ph.D. ’69, Jan. 26, in Santa Rosa. While studying criminology at Berkeley, Ron volunteered at Suicide Prevention, later becoming its executive director. The organization is today the Crisis Support Services of Alameda County. Throughout Ron’s tenure, he worked to establish a suicide barrier on the Golden Gate Bridge, wondering if it would ever happen in his lifetime. In 2024, a safety net was completed, spanning all 1.7 miles of the bridge. Ron is survived by his wife, Frances; his two children; his stepdaughter; six grandchildren; and his sister.

Charlie Cunningham, June 2, in San Anselmo. After Charlie realized that cars were hurting the planet (during his one and only acid trip, on a mountain in Colorado), he devoted himself to a life without using them and began building bikes in 1977. The Berkeley engineering dropout inno-



Craig Morton ’64, May 9, in Mill Valley. Five former Cal quarterbacks have gone on to start in NFL Super Bowls—more than from any other college program. Craig was one of them. Unlike the others, however, he played in two championship games,

and for two different franchises.

He led the Dallas Cowboys to Super Bowl V (1971) and the Denver Broncos to Super Bowl XII (1978). Both games were losses for the 6’4” play-caller, but he would still earn a Super Bowl ring as a backup for the Cowboys in 1972.

All told, Craig played 18 seasons in the NFL, retiring from the Broncos in 1982.

At Cal, he played for head coaches Marv Levy and Ray Willsey and assistant Bill Walsh. In his 1962 debut as a sophomore against Penn State, he came off the bench to throw for 274 yards and three touchdowns. Despite stellar individual performances, however, he never played on a winning team at Berkeley. In 1964, his senior season, he led the nation in passing yards, but the Bears went 3–7 on the year. Nevertheless, Craig, who also played baseball at Cal, was selected as an All-American and picked fifth overall in the 1965 draft.

In 2013, unhappy with the terms of the NFL’s concussion settlement with former players, Craig filed his own suit against the league. He told *SFGATE* at the time, “I came to the conclusion that if I have to step forward and get them to trial to deal with these issues, I will.”

He is survived by his wife, Kym; his children, Michael and McKenna; and his grandchildren.

vated the “klunkers” of early mountain biking and cofounded one of the first mountain bike component companies, Wilderness Trail Bikes, in 1982. He later focused on making custom bikes, producing 188 in his career. It was while testing one he had made for his wife, the mountain biking champion Jacquie Phelan, that Charlie crashed, resulting in a brain bleed that impaired his vision and balance. He managed to return to the trails by riding tandem with his wife or friends. He is survived by his wife of 38 years, Jacquie.

71 Alan Gribben, Ph.D. ’74, May 9, in Montgomery, AL. As a graduate assistant at the Mark Twain Papers and Project at Bancroft Library, Alan became fascinated with the mystery surrounding the author’s literary influences. For his dissertation, he set off on a quest to track down Mark Twain’s library. Nearly 50 years later, in 2019 and 2022, he published in two volumes the nearly 6,000 written works that Twain had read and referenced throughout his life. That monumental project earned him accolades just years after he ignited controversy for replacing a racial

The Gate

slur with the word “slave” in a revised edition of *The Adventures of Tom Sawyer* and *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*. His aim, he said, wasn’t to sanitize literature, but to return the sometimes banned books to classrooms and libraries. In 2025, he and his wife and frequent collaborator, Irene Wong, followed up with an edition of *Tom Sawyer* and *Huckleberry Finn* that made the dialogue more comprehensible to modern readers. Alan is survived by his wife, Irene; his children, Walter and Valerie; his brother, John; and two grandsons, Elliot and Theodore.

79 John Bengtson, MBA ’81, Jan. 29, in Pleasant Hill. Known as the Sherlock Holmes of silent movies, John tracked down where countless scenes from the classics were filmed. He began his sleuthing in the late ’90s, without Google Maps or streaming. It took him four years to put together his first book of film-location finds, *Silent Echoes: Discovering Early Hollywood Through the Films of Buster Keaton*. In his day job, he did pro bono copyright work for California Lawyers for the Arts. But his film projects were his life’s work. For his final project, he did a year-by-year analysis of the filming locations used by Stan Laurel and Oliver Hardy. By then too weakened by ALS, he used an AI clone to narrate the final volume. John is survived by his daughters, Linden and Arden, and his older brother, Bruce.

82 Alicia Queen, June 22. Alicia was devoted to advocacy and justice. She spent many years providing court-appointed representation through the Superior Court of Alameda County, the Alameda County Bar Association, and the Judicial Council of California. She then served as an associate trial attorney at Farmers Insurance until her retirement in 2024. A long-standing member of Alcoholics Anonymous, Alicia marked over 30 years of sobriety. Her commitment to AA was not only a personal triumph but

also a testament to her desire to give back to the community. Alicia was predeceased by her brother, David. She is survived by her partner, Michael; her sisters, Laurie and Leslie; and her foster son, Eric, and his son, EJ.

86 Brandon Todd Yee, May 14, in Oakland. Most recently, Brandon was the CEO of Golden Link Concessionaire, LLC, the company that built and maintains the Presidio Parkway. In his career, he worked on the Richmond–San Rafael Bridge, the San Francisco–Oakland Bay Bridge Self-Anchored Span, and the Airport Rail Transit Guideway at San Francisco International Airport. Brandon is survived by his wife, Candy ’87; his sons, Jameson and Griffin; and his brother, Gordon ’83.

03 Ryan R. Waterman, J.D. ’03, MCP ’03, Feb. 9, in San Diego. Ryan was committed to service. He spent much of his career in the natural resources department of Brownstein Hyatt Farber Schreck, where he took on CEQA issues; renewable energy projects; and land use, water quality, and hazardous substances matters. He ran a successful quarterly newsletter called *CEQA News You Can Use*. His legal practice meant a great deal to him, and he continued working full-time even through cancer treatment. Ryan was also a lifelong supporter of mentoring, particularly through Big Brothers Big Sisters. He first became a Big Brother to Daniel in 1996 and later to Paris, Garrett, and Marvin, creating lifelong relationships he treasured. Ryan is survived by his wife, Julia, M.J. ’00; their children, Ben, Luke, and Kate; his mother, Donna; and his sister, Darlene.

18 Marcus Alan Owens, Ph.D. ’18, Aug. 26, 2025. Marcus and his wife, Christina Antiporda, founded their own studio, CAMO, to implement placemaking projects for the government and local communities. Marcus later

worked for the U.S. Forest Service in Kamiah, Idaho, where he designed the landscape surrounding the Nez Perce–Clearwater National Forest supervisor’s building. He was also an assistant professor of landscape architecture at Washington State University. Marcus is survived by his wife, Christina; his daughters, Simona and Katharine; his parents, Vera and Marcus; his siblings, Emily and Christopher; and his parents-in-law, Lea and Celso.

26 Paloma Fabiana Guadalupe Foster, June 21. Paloma died in a car crash near San Quentin. After experiencing incarceration and emancipation from the foster care system on her 18th birthday, Paloma became a Regents’ and Chancellor’s Scholar at Cal. A political science major, she dreamed of earning both a J.D. and a master’s in public policy so she could improve the decisions affecting foster youth and formerly incarcerated people. She hoped to one day become a foster parent herself. Above all, she worked to build a life that made her two sons proud of their mother. Paloma is survived by her beloved sons, Micah and Cairo; her partner, Shiloh; and her best friends and chosen family, Marlo and Karen.

27 William Yi Lu, April 21. William was a valued member of the theater community on campus. He developed his interest in theater while taking Fundamentals of Acting II. Fellow students described him as “full of energy,” a “ball of light,” and a “one-in-a-million person.”

Harshita Nair, June 11. Harshita was a legal studies student and rising senior. As a Diversity, Equity, Inclusion and Justice intern in the ASUC Office of the President, she worked on serving the campus community. Harshita went by the nickname Khushi at home, which roughly translates to “joy” in English. She was the beloved daughter of Ashok and Vanita and a cherished sister and granddaughter.

FACULTY AND STAFF

Anne-Therese Ageson ’67, July 3, in Oakland. An expert in child welfare, Anne-Therese taught for 13 years in Berkeley’s School of Social Welfare as a lecturer, field consultant, and head of the Title IV-E Child Welfare Scholars Program. Her mantra (and bumper sticker) was that “children should be seen, heard, and believed.” She had previously spent more than 20 years as a social work supervisor for Contra Costa County. Upon her retirement from Berkeley, the California Assembly recognized her contributions to the state with a resolution. Anne-Therese was also active in politics, frequently working as an election manager for local campaigns and serving a stint as chair of the Richmond Planning Commission. She supported female candidates at all levels and held leadership positions in the National Women’s Political Caucus and the National Organization for Women. Anne-Therese partnered with John



Michael May, Ph.D. ’52, May 17, in San Francisco. When Michael reported for his first day at Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory in 1952, he learned what he would be working on: nuclear weapons. “My jaw dropped.”

From initially doing theoretical calculations for “the guts of the weapon,” he rose up the ranks, becoming the lab’s fifth director in 1965. During the tumultuous era, he promoted dialogue. When he spoke about nuclear weapons with faculty and students, he would matter-of-factly lay out the possible nuclear strategies, with their associated risks, benefits, and feasibility. The least bad choice, he concluded, was having a nuclear weapon deterrent—but not using it. “Predictably, I’d always backed that policy, the best of the pos-

sibilities.” When demonstrators accused Michael of war crimes, he took it in stride. “I thought it was understandable they would have that feeling.” But also: “I thought that most of them were ignorant of the real situation.”

In the 1970s and ’80s, as the lab’s first associate director at large, he increasingly lent his scientific expertise to discussions of arms control, including at the Strategic Arms Limitation Talks with the Soviet Union in Geneva. He argued that the U.S. could safely slash its arsenal of strategic nuclear weapons by half, a goal reached during George H. W. Bush’s administration.

“Nuclear deterrence policy,” Michael said, “is a product of decisions by people, repeatedly, over many years. So, if anything is moral, or immoral, or some of both, that is it.”

Michael was predeceased by his wife, Mary, and his sister, Bella. He is survived by his brother, François; his four children; and his longtime companion, Professor Emerita Gail Lapidus.

Hadreas '77 in 1973. After John graduated from Berkeley with a degree in classics with an emphasis in ancient Greek, he opened Aardvark Books in San Francisco and ran it for 40 years. Together, Anne-Therese and John were Golden Bears for 52 years. They watched and attended football games until John's passing on March 2, 2025. Anne-Therese remained a loyal fan, spending her last Christmas Eve watching the Cal game. She was predeceased by her sister Mary. The couple is survived by their daughter, Anne-Catherine '03; their son-in-law, Patrick '03, M.S. '06; John's brother, Peter '66, Ph.D. '75; and Anne-Therese's sister Ruth and her brother, Martin '76.

Ching-Shui Cheng, June 7. Ching-Shui was a renowned statistician and a leader in contemporary experimental design. He joined the Berkeley faculty in 1977. After taking early retirement, he returned to Taiwan, where he established a joint data science program between Academia Sinica and National Taiwan University to train future generations of statisticians and data scientists in his home country.

Richard James Felciano, Feb. 21, in San Francisco. Rico relished being something of a musical heretic. He pioneered the use of TV as a compositional medium; introduced electronic sounds to sacred music at St. John the Divine in New York; and devised scores informed by his love of modernist design, their text always set in Helvetica. In 1987, he founded the Center for New Music and Audio Technologies at Berkeley. Rico was predeceased by his brother, Joseph. He is survived by his wife, Rita; his sons, Ramon and Manoel; and his granddaughters, Astrid and Vera.

Judith Marie Frank, CERT '80, May 29, in Sacramento. As the assistant director of financial aid, Judith worked with donors to support Berkeley students. Prior to her tenure, she was the communications leader for Kaiser Permanente Northern California, where she founded and served as managing editor of the employee journal *Visions*, which enabled hundreds of nurses to publish their own experiences. She is survived by her husband, Brent '76.

Michael Freeling, July 20. From early work on anaerobic genes and transposons, Michael changed his focus to plant comparative genomics and understanding evolutionary trends. He was elected to the U.S. National Academy of Sciences in 1994 and won the McClintock Prize for Plant Genetics and Genome Studies in 2017.

Donlyn Lyndon, April 5, at The Sea Ranch. Donlyn was the last surviving member of the original design team of The Sea Ranch, the planned community rooted in ecological design on the Northern California coast. His firm, Moore, Lyndon, Turnbull and Whitaker, and fellow Berkeley professor Joseph Esherick were selected as architects of the first buildings, which used vertical

redwood cladding and slanted shed roofs to become part of the landscape. Donlyn continued adding homes to the community throughout his career and stewarded its growth as a member of the Sea Ranch Design Committee. Donlyn taught architecture and urban design at Berkeley from 1960 to 1964 and 1979 until his retirement in 2004. In 1997, he received the AIA/ACSA Topaz Medallion, the highest award in architectural education. He was predeceased by his wife, artist Alice Wingwall, MFA '63.

Jasper Kim, July 9. Jasper lectured at Berkeley Law on negotiation, business law, and AI strategy. Prior to entering academia, he worked as a banker and lawyer with global investment firms including Lehman Brothers, Barclays Capital, and Credit Suisse.

Scott Logan, June 17, in Pleasant Hill. A lifelong East Bay resident, Scott was deeply connected to the community he called home. Scott managed facilities projects for schools, serving Cal, San Ramon Valley Unified, and Saint Mary's College in his career. Scott is survived by his son, Christopher; daughter, Danielle; sister, Colleen; and brother, Gregg.

James Midgley, June 21. After growing up in South Africa during apartheid, James started his career doing frontline social work. He helped establish a program in social policy and planning for developing countries at the London School of Economics and later became the dean of the School of Social Welfare at Berkeley. He spent his life insisting that a society is measured by how it treats its people with the least.

Elijah Lucien Polak, M.Eng. '59, D.Eng. '61, June 12. Elijah was a co-creator of the Polak-Ribière method, an algorithm that remains a fundamental tool in mathematical optimization and modern machine learning applications. During his six decades at Cal, he cemented Berkeley's reputation as a world leader in control systems and optimization.

Graham H. Powell, June 15. Dubbed "Mr. Non-linear" by his colleagues, Graham was a visionary in earthquake engineering, transforming how the profession understands the response of structures under seismic loads. Through his leadership in developing the DRAIN software at Berkeley, and his later collaboration on industry-standard tools like Perform3D, Graham bridged the gap between mathematical theory and practical, life-saving engineering applications.

Ruth Stimson, Aug. 24, in Berkeley. As a professor at the Berkeley School of Public Health, Ruth helped prepare generations of future health-care leaders through the school's hospital administration curriculum. She was committed to improving the quality of patient care and incorporated both objective and subjective measures into her classes. Ruth was predeceased by her husband, David, Ph.D. '65, and her brother, Bob.



Robert Cole, July 11. Robert had a clear goal for Cal Performances when he became its director in 1986: "I had the idea to make [Berkeley] more like a London, New York, or Paris, where the greatest artists come from all over the world," he told KQED.

Seeing few singers in recent programming, one of the first artists he thought of was Leontyne Price, the legendary soprano and prima donna. When Robert called to book her, her agent said he thought Cal Performances hadn't been interested. Robert set the record straight. "That's before *me*. Just cross that out. We are interested. I want Leontyne."

Cal Performances hosted her along with many others over the 23 years that Robert was at the helm: the Kronos Quartet, Renée Fleming, Yo-Yo Ma's Silkroad Ensemble, the Bolshoi Ballet, Mikhail Baryshnikov, Cecilia Bartoli. "We were witnessing the 'arrival' of Lincoln Center at Berkeley," a faculty member wrote.

The common thread, season after season, was Robert's educated taste. His father, who died in a car accident before he was born, had left behind a child-size violin. Robert traded that for the double bass, then the saxophone and clarinet. By his senior year in high school, he was a proper working musician, playing twelve shows a week at a high-end nightclub in San Jose. In his late 30s, he was studying conducting with Leonard Bernstein.

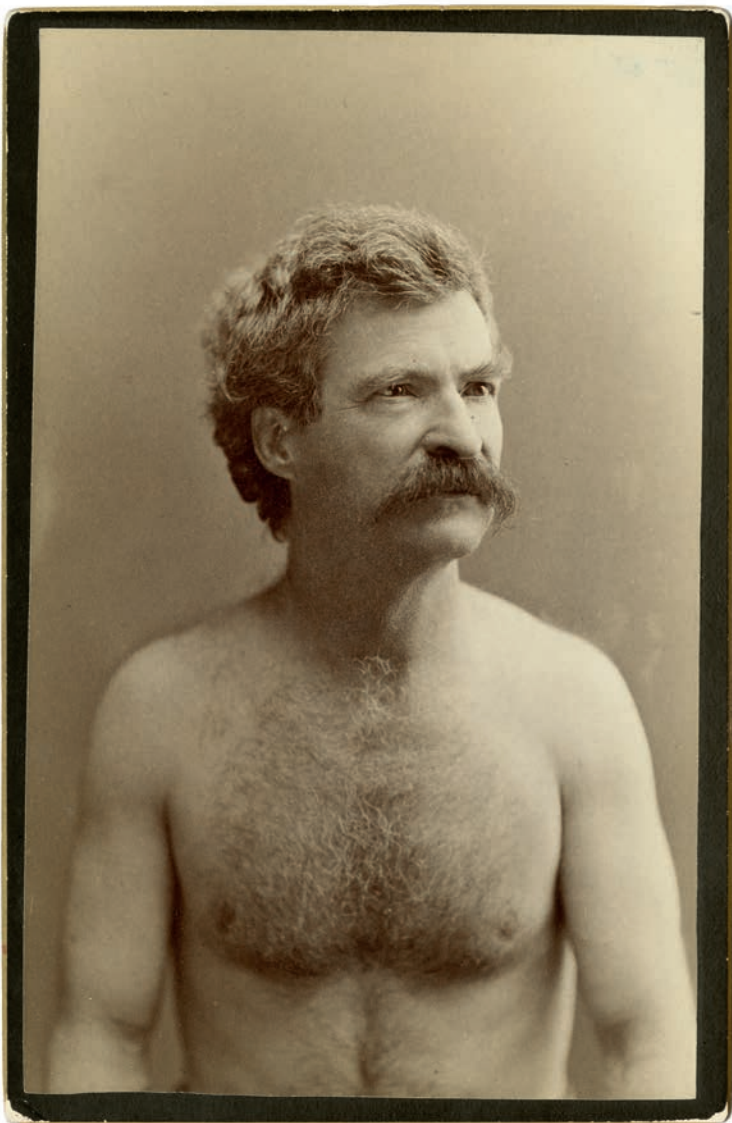
He was glad that a career in conducting never panned out. As he told the *San Francisco Chronicle* in 2007, when he announced that the curtain would soon be closing on his long reign in Berkeley, "Unless you're at the very top level of the field, you end up conducting this orchestra and that orchestra and it's kind of routine." But at Cal Performances, he said, he'd been able to work internationally, with art in all its forms. "I like to do different things."

Robert is survived by his wife, Susan; his sons, Alex and Thomas Montgomery; and his grandsons, Charles and Daniel.

For In Memoriam guidelines, please visit alumni.berkeley.edu/submission-guidelines/#memoriam. We prefer that you email submissions to obits@alumni.berkeley.edu with "Obituary: first name, last name, class year" in the subject line, but you can also mail a hard copy to In Memoriam, *California* magazine, CAA, 1 Alumni House, Berkeley, CA 94720-7520. Submissions may be edited for length and clarity.

Submissions deadline:
Winter 2026: October 1, 2026

Photograph of Samuel L. Clemens Shirtless



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his 1884 gelatin print—one of many oddities housed in the Mark Twain Papers and Project of the Bancroft Library—was likely made as a reference image for a sculptor who was working on a bust of the famous author. In the archivist’s clinically precise descrip-

tion, it depicts: “Clemens, Samuel, L. Front view of torso, three-quarter view of head. Naked.”

Naked, indeed. And surprisingly buff, even at age 48.

The bust itself was photographed and served as a frontispiece in *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, published the same year.

Twain was friendly with the young sculptor, Karl Gerhardt, and his wife, Harriet. On their first meeting, “Hattie” insisted on showing him a topless sculpture of herself that Karl had made. Twain later wrote to a friend, “it will be many a long day before I run across another woman who can do the like & show no trace of self-consciousness.” As for Karl, Twain considered him so talented that he sent the 28-year-old to Paris and paid for three years of his artistic training.

The once-obscure photo has become a source of some amusement online, usually paired with one of Twain’s aphorisms: “Clothes make the man. Naked people have little or no influence.” Fewer know the story of the author’s generosity—another topic Twain quipped about. “Never refuse to do a kindness unless the act would work great injury to yourself, and never refuse to take a drink—under any circumstances.”

—J.P.T.



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in the category of
your choice:

- Gas & EV Charging Stations
- Online Shopping & More
- Dining
- Travel
- Drug Stores & Pharmacies
- Home Improvement & Furnishings

2% **cash back**
at **grocery stores**
& **wholesale clubs**

1% **cash back**
unlimited on all
other purchases

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***Bonus Cash Rewards Offer.** You will qualify for \$200 bonus cash rewards if you use your new credit card account to make any combination of purchase transactions totaling at least \$1,000 (excluding any fees) that post to your account within 90 days of the account open date. Returns, credits, and adjustments to this card will be deducted from purchases, even if this card was not the original payment method. Cash Advances and Balance Transfers are not considered purchases and do not apply for purposes of this offer. Limit 1 bonus cash rewards offer per new account. This one-time promotion is limited to customers opening a new account in response to this offer and will not apply to requests to convert existing accounts. Your account must be open with active charging privileges in order to receive this offer. Other advertised promotional bonus cash rewards offers can vary from this promotion and may not be substituted. Once you qualify, you will receive your cash rewards within your next 1–2 billing cycles. The value of this reward may constitute taxable income to you. You may be issued an Internal Revenue Service Form 1099 (or other appropriate form) that reflects the value of such reward. Please consult your tax advisor, as neither we, nor our affiliates, provide tax advice.

¹ Customized Cash Rewards Additional Earn Choice Category Bonus Offer. Earn an additional 3% cash rewards bonus (equal to \$0.03 for every \$1) on Net Purchases in the Choice Category you have selected that are made with the card each billing cycle and post to your account within 365 days of the account open date. This offer is in addition to the 3% cash rewards you will earn in the Choice Category you have selected for a total of 6% cash rewards. This offer is subject to the \$2,500 quarterly limit for Bonus Categories in which eligible Net Purchases made in both the 2% and 3% Bonus Categories earn bonus cash rewards on the first \$2,500 of combined Net Purchases posted to the account each calendar quarter. Once the \$2,500 quarterly limit is reached, additional Net Purchases will not earn the additional 3% cash rewards earn offer until the first day of the next calendar quarter; instead, they will earn the standard 1% base cash rewards for that period. Cash Advances and Balance Transfers are not considered purchases and do not apply for purposes of this offer. Limit 1 bonus cash rewards offer per new account. This one-time promotion is limited to customers opening a new account in response to this offer and will not apply to requests to convert existing accounts. Your account must be open with active charging privileges in order to receive this offer. This offer will not apply to any customer bonus or account opening bonus, nor will you receive any Bank of America Preferred Rewards® bonus on the additional cash rewards earned from this offer. The value of this reward may constitute taxable income to you. You may be issued an Internal Revenue Service Form 1099 (or other appropriate form) that reflects the value of such reward. Please consult your tax advisor, as neither we, nor our affiliates, provide tax advice.

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